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Nightingale

Chapter 1

The screening process had been even more involved than Kurapika thought it would be. It started out as a simple form, then Kurapika was called for an interview which was practically a minor psych evaluation and now… *This.*

Kurapika sits in a creaky plastic chair with his hands curled in his lap and his back perfectly straight, staring at the white *"scent test"* barrier. It reminds Kurapika of a bank tellers station because of the counter top with a divot in the center that's just big enough for a hand to pass through. The only difference is that there isn't a clear window to the other side. Kurapika won't be able to see who sits across from him and neither will they. He'll have to rely on his other senses to pass judgment.

For the last few months Kurapika has been playing his cards carefully. His application to the program was a blend of selective truths and lies. His highborn education: a lie, his eclectic studies: the truth, his passion for collecting rare antiques: another lie, his ambitious and independent personality: the truth, and his reason for signing up for the program: the biggest lie of them all. Then he rehearsed his interview with Melody dozens of times to make sure it would be convincing.

Every move he's made has hopefully led to him being paired up with the correct alpha. The infamous Tserracnich.

Yorknew City has many prisons but finding out which held Tserracnich was easy enough. What was much harder was finding out that *he* was recently cleared as eligible for the omega therapy program.

The program is meant to address the mental-health crisis that has plagued alpha prisons for decades. Separating prisons by secondary gender is mostly to protect beta and omega convicts from alphas but the results of locking a bunch of alphas up together - including the guards - has created a uniquely hostile environment. For alpha convicts, even the non-violent offenders, healing is nearly impossible and rates of recidivism are staggering. It creates an ouroboros effect that only worsens alpha reputations across the board.

So the omega therapy program was created to pair approved alpha convicts up with omega volunteers as a way for the convicts to practice proper socialization and provide respite from the constant need to compete for dominance with everyone around them. Not to mention the convenient fact that giving hopeless alphas something to *lose* makes them easier to control. An alpha can be removed from the program for bad behavior so they'll have to be good if they want to keep their access to their *therapy omega.* It's still an experimental concept. However, thanks to an abundance of caution, the trials so far have been promising.

As a general concept, Kurapika would say he's in favor of restorative justice - another truth on his application. It's just that *some* people don't deserve the chance to grow or heal. *Some* people should just *die*. Kurapika didn't mention that on his application.

Kurapika's pulse jumps as he hears a door opening on the other side of the barrier. There's the sound of chains dragging across the shelf as the faceless convict sits down. Just on the other side of the wall is an alpha that they determined Kurapika would be compatible with based on his tailored application. It could be Tserracnich. It *should* be Tserracnich if Kurapika's built the correct profile based on everything he knows about the man.

Omega volunteers aren't given any specific details about the prisoners because having preconceived notions could damage potential relationships prematurely. Plus, the alphas in the program would struggle to imagine the good person they *could* be around their omega if the knowledge that all of their sins are on display is looming over them. It's hard for anyone to reinvent themselves with someone who knows their past. Kurapika understands that as well as anyone else.

But some people can't change - they don't deserve a *chance* to change.

The alpha prison guard standing to his left leans over to whisper to him.

"It's alright," she says, sensing his unease despite the scent-blocking patches he's wearing. "You can leave anytime."

Kurapika nods. He won't leave, even if the most disgusting alpha he can imagine is sitting right across from him.

On the prison side are more scraping and clicking noises as the alpha is cuffed to the table, preventing him from reaching more than a few centimeters beyond the hole. Supposedly, only alphas who are considered to be low-risk to omegas are approved for the program. However, Kurapika knows that the system isn't perfect because Tserracnich was approved. The system can't be perfect because *Kurapika* was approved.

He's pretty sure Melody is going to tease him *forever* about the answers they had to workshop for his psych evaluation.

"All clear," the alpha guard on the prison side calls to them. "You can take off your patch when you're ready."

Kurapika takes a slow, calming breath and peels off one of the scent-blocking patches on his wrist. There's trepidation in his scent, but that's to be expected given the circumstances. However, he isn't so afraid that his scent is drowned in sour fear. Kurapika's real pheromones are still palpable. His scent can't possibly be a lie.

He reaches into the opening, his palm up as a sign of invitation and his fingers relaxed. Much like a bank tellers window, the opening has a metal basin that's cold against Kurapika's knuckles. Easy to clean between visits, he expects.

The faceless alpha's fingers brush against his and Kurapika has to swallow the urge to jump out of his seat. Despite expecting to be touched, it's hard for him to stay calm when he can't see it coming.

The alpha's hands are steady and gentle as he drags the tip of a finger down Kurapika's middle finger to his palm, not touching his exposed scent gland just yet. The alpha's hands feel exploratory and curious, nothing like the selfish nature Kurapika was expecting Tserracnich to display. But if Tserracnich is also trying to play a long, slow game, then Kurapika can't expect him to be on his worst, most honest behavior.

One hand cradles the back of Kurapika’s, cushioning him against the metal basin. Against the back of Kurapika’s hand, the alpha’s palm is worn. Kurapika closes his eyes to map the calluses in his mind. The toughest areas of skin are consistent with someone whose spent a lot of time practicing with a weapon - perhaps a knife. There is also an odd callus on his thumb that Kurapika doesn't know what to make of… He didn't think Tserracnich was the type to get his hands dirty with fighting, but perhaps these calluses were formed from wielding instruments of torture which Kurapika isn't very familiar with.

Finally, the alpha presses his thumb to Kurapika’s sensitive gland. His fingers reflexively twitch at the touch and his eyes flicker behind his eyelids. The alpha massages his gland for a moment then the hand disappears. The alpha must be taking in the scent of Kurapika’s pheromones lingering on his thumb.

Then, the alpha's hand settles next to Kurapika’s in the basin. His palm is up, inviting Kurapika to investigate his pheromones in turn. Kurapika opens his eyes and looks down to see light skin which is a good sign. Tserracnich is pale. Just barely peeking through the opening is the alpha’s wrist where the metal cuff is digging into his skin just below his scent gland.

Much like the alpha did, Kurapika approaches him slowly. He slides his fingers down the man's palm and it looks just like he pictured. The alpha’s fingers are long, his nails are clean, and the blue veins on the inside of his wrist are surprisingly prominent… Kurapika runs his fingers along them until he touches the man's scent glad where he feels his pulse throb.

Once he has the alpha's pheromones on his fingers, Kurapika brings them up to his nose to take in the scent. He braces himself to conceal his disgust. He's *expecting* to be disgusted.

Kuapika is not disgusted. The alpha’s pheromones smell…

… Kurapika supposes that Tserracnich wouldn't have been as successful of a monster as he was if he was overtly repugnant. Being able to *pass* as charming was critical to Tserracnich's operation.

Kurapika's other hand is still resting on the table and the alpha reaches for it. He brushes their fingers together in a playful manner than makes Kurapika stiffen.

"Alright, time's up." The guard on Kurapika's side says.

Abruptly, the alpha's hands are pulled back over to his side of the barrier. Kurapika sticks the scent-blocking patch back onto his wrist.

Kurapika is escorted out of the room. The guard has him sit on a bench in the hall outside the psychologist's office and hands him a survey to fill out. Kurapika answers each question with neutrally-positive answers about the experience while deep in thought about his actual feelings. He doesn't have nearly enough information to be sure that alpha was his target. At the same time, he doesn't want to be too cagey and risk losing a potential opening. Secretly, he had hoped his instincts would be good enough to just *know* he was sitting across from a monster. But such a thing just isn't realistic. If it was that obvious, the list of Tserracnich's victims would have been far shorter. Those who were lured in were no less omega than Kurapika is.

From there, it's a two week waiting period while the psychologists and his potential inmate match sort things out. Kurapika's done all he can for now.

While walking to his shift at the bar, Kurapika gets a call from the Yorknew Prison Mental Health Department. His eye widen at the sight of the familiar number and he steps aside to huddle by a lamp-post away from the usual urban river of evening foot traffic to answer the call.

He schedules his first face-to-face meeting with his assigned convict alpha.

Exactly one week after the phone call, Kurapika is sitting in the designated visitation room. Waiting.

The room is small and windowless. There's a framed poster on the wall of a generic field of flowers. Kurapika is sitting on a cushioned, grey, pleather chair across from an identical chair that's arranged at a three-quarters angle towards his own. Between the chairs is a little round table with a few index cards of bland icebreaker questions. In the corner of the room is a fake potted plant and attached to the ceiling above it is a security camera.

It's early enough in the morning to be well before when he needs to go to work but that also means he's tired from being up all night. Although, if he had taken the night off of work, he doesn't think it would have helped. Kurapika knows his nervous energy would have kept him up so it's for the best that he was at least doing something productive with his time. He watches the clock that's hanging across from the poster until the door opens and a guard leads his assigned alpha in. Kurapika steals himself, determined to conceal any emotions as he slowly turns to see the alpha.

The alpha is mostly obscured by the guard's shoulders but the glimpse of dark hair Kurapika catches tells him everything he needs to know. This isn't Tserracnich.

A sickening wave of disappointment and relief washes over Kurapika, leaving him feeling cold as adrenaline drains from his veins. Getting paired up with the wrong alpha is a setback. Kurapika will have to rethink his strategy… But admittedly, he's glad to know that he didn't find *Tserracnich's* pheromones pleasant.

Once they're through the doorway, the guard steps aside so Kurapika can have a better look at this alpha. He's shorter than the guard and his size his further de-emphasized by his reserved posture. He has shaggy, black hair that frames a spade-tipped cross tattoo on his forehead. Beneath his bangs are wide, deep-set, black eyes that strike Kurapika as distinctly *focused.* The lower half of the alpha's face is partially obscured by the muzzle on him, which is a standard cautionary measure. Through the narrow bars of the muzzle, Kurapika can make our the alpha’s straight nose and pale lips.

There's something familiar about this alpha’s face but Kurapika's sure they've never met. While he was building his profile of Tserracnich, Kurapika poured over newspaper articles and internet posts, trying to capture every little detail. In his mind, he combs through all the research he did on Tserracnich, trying to match this man's face to one of Tserracnich's known accomplices. He imagines each mugshot one by one but none of them match this alpha. During his investigation, he also glossed over a lot of other recently convicted criminals by proxy, so perhaps this alpha was just in a report he skimmed.

The guard gestures for the alpha to have a seat in the empty chair and he does so. The guard looks between Kurapika and the alpha without making any move to remove the alpha's handcuffs. After a beat of silence where Kurapika and his new partner size each other up, the guard clears his throat. He speaks only to be Kurapika.

"Would you be more comfortable with me in the room? Or should I step out?" He asks.

"You can go," Kurapika says.

He's not happy, but it's isn't out of concern for his own safety.

The guard nods. "I'll be right outside."

Once the guard has left, the alpha sinks into his chair to lounge. The pleather creaks.

"You look like you have a lot on your mind." The alpha says.

His voice is low and smooth and his tone is casual, like he's chatting with someone in a café.

"Why don't we start with introductions? My name is Chrollo."

Kurapika folds his hands in his lap. He feels as though he's being intensely observed and it isn't because of the security camera. He wants to avert his gaze to hide from the feeling but refuses to appear so submissive. He forces himself to meet Chrollo’s eyes.

"My name is Kurapika. It's nice to meet you."

Kurapika is speaking politely but even to him it sounds entirely fake. It's hard to care about all of his rehearsals when he's sitting across from the wrong man.

"Kurapika," Chrollo echos. "I can't help but get the feeling you're disappointed."

Kurapika bites the inside of his cheek.

"I think I'm just still getting used to the new environment," Kurapika deflects.

It's a common stereotype that omegas struggle with feeling unsafe in new places so he could use that to his advantage.

Chrollo hums and rests his elbows on the arms of his chair. His hands are together, fingers steepled.

"… I see. That's similar to what the psychologist's office was saying about you."

That makes Kurapika’s brows twitch. He was intentionally trying to throw the psychologist off so whatever they said to Chrollo was probably bullshit. Still, Kurapika wants to know what it was. He didn't even know the psychologist was discussing his profile with his potential alpha match. Especially when Kurapika didn't hear a word about any of the inmates in the program.

Chrollo stares fixed on Kurapika’s face. It feels like his eyes are swallowing up Kurapika’s every fleeting expression.

"You can just ask me, you know." Chrollo continues as if he's reading Kurapika’s mind.

A hot flash of irritation spikes through Kurapika but he shoves it down. He reminds himself of his goal and thinks of Melody's soothing performance at the bar last night to calm down.

"… Do you know why they paired us together?" Kurapika asks.

Although he wants the gossip for what the psychologist said about him, that's not as important as knowing where he went wrong. Kurapika knows that he can request a new alpha at any time but it would be suspicious if he did that too soon. Or worse, too often if he gets paired up with the wrong person again.

Chrollo tilts his head as though he finds the question curious.

"I think there are a few reasons. For starters, I requested *you.*"

Hidden in his lap, Kurapika's hands ball into fists as he fights to mediate his temper again. This random alpha criminal didn't know he was *fucking Kurapika over.* Chrollo didn't know but now Kurapika blames him anyway.

"I didn't know we could request specific people." Kurapika says, voice tight.

Chrollo shrugs. "Not really. It isn't like I knew all the applicants but I did scent test with a few omegas and out of those options I liked you best."

There's a thick lump in Kurapika's throat that he swallows. He has so many questions. Why didn't he get to test multiple alphas? Why did Chrollo get to test multiple omegas? If he had the chance, could Kurapika have picked Tserracnich out of the lineup?

"Do you know why they let you test with multiple omegas?" Kurapika presses.

If Chrollo is bothered by being interrogated about the prison's mental health program instead of getting to do a little speed-dating, he doesn't show it.

"It's probably because of my *'even temperament'* and *'calm presence,'"* Chrollo says, obviously quoting whichever therapist or psychologist was working with him. "They consider me to be very low-risk to omegas, and I have to agree. I'm not interested in dominating omegas just for the sake of it."

Chrollo looks up and down Kurapika's body slowly.

"So they had me scent test with a few omegas who they thought were *'sensitive.'"*

It's a brutal shot right to Kurapika's ego. He knew he was a little tense but he didn't think he was portraying *sensitive.*

"I…" Kurapika finally breaks eye-contact to glance at the soulless flower print on the wall. "I appreciate the concern but I'm not sensitive."

Chrollo leans forward, resting his elbows on his knees to be closer to Kurapika.

"I can tell you're tense but you're not afraid of me," Chrollo lowers his voice even more so it will be difficult for the camera to pick up.

Suddenly Kurapika becomes very aware that Chrollo's not facing the camera, meaning not even the shape of what Chrollo says can be monitored.

"No, I still think you're disappointed about something, and you're awfully curious about the selection process… Looking for someone? A former lover?"

The suggestion is so disgusting that Kurapika's real, visceral reaction flashes across his face before he can control it.

"No," He whispers back.

"Not a lover, hm?"

Chrollo rubs his fingers together in thought. Kurapika recalls the calluses he felt on Chrollo's hand vividly.

"You also didn't hesitate to dismiss the guard. I don't get the sense that you're so afraid of alphas that you can't stand to be in a room with more than one. So perhaps… It was because he's a cop?" Chrollo proposes, a crooked smile flickering behind his muzzle. "Please stop me if I'm getting carried away but I'm starting to wonder what sort of sweet, darling little *therapy omega* I've got."

Kurapika is more careful not to react this time but he knows it's too late. Being closed off now is just as suspicious… But what does Chrollo really have? Only pure speculation. Kurapika isn't busted yet.

He shoots Chrollo a flat, unimpressed look.

"Are these fantasies of yours why you picked me in particular?" Kurapika challenges.

"No," Chrollo shakes his head and straightens up again. "I just liked your scent the most and I thought you had lovely hands."

"…"

It's so simple that Kurapika is tempted to call it a lie after all the speculation Chrollo just did. Then again, why lie about something so simple? Feeling a headache coming on, Kurapika lets his head drop to the side and rubs his temple with his index finger.

Now he's wondering why such a relaxed, though strange, alpha signed up for a therapy companion at all. But Kurapika can't ask because it would be only natural for Chrollo to ask the same of him. At this point, he doubts Chrollo would buy the answer Kurapika gave on the application form.

Swiftly changing topics, Chrollo reaches for the index cards on the table between them. He flips through a few but Kurapika can tell his interest in them isn't real. Not like his risky interest in Kurapika.

"Shall we try playing by the program's rules now?" Chrollo suggests.

He stops on one card and slips it from the pile, holding it out so Kurapika can see it.

"Here's an easy one. Coffee or tea?"

Kurapika stares at Chrollo from the corner of his eye. He doesn't answer immediately, wondering if Chrollo is somehow going to spin this into a verbal trap too. The silence hangs undisturbed. This alpha really is calm. So calm it's weird.

"Coffee."

As soon as the word has left his mouth he recalls the strong notes of coffee in this alpha's pheromones. His cheeks feel warm against his knuckles. He hadn't allowed himself to form an opinion on Chrollo's scent when there was still a chance he was smelling Tserracnich. Now that he knows he wasn't enjoying Tserracnich's pheromones, it's harder to dismiss the fact that they were genuinely compatible during the scent test.

Chrollo rolls the card between his fingers then lets it go, allowing it to flutter to the floor carelessly.

"I pick coffee too. Next question…"

Chapter 2

The evening after meeting Chrollo, Kurapika settles into the methodical task of wiping down tables while Melody performs her set on stage. Weeknights are lethargic, which Kurapika is grateful for. The patrons who come at midnight on a Wednesday are halfway into a stupor when they arrive.

Watching his hand move in circles over the scuffed table he's cleaning helps Kurapika think more clearly. He needs to slow down and consider his options carefully.

After his shift, Kurapika looks into Chrollo's past. Though he didn't get a last name, Chrollo's first name is unusual enough to yield results. According to public records, Chrollo's in his thirties and has a few charges related to robbing a bank using a dangerous weapon, although it appears no one was killed during the altercation. Even so, he was given a heavy sentence of twenty-five years…

Looking deeper into the case, Kurapika can't find any indication that the contents of the bank's vault were ever recovered, which means Chrollo either somehow spent it all, or he had accomplices who were never caught. Kurapika is willing to bet that has something to do with how aggressive Chrollo's sentencing was. There's always more going on than what a person is formally charged with. Still, Kurapika doesn't find the story to be particularly moving. If Chrollo’s primary vice is being a thief who refused to snitch that lines up with what he said about being low-risk. Compared to how evil Tserracnich is, Chrollo might as well be a saint.

Although Chrollo was too observant for comfort, he also seemed to be very forthcoming. If his relationship with the people running the therapy program is half as good as Chrollo acts like it is, Kurapika could get a lot of valuable information from him.

He doesn't cancel his reoccurring appointment to meet Chrollo. The mental-health facility is separate from the concrete block which houses the prisoners but it's still on the prison's campus. So, Kurapika has to pass through the front gate and security check-in like everyone else, but he has special badge that marks him as a therapy omega. He can tell the security staff view him differently from other visitors, even though they're not supposed to.

This time, Kurapika is carrying a travel mug of coffee from home to compliment the bags he's got under his eyes. He's not sure how lax they'll be about bringing in a drink from outside, but it's innocent enough that he shouldn't face much backlash if it's the wrong move.

The guard at the check-in desk opens Kurapika’s mug to run a wooden stirring stick through the dark liquid, making sure there's nothing hiding inside. The restrictions on what therapy omegas can have are lighter because there's a real effort being made to create a gentler environment for the program. Kurapika also suspects that lingering biases against an omega’s capacity for violence are covertly at play.

The coffee could have poison. If Kurapika was paired with was the *correct* alpha it would have been poison. Consequences be damned.

Kurapika takes his coffee back without comment and goes to wait in the therapy visitation room, nodding in recognition to his familiar escort. He sits in the same chair as last week, holding the mug in his lap with both hands. A few minutes later, the door is opened and Chrollo is allowed in. Like last time, Kurapika waves the guard away so they can be alone.

"I knew I smelled something good in the hall." Chrollo remarks as he takes a seat.

He gestures to the mug with his cuffed hands.

"Did you bring that to taunt me or gain my favor?"

Kurapika eyes the muzzle over Chrollo’s mouth, keeping it locked up. Though he doesn't particularly care to free this man, Kurapika doesn't think Chrollo is some rabid beast either. Kurapika sets the mug on the table between them and gives Chrollo a slightly awkward smile.

"We're friends now, aren't we?"

Surprise flashes through Chrollo’s eyes then he places his hands over the muzzle, hiding his clear amusement.

"That sort of act really doesn't suit you."

A muscle twitches under Kurapika’s eye and without thinking he snatches the mug back and drinks from it. He can feel the weight Chrollo's eyes on him as he swallows the hot, bitter drink.

"Xi-Yu University?" Chrollo remarks, observing the logo plainly visible on the side of the mug. "Did you study there?"

Kurapika lowers the mug, his face calm once more. Xi-Yu University is a prestigious school in upper Yorknew City that's known for its elite ties to the world of business and finance. Kurapika just got this mug to match the story he made up on his application. He studied the school with the intention of impressing that highborn beast Tserracnich during conversation.

"Yes," Kurapika lies without inflection.

He dangles the easy lie like a lure. As expected, Chrollo sees through it.

"Come on, you're not even trying anymore." Chrollo replies.

Kurapika shifts his chair to fully turn his body to Chrollo. He rests his elbows on the table, leaning over it towards the alpha. Chrollo's brow twitches but he doesn't change his posture to mirror Kurapika’s. In this position, Kurapika is aware his face is in full view of the camera above that ugly, fake plant.

"Are you educated, Chrollo?" Kurapika asks, letting the man's name roll off his tongue for the first time.

There's a gleam of interest in Chrollo’s hollow eyes. He sees the lure that Kurapika’s waving in front of his face.

"Not formally," Chrollo replies. It's likely the truth. "But I've read up on a few subjects. Mostly in the humanities."

Kurapika nods, taking that in as a possible subject to engage Chrollo with.

"That's good. Education is important for its own sake."

Chrollo's eyes close as he chuckles, lashes casting shadows on his cheeks from the harsh overhead lighting.

"That sounds like an earnest belief. Now I know there's no way you went to a business school. It probably wasn't even your major wherever you actually studied. What a strange thing to lie about." Chrollo says.

Chrollo is speaking softly again so only Kurapika’s lies have a chance of being recorded and Chrollo’s acknowledgement of the truth is hidden.

"Maybe you're just a pathological liar and came here for some easy validation. I wouldn't really mind that… But I'd love to have the privacy to speak with you more plainly."

Kurapika swallows. On top of knowing a lot about the therapy program, Chrollo is clever and savvy. He would make a great ally even though Kurapika can't risk telling him the whole truth.

"… One of the great things about Xi-Yu University was the networking opportunities."

"…"

Kurapika is speaking clearly so he believes that the surveillance will pick up on his "normal" half of the conversation and hopefully lead anyone listening into filling in the blanks of what Chrollo is saying to be equally mundane. But the non-sequitur is so obvious that Chrollo should be able to understand there's a hidden message in his words.

Networking… let us connect for real. I want to speak more plainly with you too.

Chrollo finally mirrors Kurapika's body language, leaning into the conversation. His cuffs clunk against the tabletop as he rests his hands on it.

"Even though, as an omega, some of the people there thought I was just trying to find someone to marry." Kurapika continues.

I want something I'm not supposed to want. I'm not here to act like a proper omega.

"… Is that right? Must be frustrating to not be taken seriously."

Chrollo engages with Kurapika's lie and responds at a normal speaking volume so Kurapika knows he must've gotten the gist of it.

Kurapika nods earnestly. As he thinks of what to say next, he licks his lips unconsciously, searching for the right words. He's sure there must be a way for alphas and omegas to have more privacy. But how?

"So, you aren't married?" Chrollo asks.

Kurapika pauses. What could the coded message in that be? In trying to figure out the clue, an awkward amount of silence passes between them.

"… No," Kurapika answers hastily.

It's the truth and it matches what's on his application. Maybe Chrollo is asking if Kurapika already has an accomplice. He does, but he would never say anything that could implicate Melody. Kurapika presses his lips together in thought then decides to continue with this line of dialogue. If he's interpreting Chrollo correctly, Chrollo might be asking if he's open to a partnership.

"… But, ah. I'm open to the possibility. For the right… alpha."

Kurapika's cheeks grow warmer with each embarrassing word that leaves his mouth. He bites down the urge to cringe at himself. It's a miracle that Chrollo doesn't laugh in his face.

"… Right. Whoever you take an interest in would be very lucky." Chrollo's response is playful but measured.

There's amusement twinkling in his eyes like light catching on something at the bottom of a well. Kurapika wonders if Chrollo is flashing a lure of his own.

Kurapika clears his throat and sips his coffee again. This time, he reaches for the index cards of ice breakers to flip through them. Maybe there's something in them he could use.

"What was the last book you read?" Kurapika reads from a card.

That should give Chrollo some flexibility in his answer. If Chrollo is as well-read as he claims, he could pick some title or genre that will give him a clue about what he wants in exchange for this partnership.

"The second volume of the Horror Angel series. "

"..."

The response is so instantaneous Kurapika doubts there's any secret message in it.

"Have you ever heard of it? It's about-"

Kurapika takes a deep breath. "Yes, I know it. I've read the latest volume."

Chrollo gives Kurapika a charming smile.

"Will you bring it for me? I've been requesting it through the prison's library for months without any luck."

There it is. Now Kurapika knows they can start trading. He gives Chrollo the same pretty smile that he gives to patrons at the bar. The smile that almost touches his eyes.

"Okay, I'll try."

It will be good to start testing the limits of what he can get past the front desk. Kurapika flips through a few more cards. *"Cats or dogs? How do you like your eggs?"* Wastes of time. Kurapika taps the cards against the table to even them out before setting the pile down.

"I think you'd be surprised what they'd let you do." Chrollo adds. "And you should try to talk to Eliza if she's available."

Kurapika nods. Eliza. She must be the one who runs her mouth to Chrollo just a bit too much.

After the session, Chrollo is escorted back to the cell block and Kurapika notifies the guard outside the visitor's room that he'd like to go to the on-site psychologist's office before leaving. The guard nods and gestures to the office that's just down the hall. It’s not even out of this guard's view so he doesn’t bother calling a separate escort for Kurapika.

By the hallway benches is the a guard for the to the office. He's stationed behind a desk with a pair of monitors. The guard is leaning back in his chair and flipping through a magazine that Kurapika can't see the cover for. Beyond the guard desk is a receptionist - a petite woman who Kurapika can barely see behind her computer.

Kurapika fixes his hair as he walks past the guard, his visitor's pass dangling over his navel on the end of a yellow lanyard that signals he's an omega. Only when he's right in front of the desk does the guard look up. The man looks at Kurapika's badge first and his face second. So inattentive… Kurapika wonders if this guard is always on the morning shift. He glances at the guard's name tag to take note of it. *Squala.*

Kurapika keeps his chin down and greets the guard politely as he continues walking to the receptionist. It seems that once he’s been cleared at the entrance to the prison, the guards inside won't bother frisking him between locations. Unless he gives them a reason to be suspicious, that is.

The receptionist looks up once Kurapika reaches her desk. The woman has long, dark hair with a bright yellow lanyard peeking through the strands, meaning she's also an omega, but her badge is clearly marked as member of the staff along with her name: *Eliza*.

Kurapika’s careful not to show his surprise. He was sure that the person Chrollo was getting his details from would be a doctor or therapist. Sensitive information must pass through this woman's hands.

Under his bangs, Kurapika allows his eyes to sweep across her desk, scanning the space. There are piles of folders filled with papers and a cup of pens with silly charms attached to the ends. Along with the paperwork, the desk is full of little trinkets. The sort of silly things found in gift-shops. Either Eliza has more time to travel than the average receptionist or she's popular among her co-workers.

Just like Squala, Eliza's eyes flicker from Kurapika's badge to his face.

"Good morning, Kurapika!" She greets him with a chipper smile after having read his name. "Are you here for your alpha appointment?"

Since this wasn't his first appointment with his alpha, there was no need for Kurapika to check in with the staff for the therapy program after clearing security. The fact that she's asked that question means there's a communication gap between security at the front and here.

"Oh, no, I just finished it." Kurapika says. "I was wondering if someone here was available to talk about it."

Eliza nods and starts moving her mouse, clicking around.

"Let me see who's available…"

Eliza eyes flicker in recognition as she reads something on her monitor.

"Oh! You're paired with Chrollo! How's that been? Um, if you don't mind telling me, that is." She asks, visibly eager in the way a friend would be but trying to tone it down for her job.

Behind Kurapika, he can hear the leather of the guard's chair creek.

"It's been going well," Kurapika replies, not making any attempt to lower his voice. "I'm not coming to complain about him, I just wanted to ask if I could bring him something."

Now that Eliza knows Kurapika isn't in emotional distress, she opens up right away.

"Ah, yes. Omega companions bring things in for their partners all the time. It's a real perk for the alphas." Eliza says. "But it does depend on the thing. It has to be cleared and all." She adds quickly.

"Right, that makes sense." Kurapika nods.

Eliza leans over her desk so Kurapika matches her. She lowers her voice and whispers to Kurapika poorly.

"Not that I have favorites or anything, but I think you got really lucky." She says with a twinkle in her eye.

Eliza is definitely the sort of person to try and make friends with anyone and anything. Kurapika doesn't understand that sort of thing, but he doesn't disparage her for it either.

"You really think so?" Kurapika whispers back.

Eliza nods.

"I think a lot of the inmates are good on the inside and all… But Chrollo just makes it easy, you know?"

Kurapika thinks of the mind games Chrollo has been trying to play with him. Being with Chrollo these last two appointments has been like someone running their hands over worn fabric, intentionally searching for and picking at loose threads. At the very least this means that Eliza isn't listening to their conversations, not that he would have expected a receptionist to be allowed to do that.

"Right…"

Kurapika can feel eyes on them. He looks back to see the guard Squala staring. Once he's been caught, Squala blushes and quickly turns away to pretend to be watching his monitors. From this angle, Kurapika can see that Squala has the security camera footage open. The monitors have at least a dozen feeds split between them. Kurapika doesn't have time to examine the feeds without drawing attention but within three seconds he can spot footage of the inside of the visitation room he and Chrollo were just in as welll as the hall outside the room where the other guard is posted.

Kurapika turns back to Eliza and sees there's a faint blush on her cheeks too.

"A-Anyway!" She clears her throat. "The only person who's free right now is a counselor, but if all you want to talk about is policy, he should be able to help. Is that okay?" Eliza says.

"That would be great, thanks." Kurapika replies.

Kurapika steps back into a little chair that's in the corner of the room. It seems like he and Chrollo aren't being heavily monitored in real time, especially not their words since Squala isn't listening with headphones. With the way he's sitting, Kurapika thinks Squala is only likely to notice big movements on those little feeds, such as a scuffle. The feed could be being transmitted to other computers and Kurapika thinks it's safe to assume the recordings are stored somewhere but… He and Chrollo should have a little breathing room.

After a few minutes, the counselor calls Kurapika into his office. The counselor is a tall man with long, white hair. He's wearing a butter yellow sweater and has a calm demeanor to match. He's either a beta or blocking his pheromones heavily.

The counselor gestures for Kurapika to have a seat in front of his desk. Unlike Eliza, this man keeps him desk clear. Aside from his computer, there's onto a box of tissues placed next to his name plate: *Kastro.*

"Hello, Kurapika, I don't believe we've had the pleasure of meeting."

Kastro introduces himself politely.

"Thank you for volunteering and welcome to the program. How have your appointments been going?" Kastro asks, taking a seat across from Kurapika.

"It was nice. I was nervous at first." Kurapika keeps his voice soft as he speaks.

If they already think he's *sensitive* then he might as well use it to his advantage.

"I think we're warming up to each other. We like the same book series."

Kastro gives Kurapika a mild but encouraging smile. "That's great."

"… But he hasn't read the latest one yet. Is it alright if I bring it in to lend it to him?" Kurapika asks.

"That should be alright. We want your appointments together to be as comfortable as possible… Of course, we still have to balance things like safety and the prison's existing policies. The security check-in will have to inspect any items you bring and they'll have the final say about what's allowed." Kastro says.

That confirms what Eliza said. Kurapika wonders if there's a way he could use the words in the book to create a cipher that Chrollo would understand but the guards wouldn't notice. That should be possible and he thinks that Chrollo would be smart enough for it. The question remains, how much information should he give to Chrollo? He doesn't know Chrollo's opinion on Tserracnich, if he knows of the man at all. He also doesn't have any leverage over Chrollo yet. Kurapika should share as little as possible.

Noticing Kurapika lost in thought, the counselor speaks up again.

"You know… It's very common for omegas in the program to become fond of their alphas."

Kurapika's thoughts on creating a cipher screech to a halt. A sickening chill rushes down Kurapika's spine knowing Tserracnich is one of the alphas lurking in the program.

"There's nothing wrong with… well," Kastro reconsiders his words before continuing.

"Your feelings about Chrollo are always valid." He says, like he's worried about making too many assumptions. "That's why my colleagues and I are here to speak to you both regularly. Everyone here just wants you to be safe and happy."

Kurapika keeps his face neutral, pretending not to notice what the counselor is implying. He doesn't care if bringing Chrollo gifts makes it look like he's being swept off his feet by that convict. But the way Kastro is talking almost makes it sound like he's… expecting it.

"I appreciate you looking out for me," Kurapika replies mildly.

After a bit more smalltalk, Kurapika takes his leave for the day.

Kurapika spends another night on his feet at the bar, turning over his options for what to do next. At the end of his long shift, he plucks the third copy of Horror Angel off his bookshelf and places it next to his keys, waiting to be delivered to Chrollo.

Chapter 3

A thin mat cushions Kurapika's shoulders as Izunavi's weight bares down on him. Heavily calloused hands pin Kurpapika's wrists above his head and the scent of stale cigarettes covers Izunavi's pheromones. The position is comfortable in it's familiarity.

Kurapika looks away from the older alpha to the crowd of omegas watching just a few steps away.

"You can use your hips like this." Izunavi explains.

Kurapika shifts his hips slowly, digging his heels into the mat. The omegas watch carefully as Izunavi's balance is disrupted, giving Kurapika the opportunity to break free.

"See how he gets leverage here," Izunavi lets go of Kurapika's wrists to reach back and tap his bare ankle.

Kurapika keeps his hands in place, waiting for Izunavi to grab them again so they can slowly demonstrate the move a few more times.

Then, they demonstrate the maneuver at a more realistic speed. To show the omegas how to really put up a fight, Kurapika puts everything he has into bucking Izunavi off and the old alpha falls heavily onto one shoulder as Kurapika scrambles to his feet. From there, Izunavi and Kurapika explain that the omegas have a lot more options to protect themselves.

"- but if you can manage it, running away to get to safety is always better than dragging out a fight." Izunavi reminds them.

With the demonstration over, the omega students split into teams to practice together.

A few times a month, Kurapika assists Izunavi in teaching these omega self-defense classes in their local community center. Kurapika's known the man for years. Long before his haphazardly pieced together life came apart at the seams. But in this room it's almost like nothing has changed about Kurapika as he roams the floor, watching and giving feedback to this crop of nervous but determined students

The class ends at eight, so Kurapika and Izunavi walk to the nearest corner store for a late dinner. They grab a few sandwiches then sit on the curb to eat together. They don't talk much but Izunavi asks how his new job at the bar is going and Kurapika asks Izunavi about his three other jobs that he works in addition to teaching self-defense.

Izunavi doesn't know that Kurapika is volunteering in the prison. As far as Izunavi knows, Kurapika is moving on and slowly recovering from the horrors that drove him to seek the prison out in the first place. Kurapika doesn't plan on telling him. It would only disappoint the man. Izunavi doesn't need to know that Kurapika *can't* move on from what happened.

Kurapika brings volume three of Horror Angel to the security desk for his next appointment. The guard at the desk flips through the slightly worn pages and his eyes don't even linger on the occasional coffee stains. He hands the book back to Kurapika and gestures to him to pass through the gate. Kurapika's usual escort is waiting for him, hands folded behind his back. He's a tall, broad alpha with a strong jaw and curly, light hair that's cropped onto the top of his head.

Kurapika walks down the hall, holding the book to his chest. The electricity of the overhead lights buzzes and Kurapika's soft, flat shoes are barely audible on the linoleum next to the heavy, steel-toed boots of his escort. As they pass the psychologist's office, Kurapika's eyes dart over to see Squala on the morning shift again, slumped over a disposable coffee cup. Halfway down the hall, a low voice above his head cuts through the dead air, nearly startling Kurapika.

"Babimyna."

Kurapika looks up at the guard who's face remains stiff.

"What?"

"My name is Babimyna," the guard says again. "I just thought I should introduce myself to you."

"… Babimyna." He says the guard's name slowly for the first time. "I'm Kurapika."

He introduces himself in turn to be polite. Though he's sure his escort knows his name already.

They reach the visitation room and stop just outside the door. Babimyna clears his throat a bit awkwardly.

"Still want me to stay outside?"

Kurapika nods.

"There haven't been any issues." Kurapika assures him.

He wonders if Babimyna is concerned since Kurapika went to the psychologist's office yesterday. But rather than questioning him, Babimyna just nods in agreement.

"Right. If you need anything, just shout."

Babimyna opens the door and holds it for Kurapika. Kurapika nods in acknowledgement and walks in, getting a hint of the alpha's pheromones as he passes the length of his outstretched arm. Babimyna's scent is clean and inoffensive.

Kurapika has a seat and Babimyna closes the door to give him a semblance of solitude while he waits for Chrollo. Kurapika holds the book in his lap, hidden just out of sight under the table. A few minutes pass and the door opens again to let Chrollo inside. As soon as Chrollo is sitting close enough to hear Kurapika speak in a low voice, Kurapika gets straight to the point.

"Squala's at the desk again, so no one is listening to us now." Kurapika whispers.

Chrollo’s brows raise. He leans over the table, eyes sharpening with tangible focus rather than the open, passive perception Kurapika usually gets from him.

"How do you know that?" Chrollo whispers back.

"We're just one feed of at least a dozen."

Chrollo stares at Kurapika, urging him to elaborate. He's incredibly still and despite his lack of expression, Kurapika can sense his growing intensity.

"I saw it on his screen." Kurapika explains.

Surprise makes Chrollo's brows twitch, undeniable judgment slipping through the cracks of his stony facade.

"You looked at his screen *in front of him?"*

"He didn't notice," Kurapika hisses. "I'm pretty sure he's more interested in Eliza than me."

Chrollo's intensity softens around the edges into something more like curiosity.

"Ah, that makes sense. I hadn't noticed… I'll have to remind her not to date cops." Chrollo says.

Kurapika lifts the book he's holding in his lap and places it on the table between them. Chrollo stares at it. Kurapika is sure he's surprising the alpha a lot today.

"I think we have a lot to offer each other." Kurapika says softly, pushing the book towards Chrollo.

Chrollo places his hand on the cover to accept it and Kurapika's hand shies away from his, remembering their first and only touch.

"… So you'll finally tell me what it is you want?" Chrollo asks.

Kurapika takes a steady breath, reminding himself of what to say before the words come out.

"I want information about how to navigate more effectively in the therapy program."

"Why?"

"Because you were right, I am looking for someone." Kurapika admits that much.

"Who and for what?"

Kurapika rests his hands on the table and laces his fingers together.

"I can't say."

Chrollo turns the book over in his hand.

"… Incomplete information from you will mean incomplete dedication from me." Chrollo hums.

Kurapika hesitates. "… That'll have to do for now. Will you just give me *some* information in exchange for whatever I'm allowed to bring you?"

It's a gamble. According to Eliza, omegas will often bring their alphas things for nothing other than the companionship itself. Not to mention the fact that Eliza made it clear that Chrollo is capable of *choosing* to be charming. If he were to ask for a different omega, he could probably get a lot out of them without the extra trouble Kurapika brings.

A few beats of silence pass as Chrollo considers his options. There no way for Kurapika to know what's going on inside Chrollo's head as he idly traces a finger along the spine of the book. Eventually, Chrollo breaks the silence with his decision.

"Alright, then here's some information for you that'll make us even for now: You aren't the only crazy omega in the program." Chrollo says.

Kurapika's brows raise as he's taken aback. Chrollo doesn't know Kurapika's reason for being here, so he thinks it's a bit much that Chrollo's already calling him crazy. He hasn't even broken any rules yet… except for a few, little lies.

Rather than challenge Chrollo's interpretation of both him and the other omega volunteers, Kurapika is more interested in understanding it.

"What do you mean?" Kurapika asks.

"Come on, just think about it," Chrollo leans in with a slight smile playing on the corners of his lips. "What sort of omega would volunteer for this? I mean, really? Omegas would only come here if they're writing a thesis or they're desperate for an alpha that they have almost total control over. Maybe some even want both."

Kurapika turns Chrollo's interpretation of the program over in his mind. It's true that if Kurapika didn't have ulterior motives, he wouldn't volunteer for something like this out of good will towards alpha

prisoners. When he thinks of working for a good cause, he thinks of the omega self-defense classes and his old career.

"Now you're a rare case that I haven't figured out yet." Chrollo continues. "But, my point is, *they* already think you're weird."

Chrollo's thumb twitches up, a barely-noticeable acknowledgement of their overseers.

"They're *expecting* you to ask for questionable exceptions. Do us both a favor and take advantage of it."

Kurapika raises a skeptical brow and lowers his chin, speaking even quieter and more rushed.

"I'm not going to ask them to do something as suspicious as assign me to the prisoner or my choice just because *you* think-"

Chrollo shakes his head no so Kurapika stops, giving him a chance to explain. He hold his hand out to Kurapika.

"Take off your scent patch and give me your wrist."

Kurapika stiffens and pulls his hands into his chest protectively.

"What?" Kurapika breathes.

Chrollo doesn't move a muscle. Not even a twitch. He doesn’t blink and continued to stare at Kurapika expectantly.

Being stared at like that sends a chill through Kurapika. He hesitates a moment longer, then steels his nerves. He pushes himself up from his seat and takes the two steps around the table to Chrollo's side. He's very aware that this much movement could have gotten Squala's attention but as long as nothing too dramatic happens, they won't be interrupted. By closing the gap between them, they can whisper more effectively and it'll give Kurapika an excuse to keep his head down and hide his face.

He stands over the alpha, a hand wrapped protectively over his wrist as he mentally prepares to expose a bit more of himself to Chrollo than he planned to. Sharing scents is allowed by the program so he's sure other pairs must do it on occasion…

Chrollo sits beneath him perfectly still. He's simply watching Kurapika, waiting for him. The act shouldn't feel as significant as it does. Kurapika knows he's already shared his scent with Chrollo, but doing it face-to-face makes it feel so much more personal.

Before signing up for this program, Kurapika had only ever shared his uninhibited scent with close friends and a few children in need of comfort. Still, he reminds himself that it doesn't have to mean anything. He slowly digs his nail under the adhesive of the patch.

He peels off his scent blocking patch and slowly lowers his arm, offering his hand to Chrollo. He holds his breath as he waits for Chrollo to take it, his heart pounding in his ears. Mercifully, Chrollo doesn't make him wait for long.

Chrollo raises his cuffed hands to cradle the back of Kurapika's hand just as gently as he did the first time they explored each other. With his hands cupped as though he's holding water, Chrollo curls his thumb over the curve of Kurapika's palm to caress the valley between his pinky and thumb. He traces Kurapika's prominent fate line and glances up to his face once more.

Kurapika can't make out what Chrollo sees in him before he bows his head to press his face to Kurapika's palm. The muzzle keeps a few centimeters between them, preventing Kurapika from feeling the true shape of Chrollo's face. The thin metal bars separating them are cold on Kurapika's skin but he doesn't pull away. Slowly, Kurapika relaxes as he comes to realize that like this, Chrollo also has an excuse to hide his face from the camera. It's strange but Kurapika can rationalize it.

Chrollo's breath flutters over his skin as he slowly moves his face to get as close to the scent gland at Kurapika's wrist as possible. A low, pleased sound rumbles in Chrollo's throat and Kurapika's heart skips a beat. The unsteady hold Kurapika has on his nerves shakes.

Chrollo's hands glide up to explore Kurapika's forearm and the light touch gives Kurapika goosebumps. While Chrollo's face is hidden in Kurapika's hands, Chrollo finally whispers what exception he wants Kurapika to take advantage of.

"Tell them we're courting," Chrollo's deep voice is barely audible.

Kurapika stiffens, shivering as the breathy words spill over his wrist. Instantly, the tentative calm he had is blown away, leaving him feeling cold and nauseous. Kurapika can barely conceal his shock at Chrollo's request. It's not that he *trusted* Chrollo, but during their last meetings it didn't seem like *this* was what he was after. Kurapika had mentally prepared himself for the possibility that he'd need to do something like *that* to get Tserracnich to let his guard down with him. He hadn't thought he's need to do *that* just to get information on the program without the guarantee he'd even be able to get close to Tserracnich.

Kurapika swallows. When he finds his voice it's brittle and dry.

"You want me to-?"

Chrollo shakes his head no, disguising the motion as rubbing his face on Kurapika's arm like an affectionate cat.

"No. Calm down. They'll give us more privacy if you tell them that. We're not the first pair to get cozy…"

Kurapika resists the urge to glance at the camera, his face burning. The notion that the program's safety measures would be more lax if they think the omegas want to get intimate with felons is *absurd.* It's so absurd that Kurapika would think Chrollo is lying if he hadn't had that strange conversation with the counselor.

Chrollo lifts his big eyes to Kurapika's face but keeps his chin down.

"But isn't it… too soon?" Kurapika murmurs.

"I said there were crazier omegas than you, right? The other inmates talk. Some like to brag."

Kurapika is skeptical about that. It seems like Chrollo is telling the truth, but those other inmates might not be. They could be a bunch of knot-heads who are just eager for a chance to brag about getting an omega now that it's a least possible for them to do so.

"Fine, tell them whatever you want. Just get us close enough to *network* and we can see where this goes. Maybe we can find a few more reasons to trust each other." Chrollo whispers.

The notion of trust turns in Kurapika's mind. He's come to see trust as a strange thing. Like a crystal, trust has a complex shape that looks different from every angle Kurapika views it from. It distorts the light of truth as it bounces through it's jagged structure. Much like a crystal, trust can also be worn down,

reshaped under pressure and heat, or shattered entirely. Still, trust remains valuable, and Kurapika can't help but crave it.

Although this alpha's intentions are mysterious, Kurapika can't help but feel there's something undeniably sincere about him. It's that sincerity that trips Kurapika up. Before he even realizes he's doing it, he asks a question that he shouldn't.

"… Why did you sign up?" Kurapika breathes.

He wishes Chrollo didn't hear him.

"You first."

Of course.

Kurapika presses his lips together tightly. They both know he won't say. Through the muzzle, Kurapika catches a flash of white teeth as Chrollo smiles. He lifts his face from Kurapika's hands and lets go of Kurapika's. Then, Chrollo holds his cuffed hands up to Kurapika in offering.

"Do you want a turn? I am not an unfair man."

Kurapika sighs, his shoulders slumping a little bit.

"No, but give it to me anyway if we're going to do this."

"Ouch."

Kurapika takes hold of Chrollo's hands and looks down at his palms. Using his thumb, he brushes one of Chrollo's cuffs out of the way so he can rub his scent gland. He refuses to lower his head to take in the alpha's scent, able to smell it just fine with what distance remains between them.

This time, he lets himself think about Chrollo's pleasant scent a little more. There are warm, roasted notes that remind him of coffee and something rich and earthy like leather. There's something more to it though. A faintly sweet and herbaceous note that Kurapika can't put a name to.

Before he can get too wrapped up in it, Kurapika moves his thumb down to rub Chrollo's fingers. He finds that callous he couldn't identify the cause of from their scent test.

"What's this from?" Kurapika asks.

Chrollo flexes his fingers under the touch.

"Lock picking. I used to be too heavy-handed when I was starting out but I promise that my touch is much more refined these days."

"So you're a thief," Kurapika ignores the innuendo and pretends he doesn't know about the bank robbery for now.

"I have a few charges but that's how I see myself."

Kurapika moves away from Chrollo's thumb to trace straight down his palm and all the way down his middle finger.

"Do you have any skills you take pride in?" Chrollo asks.

Kurapika stills his hand and closes his eyes. He takes a deep breath.

"… I just work in a shitty bar," he mumbles.

"That's not what I asked."

Kurapika knows he's keeping his eyes closed for too long. He needs to look at Chrollo and try to finally get a read on his enigmatic face. Instead, he trails his fingers back down to Chrollo's wrist and lets the weight of his palm rest in Chrollo's.

"I… I help teach omega self-defense classes on the side," He admits.

Kurapika still doesn't open his eyes to check Chrollo's reaction.

"That's noble of you," Chrollo replies and Kurapika can't read anything in his tone at all. "Have you ever had to take down an alpha before?"

Kurapika's been in a few confrontations in his life. Mostly, it's been little things when he was in community college and a few bad shifts at the bar. Usually, just a bit of force and a whole lot of confidence is all that's necessary to get a dumb alpha to back off. He's never had to hurt anyone badly before.

"… Not yet."

Chapter 4

Later that week, Kurapika's manager asks him to work a double-shift at the bar to cover for one of his co-workers. He pulls his hair back into a tie and rolls up his sleeves to keep up with the workload through the crowds and the heat. The whole time, he's thinking about Chrollo.

At first, Kurapika thought that Chrollo signing up with the program was odd since he doesn't appear to have any issues related to dominance. Then, Kurapika learned a bit more about the perks of the program beyond having a therapy companion which would be more than enough incentive for every alpha in the prison to try to get cleared and matched. Now, Chrollo's words from their last meeting add a new element. If Chrollo truly believes that the majority of omegas volunteering are crazy - that they just want subjects for think pieces or partners to keep under their thumb - would dealing with an omega like that be worth the perks?

Maybe. Maybe books and coffee and getting to talk to someone nice on the outside are good enough when you're sentenced to be locked up for over a decade. Kurapika could believe that.

Or maybe Chrollo is really looking for something more. Something he thinks he'll have a better chance at getting by leveraging an omega who has something to hide rather than omega who just wants to delude themselves into a love affair.

Kurapika doesn't make it home until the sun comes up. He collapses onto his futon for a few hours of sleep then wakes with a fresh determination. He decides to arrive for his next appointment early to do a little more investigating on his *partner.*

"You're early," Babimyna observes once Kurapika passes through security.

"Yes," Kurapika agrees blandly. "I'd like to wait in the office until it's time for my appointment."

Babimyna shrugs and stops outside the office to wait. He gives Squala a nod of acknowledgement while Kurapika gives him a wave and steps inside. He passes Squala's desk and goes straight to Eliza who perks up when she sees him.

"Good morning, Kurapika! How are you doing?" Eliza says.

"I'm doing well," Kurapika replies. He can feel Squala's attention on them.

Kurapika crosses his arms over his chest and hunches a bit to make himself appear smaller and more meek than he is. He lowers his voice to whisper to Eliza like they're friends.

"I was just curious about something… but I was worried about being rude by asking." Kurapika whispers.

Immediately interested, Eliza leans in to listen carefully. Kurapika continues.

"Do the others who visit Chrollo not bring him things?" Kurapika asks.

"Others?" Eliza looks confused. Good.

Kurapika pretends to look confused as well. He's intentionally creating a misunderstanding in hopes that Eliza will accidentally say more than she should when she explains.

"Each alpha only gets assigned one…"

"Oh, no, I know he only has one therapy omega." Kurapika continues, wringing his hands together awkwardly and pinching his brows to mimic concern for his partner. "I just meant… are only therapy omegas allowed to bring things for the prisoners? If Chrollo's been wanting something as simple as a book, wouldn't his family…"

Eliza's eyes brighten up once she realizes what Kurapika's 'misunderstanding' is.

"Ah, I thought you were asking about other therapy omegas!" She laughs a bit and Kurapika chuckles with her.

"No, no, other visitors will bring things like photos or letters once they're cleared, but Chrollo hasn't had any visitors as long as I've known him. Not until you. I can see why he'd be fond of you."

There it is. Happy with the information he's gotten, Kurapika quickly steers the conversation away from Eliza revealing some of Chrollo's private information towards a juicer topic. One that will hopefully keep Eliza from wondering if she's said too much.

Kurapika brings his hand up to curl it around his face shyly.

"You really think he's fond of me? We get along great but I don't know if it's just…"

Eliza slaps her hands on her desk, leaning over it with a big smile.

"Definitely! Listen, omega to omega, he's been talking to me about you too." Eliza gives him a wink. "But don't tell him I told you."

Kurapika smiles and nods. The omega code of honor is real. He didn't expect Eliza to give him even more information than he was fishing for so easily. Chrollo must be doing the same thing when he has to come here to talk to his therapist. There's no way for Kurapika to know what Eliza's told Chrollo, but he's been careful to keep his persona consistent around her.

"Ah, that's good. I just… I know I can be a little shy, so…"

Kurapika lowers his voice and ducks his head to touch his hair, mimicking the body language he uses in the room when he whispers things to Chrollo that he wants to hide from the camera.

"Don't worry about a thing. You are so cute," Eliza encourages him just like the girls at the bar do with their friends. "I can totally see you being his type."

Kurapika cups his hand over his mouth to whisper to Eliza even more softly. He knows Squala is still trying to eavesdrop.

"Omega to omega… I think that," Kurapika points towards the guard desk and then to Eliza. "… Y'know?"

Chrollo said that he'd tell Eliza not to date cops and Kurapika doesn't actually disagree. But it would be nice if Eliza and Squala were more preoccupied with each other than with what's going on in the therapy visitation rooms.

Eliza follows the motion of Kurapika's hand and her eyes flicker in recognition.

"… Really?" She whispers.

Kurapika nods.

"It's just a feeling I get."

While Eliza babbles about her interactions with Squala, flustered and looking for hints she may have missed, Kurapika reminds himself of the simple facts he has to use against Chrollo.

He's in jail for a big robbery and the stolen goods were never recovered. Chrollo most likely had accomplices that he didn't have a falling out with or he probably would have snitched for a lighter sentence. Thanks to Eliza, Kurapika now knows those accomplices are smart enough to stay away from Chrollo, which leaves him all alone. Then, Chrollo decided to get involved in the therapy program, which he knew would get him access to one random omega from the outside who Chrollo believed was likely to be emotionally compromised. Either Chrollo was really bored with serving his sentence legitimately, or he is looking for a way to contact his people.

If Kurapika's right, then he's willing to get his hands a little dirtier if it gets him a shot at Tserracnich. Working with some thieves is trivial on Kurapika's conscious compared to the weight of Tserracnich's continued existence.

Kurapika clears his throat and decides to take the leap, asking the most important question.

"Um, Eliza. I know it's for safety but I was wondering if… Chrollo and I could get a little more *privacy?* I really don't think Chrollo would do anything bad to me."

Eliza straightens up.

"O-Oh, okay! I mean, *I* can't give you permission for that but it does happen. Mated pairs have visitation completely unrelated to our program - not that you have to be mates - but I'm just *saying* that we know

how things are sometimes. Let me send an email. You'll have to do an application and a consultation for a private room."

Eliza's manicured nails fly across her keyboard as she types up a message.

"… But on the down-low, we don't really *watch*. Y'know. Unless it's a prisoner who's kinda a yellow alert already, but your partner is just Chrollo, so."

Eliza does a wiggly motion with her hand, showing that no one in the program is worried about him.

"I don't think you'll have any problems getting approved for next time."

It's time for his appointment so Kurapika stops gossiping with Eliza. He walks past Squala like he wasn't just using him to stir the pot in the office and returns to Babimyna in the hall, giving him his usual shy smile.

"Everything still okay?" Babimyna asks.

Kurapika nods. "Yeah, I just like chatting with Eliza. She's so sweet."

Babimyna shrugs, accepting that easily. Eliza's the popular type and one more omega wanting to be friends with her is normal. Kurapika is so good at being normal.

Babimyna and Kurapika continue down the hall to his usual room.

Once Kurapika's in the room, he grabs the icebreaker cards off the table and starts laying them out in a grid randomly. He won't reveal his hand to Chrollo until they're alone so for these appointments so Kurapika will make due as he has been.

When Chrollo enters the room, Kurapika's standing over the table, the array of cards clearly on display. Chrollo raises a brow as he approaches, stopping on the opposite side of the table.

"What's this?" He asks.

"I think we should play a game," Kurapika says. "So we can get closer."

Just one more game and then we'll be close enough.

Chrollo's eyes flicker over the cards, likely looking for a pattern.

"… Alright, what are the rules?"

Kurapika gives Chrollo a dry smile.

"I think you'll get it." *We've already been playing.* "We take turns picking cards to ask each other questions. If one of us doesn't want to answer, we can pass and set it aside. For each one you do answer, that's a point."

Info for info, just like before.

Chrollo hums in thought as he takes in the utterly useless questions on the table.

"And what are the points for?" Chrollo asks.

"I'll bring you something next time." Kurapika says.

"For how many points?"

"Any."

Chrollo and Kurapika stare at each other for a beat of silence. Kurapika implores Chrollo to get it with his eyes.

We're killing time until our next appointment and getting new things to say about each other.

Chrollo chuckles.

"Alright, if that's what you want. Mind if I go first?" He plucks a card off the table and passes it to Kurapika.

"What season would you be?"

Kurapika looks down at the card and sighs. The problem with this plan is that he has to answer these stupid questions too.

"I don't know… fall?"

Not that it's matters but Kurapika thinks that a burst of color right before everything shrivels up suits him fine.

"Really? I think you're more of a spring." Chrollo says.

Kurapika closes his eyes so he won't roll them at Chrollo on camera. He can think of half a dozen cheap reasons an alpha would compare a younger omega to spring.

What an asshole.

Not that it matters.

Kurapika sets the card aside and picks one for Chrollo.

"What celebrity or character was your childhood crush?" Kurapika asks.

"The Red Power Cleaner. Red's my favorite color."

Chrollo answers so seriously that Kurapika almost laughs. That is the sort of logic children use… But he's had a lot of practice at not laughing at the silly things kids say.

"I like red too," It's exactly how Kurapika would respond to a child.

Chrollo puts the card in his pile. One point was all Kurapika said he needed but hopefully they can keep putting on this show, even if everything Chrollo says from now on is a lie.

Chrollo picks another card.

"If you were a school teacher, what would you teach?" He reads.

Kurapika heart stops. He hadn't bothered to check the cards because he didn't think that any of them would affect him. He knows the question is innocent, but the words bring a flood of memories that slam into the shaky dam surrounding Kurapika's mind. He shuts his eyes and holds his breath like he's been

plunged underwater. Despite Kurapika telling himself that it's a normal question and he can just say anything, the words won't come out. It doesn't matter but it feels like it does.

"… Pass." Kurapika hates himself for being weak.

Chrollo’s brows raise in surprise.

"… Alright."

Kurapika opens his eyes but avoids Chrollo’s gaze. He puts the card in the pass pile and to his surprise Chrollo picks another card.

"Then how about this one for me. Do you like rainy days? Yes, I love the rain. How about you?"

Kurapika takes a steadying breath and nods.

"I like the rain too."

The next time Chrollo and Kurapika meet, it's raining.

Thanks to that icebreaker game, Kurapika had a lot of pointless things to say about Chrollo during his evaluation and he's sure Chrollo was able to do the same. Kurapika had to fill out a lot of paperwork with a witness, saying that he was of sound mind and understood the risks and all that.

Kurapika rushes out of his cab, holding the hood of his raincoat in place to avoid getting soaked on the way to the guard's check-in. He goes through the front gates and tries to contain his nervous energy. Kurapika isn't naive enough to believe they'll have real privacy but being able to get the heat off their backs until Kurapika can accomplish his goal will be enough. More than being alone with Chrollo, Kurapika is nervous about the item Chrollo asked for in exchange for playing that card game.

Babimyna escorts Kurapika to a different visitor's room a little further down the hall. Kurapika doesn't bother to fight down his blush. Anyone would be embarrassed if they were being so obviously brought to a separate space that announces their relationship status. But Babimyna remains professional and reminds Kurapika that he can call out if he needs anything.

Stepping into this room is like stepping into another timeline. Kurapika takes in the new space as removes his raincoat. It's nearly identical to the first room but just different enough to feel off. The little table and chairs are the same and the soulless print on the wall feels like a picture of the same flower field taken at a different angle. The main difference is the addition of a little, gray loveseat. Kurapika shudders at the sight of it.

Taking a cursory glance, Kurapika can't see any obvious surveillance. But camera feeds exist and don't whenever its convenient for the system. He'll just have to make sure not to raise any suspicion until the job is done.

Even though he hates the sight of it, Kurapika sits on the couch to wait.

Several minutes later, Chrollo is brought into the room. He's still cuffed and muzzled. During the consultation, Kurapika was told that they'd be kept on unless he requests access to a key. He's fine with handling Chrollo like an animal until it's more convenient to do otherwise.

"Imagine my surprised when I was called into a private room consultation." Chrollo says the moment the door is shut behind him.

"You weren't surprised," Kurapika counters. "And I gave you plenty to talk about."

Chrollo hums in agreement and approaches the loveseat. He sits with his cuffed hands resting in his lap and leans back into the cushions while Kurapika remains stiff and upright. Kurapika crosses his arms over his chest as the couch shifts under Chrollo's weight. His eyes flicker to Kurapika's crossed arms pointedly but Kurapika keeps them folded. Chrollo smells like the rain.

"You brought me my prize?"

Chrollo opens his hands expectantly.

Kurapika slowly unfurls his arms. He tugs his left sleeve up to reveal the bandana tied around his wrist. He pulls on one of the ends until the thin material unravels. He still can't believe Chrollo wants something like this. Kurapika holds it out pinched between between his thumb and forefinger like he's repulsed by it. He lets it go and it flutters down into Chrollo's open hands.

Chrollo closes his hands around the fabric and it disappears with a little sleight-of-hand.

"Much appreciated. Even some of the alphas who aren't approved to go into the private rooms with their omegas are getting tokens of *affection.*"

"I see…"

Reflexively, Kurapika covers his un-blocked wrist with his hand. Chrollo has a point, though. The more genuine they make their attraction seem, the less suspicion they'll draw. Slowly, he pulls his hand away from his wrist and folds his fingers together in his lap primly.

With that exchange out of the way, there's no reason to put off his next move. Kurapika takes a deep breath and braces himself for their next exchange. Without any preamble, Kurapika tips his hand just enough to reveal he's looked into Chrollo's background.

"You have accomplices on the outside from that heist, right?" Kurapika whispers.

The words feel too big to fit in the small space between them, but Kurapika drives them in like a wedge. Chrollo's face remains completely blank.

"No," He lies.

Kurapika is sure it's a lie, so he keeps pushing try and rattle Chrollo enough to crack his poker face.

"You must be loyal to them. That's why you haven't had any visitors in years, right?"

There's another stretch of silence that grows wider the more Kurapika drives his challenge between them. Chrollo slowly reaches across the gap from his lap to Kurapika's. From an outsider's perspective, the way Chrollo wraps his cuffed hands around Kurapika's to envelope them might look tender. Kurapika knows it's a warning but he won't back down. He keeps his hands still and counts his steady breaths.

"Tell me who they are and I can get in touch with them for you." Kurapika continues.

Chrollo's hands clamp down around Kurapika's tightly. His grip is strong enough to make Kurapika's fingers ache. He bites the inside of his cheek so he won't flinch when Chrollo applies pressure to his

thumb - knowing it would take only a bit more force to break it.

Kurapika meets Chrollo's dark eyes, refusing to show fear. Chrollo wouldn't threaten to destroy both of their chances like this unless it was something he really cared about. Kurapika is on the right track.

"… You give me a name first. Who are you after?" Chrollo replies, his voice lower and more dangerous than Kurapika's ever heard.

Kurapika swallows the chill that tone sends through him. This is it. The tipping point for both of them.

"….. Tserracnich."

The name falls out if his mouth and lands between them with a heavy thud. Whatever the name means to him, it makes Chrollo loosen his grip, but Kurapika is too tense to relax as the pressure eases off his fingers.

"Do you… know him?" Kurapika asks.

"… I'm familiar with his work."

Kurapika's jaw tightens, fearing the worst. There are many monsters who are *fans* of Tserracnich's.

"What's that supposed to mean?" He hisses through his teeth.

Chrollo pulls his hands back, surrendering their eye-contact by dropping his gaze first.

"Tserracnich's network sprawled far beyond him. He's got more victims than the ones he was sentenced for."

Kurapika's fury vanishes in and instant and his jaw relaxes. His carefully measured breaths break formation into real, pained gasps.

"… Yes…." He agrees. "So you… you know someone?"

Chrollo nods and looks over at the shitty print on the wall.

"Knew someone. I think. I can't prove it." Chrollo says softly.

The words hit the wound in Kurapika's heart that's raw and festering. Chrollo doesn't need to prove that to Kurapika. Moving with his emotions and not his reason, Kurapika places his hands on Chrollo's forearm and leans in closer to him, wanting to find a mirror for his own pain in Chrollo's hidden face.

"Who-?"

"Tserracnich got approval for the therapy program?"

Chrollo's words are harsh, cutting through the thick haze of Kurapika pain like an icy wind cutting through thick humidity. The coldness in Chrollo's voice shakes Kurapika out of his vulnerability and makes him focus on his real goal. He isn't actually here to do group-therapy with another person who Tserracnich has caused misery.

He pulls away from Chrollo and crosses his arms over his chest, curling into himself as he looks away from Chrollo to the blank wall on the opposite side of the room. This is the second time he's shown his weakness to Chrollo. He needs to *get it together.*

"From what I've been able to dig up, that seems to be the case." Kurapika replies, his voice having been dried out by the cruel reality stretching out ahead of them. "Unless he shows his true colors and does something to get kicked out, I…"

"He probably won't. Tserracnich's spent decades being careful as a free man and as a convict." Chrollo says.

Kurapika nods although he doesn't know if Chrollo is looking.

Chrollo is probably right about Tserracnich. All at once, he feels the leftover aching in his feet from his double-shift anew and his eyes feel heavy. He is so tired.

Kurapika's shoulders slump and he sinks deeper into the couch.

"Then I'm sure you can understand why I want to get him alone."

Chrollo chuckles. It's hollow and so far away that it echos in Kurapika's head.

"I do."

"Help me get to Tserracnich and I'll help you get in touch with your people. I don't care what you want to say to them. I suspect you wanted to charm some delusional omega into helping you anyway."

"You were right. We've got a deal."

Kurapika feels Chrollo's knuckles bump against his bicep. He looks over his shoulder to see the alpha offering his hand. Kurapika turns his shoulders towards Chrollo once more and firmly grasps his hand to shake on it.

Chapter 5

"Next time, bring me a copy of Paradise Lost. I'll be able to make a message my people will understand with that." Chrollo said.

"But you still won't give me any names?" Kurapika pressed one more time without fearing that Chrollo would threaten him again.

Chrollo shook his head. "You don't need any right now."

Despite being annoyed that Chrollo still hasn't given him any details, Kurapika did reveal that he's able to investigate people's pasts. Chrollo must think that Kurapika would use any details to find out more than Chrollo wants him to about his accomplices.

Chrollo is right, of course, and Kurapika can't find fault in the level of loyalty Chrollo has for his people. There's a saying that there's no honor among thieves, but it seems Chrollo would disagree with that idea. Kurapika just hopes Chrollo's people feel as strongly as he does so they can make this deal pay off.

Kurapika sighs through his nose, idly flipping through the fresh pages of his new copy of Paradise Lost. With how protective Chrollo got when Kurapika brought up his secret allies, he may as well have

screamed in Kurapika's face how important they are to him. That and having a strange code Chrollo is certain they'll get means there must be a lot of history between them.

Kurapika is sitting up in bed, skimming the text by the light of his bedside lamp. He doesn't expect he'll find anything useful in a naked copy of the book since Chrollo needs to get his hands on it first. Mostly Kurapika is just looking for a distraction. His whole body is aching from how tense he was for the few hours he managed to sleep - three or four maybe… Yorknew City sleeps even less than Kurapika. Flashes of light from passing cars move just beyond his plastic blinds, casting shadows that move through his room.

It's the nightmares keeping him up. Again. He doesn't have anything to take the edge off them except the distraction he's chosen for the night.

Kurapika doesn't think he's above the desire for taking things like a shot of whiskey or a small sedative for the pain of the past. It's the opposite. He's very, very certain he's exactly the sort of person who would struggle to stop after just *one* shot or just *one* pill. He thinks he'd get addicted to the absence of pain. So Kurapika stays away from all of it.

He's already broadly familiar with Paradise Lost on a thematic level. It's easy for him to imagine why a person who's been banished from society would be into something like this.

Kurapika yawns and traces the text with his fingers.

"What is dark within me, illumine."

Kurapika walks into the psychologist's office - cradling a coffee in one hand and the book in the other. It's a requirement in the program that Kurapika meets with a licensed therapist once a month - not just a counselor or the front desk. So, he's here again, just before his next appointment with Chrollo. Instead of hiding in the corner until he's dragged into his appointment like he wants to, Kurapika pushes himself to say good morning to Eliza with a small smile. Eliza leans over her desk to whisper to Kurapika, cupping her hand over her mouth.

"How was the *private room?"* She asks. "Anything exciting happen?"

"It was nice. We just, ah, got a bit closer on the couch and held hands. We're taking it slow." Kurapika whispers back, keeping his head low and demure.

He squeezes the book as he remembers how Chrollo took his hands and almost broke his thumb.

"Aw, so cute." Eliza fawns over him. "I just *knew* something happened. Chrollo was in for his therapy appointment a few days ago and he was barely saying a word to me. I knew he had to be hiding something!"

Kurapika bites the inside of his cheek.

"I guess he can be shy too," Kurapika says.

But he's pretty sure Chrollo was just thrown by their last meeting. Maybe he's still pissed that Kurapika decided to use his accomplices as additional leverage.

When it's time for his appointment, Kurapika goes into the therapist's office. Much like the visitation rooms, there are two cushioned chairs positioned across from each other. But in this room, there's a framed picture of a serene, misty mountain.

The therapist is already seated the chair on the far side of the room. The therapist is mature man with neat, black hair and glasses. He gestures for Kurapika to have a seat in the other chair. There's a mild attempt at making it appear more *cozy* with a light blue blanket folded over of the back of it. Kurapika sits, his posture straight enough so his back doesn't touch the blanket. He sits with one leg crossed over the other, the book in his lap.

"Good morning, Kurapika. My name is Kaiser," The man's voice is low and he speaks without inflection. "This meeting is just to check in with you. How have your appointments been going?"

"They're going well," Kurapika is tempted to leave it at that but if he's going to make Eliza and Squala think he's falling for his alpha convict, he might as well do the same here. "Chrollo asked me for another book. He mentioned doing a lot of self-study in the humanities."

Kurapika pats the cover of the book and Kaiser nods.

"Yes, he seems well-read." Kaiser replies neutrally.

Kurapika smiles a little and silence falls over them. The therapist is clearly waiting for Kurapika to fill it in without being leading. Kurapika crosses his ankles so he won't start tapping his foot under this man's watchful eyes. Kaiser looks at Kurapika without even a hint of judgment, but Kurapika doesn't trust it. In the end, this therapist is working with the Justice Department. Kurapika has to play this carefully.

"He, ah. Chrollo said he's most likely going to finish the last book I lent him soon. I'm looking forward to getting to talk to him about it." Kurapika says.

Kaiser nods again, not even glancing at the clipboard in his lap.

"That's good. I'm glad you have things you're looking forward to. Do you usually look forward to seeing Chrollo?"

"Yes. With my work schedule it can be difficult to get out, but I'm always glad when I come here." Kurapika replies without hesitation.

It's partially true. Kurapika's always found mustering the energy to seek people out more arduous than being around them naturally, so there shouldn't be anything suspicious about that.

"That's nice. You mentioned on your private room request form that you feel safe with Chrollo. Can you tell me more about that?"

Kurapika can see a few ways he's being invited to respond. Either he can focus on himself and how *he* is being made to feel safe, or he can talk about Chrollo and how he believes *Chrollo* to be a safe person.

So of course he chooses to talk about Chrollo.

"Chrollo is never aggressive -"

Except for last time.

"- and he always seems more interested in my thoughts than my status as an omega."

That much is true.

"And if he was able to get approval from the program for his good behavior while serving his time…"

Kurapika flatters the system, pretending to believe in their judgment as well as his own.

"Then I think he's safe. Plus, Babimyna always reassures me that he's close by in case I need him."

"Babimyna?"

Kurapika falters.

"… My… The guard who usually escorts me."

Surely it's not strange for him to know the man's name if he sees him regularly. But it's so difficult for Kurapika to get a read on what Kasiser thinks about anything he's said so far. It's like talking to a stock photo of a professional man rather than a person.

"Ah…" Kaiser nods and adjusts his glasses.

Don't read too much into it. It doesn't mean anything. Act natural.

"Yes, I understand. Those are all fine reasons." Kaiser says.

Another beat of silence passes and Kurapika swallows. The therapist's words remind him of something Melody said... About how often she notices him talking about how he rationalizes things rather than how he feels about them. Maybe it was a mistake to talk about his sense of safety this way. Maybe he should have hummed and hawed over his *instincts* and how *soothing* Chrollo's pheromones are to fit in better with his *sensitive* profile.

But Kurapika just can't get a read on him. He has no idea if Kaiser finds his behavior to be incongruous or if he cares at all.

Quickly, Kurapika decides that since there's no way for him to figure that out, he should move onto his next request. If he has to talk to this therapist, then he needs to try getting something out of him rather than waste time.

"I was thinking I'd like to to take the muzzle off Chrollo. Just to give him some coffee." Kurapika says.

It should follow the theme of safety for this session well enough.

"I think that's a nice idea." Kaiser says without inflection. Kurapika is starting to find it hard to believe this man thinks anything is *nice.*

"If you're still sure you want to take it off of him after this appointment, we can give you a key for next time. There's a vending machine in the hall by the guards' station if you want to bring him something to eat too." Kaiser finishes.

Kurapika leaves the office, letting his sigh of relief out slowly. He kept it short and only said good, reassuring things. He's a perfect, little therapy-omega. That therapist may have seemed like the most bland person on the planet, but he’s agreed to give Kurapika what he wants. Everything is going as smoothly as it could be.

Shaking off that unsettling meeting, Kurapira gives Babimyna a shy smile and they go down the hall to the private room. Babimyna lingers in the doorway while Kurapika sets the book and the coffee on the table. Kurapika pretends not to notice that Babimyna is taking longer than usual to shut the door.

When Chrollo arrives they barely exchange pleasantries before he grabs the book and opens Kurapika's coffee mug to get to work.

Kurapika sits across from Chrollo at the table, watching him with his arms crossed. Chrollo flips through the pages, searching for something in the text. When he finds whatever it is, he dips his index finger into the coffee to smear a few droplets into the paper, creating his message. As he watches Chrollo work, Kurapika finds himself slowly relaxing. Chrollo's focus makes the silence comfortable, unlike the silences that Kurapika shared with Kaiser

Whatever code Chrollo is crafting takes the majority of their time together but that suits Kurapika fine. He's sick of talking today already.

When he finishes marking the book, Chrollo blows the final drops of coffee dry before shutting it.

"What's got you worked up today?" Chrollo asks without looking at him.

Kurapika's crossed arms tighten.

"The therapist Kaiser."

"He is an odd one. I believe he's going for a non-directive therapy of sorts." Chrollo says.

"He's uncanny."

Chrollo shrugs.

"I think so too. But it doesn't really matter if we like him or he likes us. What matters is that we get what we need."

Kurapika takes a deep breath, his chest expanding within the cage of his arms.

"I know," Kurapika glances at the door, wondering if he's just being paranoid. "… and I think Babimyna's keeping an eye on me."

"Who?"

Kurapika doesn't bother to hide his expressions from Chrollo. His lip curls and he rolls his eyes - is he really the only person who thinks knowing his escort is important?

"The guard who's always with me."

Chrollo's brows raise, then he chuckles.

"I'm not really surprised that he's paying attention to you." Chrollo says, his tone dripping with amusement.

Kurapika scowls. He's half-convinced he's overreacting too but that doesn't mean he wants Chrollo to mock him.

"I meant more attention than usual. Today he stood in the doorway watching me when he usually-"

Chrollo lifts a hand to cut him off. "No, I got what you meant. I still meant what I said. I'm not surprised he's paying extra attention to you. He's an underpaid nobody and you're a beautiful omega who bothered to learn his name."

Kurapika's frown remains firmly in place even as heat slowly spreads across his face.

"He gave me his name," Kurapika argues.

"And you remembered it. I trusted your judgment on Eliza and Squala now you do the same."

Kurapika closes his eyes and takes a few more deep breathes. Alphas reading too much into basic kindness is nothing new to Kurapika so there really isn't anything wrong with Chrollo's assumption… It just feels frustrating coming from him.

Kurapika opens his eyes and holds out his hand for the marked book.

"Fine. Time's almost up, so where am I taking this?"

For one more night, Kurapika clutches Paradise Lost to help him push through his fear. He's white-knuckling the book in one and hand keeps the other hidden in his pocket, fingers threaded through the rings of brass knuckles.

All of his senses are alight as he walks down the alley behind he dark building Chrollo told him to go to. Yorknew City is never silent but this is as close as it gets. Only the distant sound of cards passing through the main roads and the scuffling of strays accompany Kurapika's light footsteps. He takes a strange, winding path through back roads that almost feels like a dream until he finally finds the building Chrollo told him to go to.

13th Street Printing Company.

The front of the building has a faded sign but it's the sort of place Kurapika would normally avoid. The type of building that children would say is haunted. The type of business that couldn't possibly be staying afloat by actually doing what the sign says.

He goes around to the emergency exit in the back and stops just outside the dented door. Under the flickering streetlamp he can just barely make out scratches on the doorframe that are just above his eye-level. It looks like an asterisk or some sort of radial burst with twelve points and a crude circle drawn through the center of the lines. Kurapika doesn't know what it means exactly, just that it's yet another code that Chrollo told him to look for. Kurapika glances up and down the alley, making sure no one is lurking nearby.

He takes a steadying breath and knocks on the door.

… Nothing.

Kurapika bites his lip, feeling frustration building. It's hardly a surprise no one is answering and he can't tell if anyone is inside.

If someone is inside, he must have their attention. He only has one more idea. If Chrollo's so sure about this book being the key, then Kurapika will use it. He opens it to the first page and begins to recite a few lines.

He doesn't even get to finish the first verse of the poem when the door opens. A tall, alpha man with a crooked nose and long hair in a sloppy a top knot is standing in the doorway.

"Who are you?" The man demands.

Kurapika stands tall, not showing fear even as his heart pounds. He holds the book out to the man.

"I'm here with a message from Chrollo," Kurapika says rather than giving his name.

The man raises a brow and looks out into the alley over the top of Kurapika's head. Then he snatches the book and fans it open. His eyes flicker over the stained pages as the lingering scent of Chrollo's pheromones waft from it.

"… Get in here."

Having left his better judgment with Melody, Kurapika follows the man inside.

The man shuts the door while Kurapika takes in the room. It's a small, floor-level office space with no windows. There's a door that likely leads to the storefront but that still doesn't leave Kurapika many choices for escape. He really has lost his mind.

There are two other people seated in the office. A small person with shaggy hair that covers most of their face is seated at the office desk. Leaning against the desk is a young woman with pink hair and sharp eyes. Kurapika can't discern a secondary gender from either of them since they don't seem as keen on displaying it like the alpha who answered the door.

The man reaches past Kurapika's shoulder to hand the book to the small person on the desk. The woman turns on the desk lamp then leans over to look at the pages with them.

"This is his work alright," The small person says in a quiet voice.

The woman nods in agreement then fixes Kurapika with a hard, skeptical stare. The light behind her casts cutting shadows across her face.

"How are you getting in contact with him?" She questions.

"Are you aware that the Yorknew Prison's participating in the Omega Therapy project?" Kurapika asks.

The woman nods.

"The *what?"* The alpha behind him balks.

Kurapika continues speaking, mostly to the woman in front of him.

"I'm one of the volunteers and Chrollo's assigned therapy omega. We made a deal."

The woman's eyes flicker up to exchange a look with the alpha behind Kurapika. The small person at the desk seems more interested by what Chrollo put in the book than Kurapika's story. They've turned away completely to pour over the message under the yellow lamplight.

"What kind of deal?" The woman asks.

"I'll be his messenger and he helps me get something from the prison."

"Something from the prison?" The man presses incredulously.

Kurapika's jaw tenses. He looks over his shoulder at the man blocking the door.

"That's as much of your concern as the contents of Chrollo's messages is mine."

In a flash, the alpha's face changes from skeptical to downright hostile. Kurapika's fist tightens in his pocket as his adrenaline spikes.

"Cool it," the woman snaps at the alpha. "Whatever it is, it's Chrollo's call."

The man's hackles lower slowly, like the pressure on a spring being released in a way that's controlled rather than letting it snap. Kurapika is relieved that these people want to help Chrollo and trust his judgment - Chrollo could have just been a fall-guy. As hair-raising as this situation is, it seems like his own trust in Chrollo wasn't misplaced either.

Suddenly, the person at the desk flings their arm up in the air. Pinched between their forefinger and thumb is a little, folded piece of paper.

"Our reply," They say.

Kurapika glances between the woman and man to gauge their reactions before taking a few steps forward to take the slip of paper.

"I'll take it to Chrollo when I see him in a week." He promises.

Kurapika doesn't believe in miracles, but he does believe that he was very lucky to be able to return to his apartment before morning.

Chapter 6

At the security check-in desk, Kurapika adjusts the sleeves of his cardigan, making a show of trying and failing to conceal the ends of a fresh strip of fabric tied around his wrist. The security guard glances at Kurapika's wrist but he doesn't say anything. In response to the man's prying eyes, Kurapika ducks his head in a poor attempt at hiding, hunching his shoulders like he wants to be even smaller.

Good. Let the guard think that Kurapika's secret is that he's bringing Chrollo another demure little handkerchief of his scent.

Inside the private room, Kurapika waits for Chrollo by the table. When Chrollo enters the room, he's also got something for Kurapika. His copy of *Horror Angel: Volume Three*. Chrollo sets the book on the table and since Kurapika is standing, Chrollo stays on his feet. He regards Kurapika with a questioning tilt of his head.

Without a word, Kurapika rolls up one of his sleeves to reveal the strip of fabric tied around his wrist. He tugs it free and the fabric unravels, falling to the table along with the slip of paper it was concealing. The actual secret. Immediately, Chrollo's eyes lock onto the note. He rounds the table to Kurapika's side and snatches the note off the table. Kurapika doesn't try to keep it from him, allowing the alpha to stride past him and so he can read it with his back turned and shoulders hunched - hiding it from prying eyes. It's pointless, of course. Kurapika looked at the note the second he was alone with it, but it's also written in some sort of code that he wasn't able to decipher. Still, one thing sticks in his mind. That strange, asterisk-type symbol he saw on the door-frame of that run-down building.

He watches Chrollo's back as he reads the short note several times. Most likely, Chrollo is memorizing it. After a few moments, Chrollo's shoulders rise and fall with a deep breath. He folds the small note up even smaller and passes it back to Kurapika.

"Get rid of this," he says.

Kurapika takes the note. Glancing back at the table, he notices Chrollo's swift hands had swiped up the strip of fabric he used to hide the note originally. He sighs but doesn't want to comment on that, preferring to not think of why Chrollo took it. He tucks the note into the waistband of his underwear since no one's strip-searching him.

Chrollo turns to face him. He looks Kurapika in the eyes and says:

"I really enjoyed the book. I'd love to hear what you thought of the reveal."

Normally, Kurapika would love to talk about the book series he's invested in. But the irrelevant statement following Chrollo essentially giving him an *order* strikes a nerve. Kurapika's jaw tightens as sudden anger ignites inside him and all of the anxiety he felt about tracking down Chrollo's people and getting trapped in a dark room with them acts as fuel. His face twists into a sneer.

Is this seriously all Chrollo has for him? Returning his paperback copy of a book?

Without breaking eye-contact, Kurapika shifts his foot in between Chrollo's. He hooks it around the inside of Chrollo's left ankle and at the same time shoves his shoulder - taking his leg out from under him and knocking him off-balance. A grunt is forced out of Chrollo as he drops backwards into the loveseat.

Before he can recover, Kurapika grabs him by the muzzle, his fingers slipping through the bars so they're centimeters from his lips. He holds on tight, letting the narrow bars of the cage dig into his skin, and yanks Chrollo's face up to take hold of his gaze with a burning glare.

"Don't forget that I don't work for you." Kurapika snaps. "What do you have for me?"

Chrollo's breath caresses Kurapika's fingers as he looks up, eyes wide without the faintest trace of hostility. Chrollo is so calm he's not even the type of alpha to get angry when he's challenged.

"I've got information," Chrollo offers right away. "Tserracnich's a high-profile prisoner so he's kept separate from most of us, but I know who Tserracnich's omega is."

Kurapika stays silent, waiting for Chrollo to continue without easing up even a millimeter.

"She's a young omega in her early twenties named Juno. Tserracnich likes her but I think he's getting bored with her fast."

Chrollo's mouth twitches just under Kurapika's fingers and his breath hitches in barely concealed amusement.

"She's blonde but I don't think it's natural so I think you've got a chance at taking her spot. You're as enticing as any blonde, baby-sitting cheerleader is to a murderous madman."

Kurapika huffs and rolls his eyes, finding that detail ridiculous. From his investigations on Tserracnich, the man didn't have a preferred hair color among his victims.

"I'll try and figure out what about Juno isn't satisfying Tserracnich and you can start dropping hints that you're growing bored with me for the same reasons. Maybe I don't know enough about wine-tasting for

you or something." Chrollo continues.

"Wine-tasting?" Kurapika replies doubtfully.

Chrollo shrugs. "Tserracnich is disgustingly rich and truthfully I don't have a very refined pallet. I'll let you know when I get something better to work with."

Kurapika holds Chrollo's serene gaze for a few more beats then eases back with reluctant acceptance. It's not nothing so Kurapika slips the key to the muzzle out of his sleeve.

"Good enough. Because I don't think you're a mindless animal, I'm going to unlock you so you can drink coffee like a human being for a few minutes."

Chrollo's eyes flicker from the lingering sneer on Kurapika's face to the key that's pinched between his forefinger and thumb.

Shoving Chrollo around a little has helped soothe Kurapika's nerves but he can't help the way his heart pounds. Since Kurapika believes that alphas can and *should* be held responsible for their behavior, he must also believe that alphas are capable of being more than mindless brutes. Chrollo isn't an exception to this. Though Kurapika's able to rationally tell himself that Chrollo wouldn't choose to attack him in this way, the possibility remains. If Kurapika's judgment is wrong, then his life could change very, very fast.

Kurapika pulls on the muzzle to make Chrollo bow his head, exposing the lock on the back of his neck. He's willing to accept the risk.

At least Chrollo isn't stupid or ugly.

The lock clicks open and Kurapika carefully eases the muzzle off his face, pausing only to run his fingers over the back of Chrollo's ears to ease the straps off them. Closer than ever, Kurapika can see that Chrollo has piercing holes in his ears. Between the piercings and the tattoo, Kurapika can't help wondering how Chrollo used to dress himself when he had the choice.

Chrollo doesn't make any sudden movements and slowly lifts his head. Chrollo doesn't lunge for him. He doesn't even look at Kurapika just yet. Instead, he's more preoccupied with rubbing the red indents left on the bridge of his nose and the backs of his ears left by the weight of the muzzle. Kurapika pushes down the urge to wince in sympathy. He hadn't considered that, but looking at the muzzle in his hands it was obviously designed without comfort in mind - just cost and durability.

He turns his back to the alpha and steps away to drop the muzzle and key on the table. He exchanges them for his travel mug which he passes to Chrollo. Chrollo accepts it and flicks the top open to breathe in the fragrant steam before taking a long sip of the drink. He hums deeply in satisfaction.

"This is good. You make it at home?" Chrollo asks.

Kurapika crosses his arms tightly and hums in affirmation, "French press."

"I'm sure it's not much of a compliment to say it's better than what I get in the mess hall, but this is a real treat. Thank you."

Kurapika sits on the loveseat next to Chrollo, keeping his arms crossed so his uncovered wrist is tucked in his armpit.

"I thought you said you didn't have a refined pallet," Kurapika says tightly.

"I don't. That's how bad it is."

Amusement plays at the corners of Kurapika's mouth and he quickly lifts his hands to comb through his hair, trying to hide his fond expression from Chrollo's watchful eyes.

"… Well, I don't know much about wine either. Bussing tables at the bar hasn't taught me a thing about it." Kurapika replies.

"Then I can tell you some wine-lingo to use and you tell me how you manage to keep the drunk alphas off you."

"A broom works pretty well." Kurapika deadpans.

Chrollo chuckles and Kurapika doesn't even realized he's uncrossed his arms to talk with his hands until he notices Chrollo tracking them with his eyes. Kurapika flushes as he becomes aware of his exposed wrist. Chrollo momentarily locks eyes with him.

"I bet. Dish rags are good for batting flies off too." Chrollo responds to Kurapika's words rather than comment about his body.

Kurapika drops his hands into his lap, warmth lingering on his cheeks, but he doesn't bother to cross his arms again.

The corners of Chrollo's eyes crinkle and he tilts the mug towards Kurapika.

"… I'm glad I can partake in communion with you." Chrollo says.

Kurapika eyes the mug. "… What do you mean?"

"I know you're well-read enough to know what I mean."

Kurapika won't try to deny that. In literature, every meal or drink shared with another is an act of communion. He slowly reaches out and wraps his fingers around the mug, fitting them between Chrollo's to take it from him. He brings the mug up to his lips and fits them over the damp imprint Chrollo left behind to take a drink of the coffee. It's still hot enough for Kurapika to feel the warmth rushing down his throat and spreading through his chest.

He lowers his chin and passes the mug back to Chrollo. Suddenly, Chrollo seems much closer despite Kurapika not feeling him move. Maybe it's just in his head. Chrollo places both of his hands on the mug, covering Kurapika's so they're holding it together. Kurapika freezes and stares at their hands, not sure what to make of the contact.

"I know you don't work for me," It almost sounds like an apology for earlier. "I've been thinking a lot about why you've come here."

Kurapika's pounding heart replaces the relaxed warmth that was settling in with a surge of adrenaline. Kurapika doesn't try to resist it. It's an important reminder. He shouldn't have gotten distracted in the first place. He doesn't respond but he listens with his whole body. All his senses are trained on Chrollo. Chrollo's voice is just as expressive as Kurapika's closed-off face.

"Even if he was arrested right after whatever it was he did to set you off, I know from experience that due process can take a very long time. Even for cases far more straightforward than Tserracnich's mess."

Chrollo fits his fingers in between Kurapika's pale knuckles.

"I'm sure being made to sit and wait must've been agony for someone as determined as you. And then, in the end, I have no doubt that he was only charged for a tiny fraction of his crimes and allowed to live."

Kurapika takes a shaky breath, remembering the cold stillness he felt during the months of gathering evidence and then the lengthy trail before a verdict was reached. He remembers the outrage he felt after he heard Tserracnich's sentencing. It shook him out of the the way he had hunkered down and shut himself off from feeling anything. It was then he was set ablaze with the heat of a new purpose.

"I think you're more of a spring."

Kurapika blinks himself out of the surge of memories brought on by Chrollo's words. His eyes are burning.

"You're mistaken about something,"

Kurapika replies, still unable to lift his gaze from their joined hands. He can feel Chrollo watching him, taking in more than Kurapika wants him to like always. It coaxes the truth of Kurapika's feelings out of the darkest parts of him. He had thought that only Tserracnich would see the ugliness inside Kurapika in his final moments. Now, one more person might get to see it.

"I don't want him to be executed by the government. I want to be the one to kill him," He whispers.

Kurapika's never said it out loud to anyone before. Melody knows that he's coming here to seek revenge, but saying it cleanly, laying out his ugly hatred - it's new. It's a heavy feeling he's never dumped out in the open. Kurapika isn't here because he wants justice as a victim, he wants revenge.

Chrollo lifts Kurapika's mug from their hands to set it on the floor by the arm of the couch. He keeps one hand on Kurapika's and brings it up to kiss his knuckles. The smoldering heat of Kurapika's hatred gets mixed up with the heat of Chrollo's lips touching his skin for the first time. Kurpakia's breath gets stuck in his throat and he shuts his eyes so he won't have to see the way Chrollo looks at him. With his lips still pressed to Kurapika, Chrollo speaks, matching the softness of Kurapika's confession with one of his own.

"I've killed. They just didn't get me for it."

Chrollo whispers.

Kurapika stiffens, shock replacing the severity of his vitriol.

"But I know you won't tell. My secrets are as safe as yours."

Kurapika's face tightens as he tries to block out the implicit truth in Chrollo's words. When he finds his voice, it's shaky.

"I haven't done anything illegal yet. If we betrayed each other, they couldn't arrest me." Kurapika whispers back, his lips barely moving.

"Sure, but I'll get them to look more closely into your fake background and they'd blacklist you just for the possibility that I'm telling the truth. You'd lose your only chance. I know that your revenge matters more to you than getting caught or you wouldn't be here at all."

Chrollo's lips move away from Kurapika's knuckles. He turns Kurapika's hand over and takes his time kissing each fingertip and then his palm.

"Consider my confession a show of trust between us."

Kurapika should be worried about details like who it was Chrollo killed. He should care how or why Chrollo did it. He should be worried about just how good Chrollo is at masking how dangerous he is. It's risky to stay close to Chrollo when Kurapika has no idea if he did it in self-defense, or as a cold calculation, or simply for pleasure. But Kurapika only has one thing he really wants to know.

"… What was it like?" He asks quietly, wrapping his free arm around himself for comfort. He opens his eyes to stare at the framed print over Chrollo's shoulder with the same feeling he gets looking out the bus window. "… Killing someone."

"I thought it would be harder than it was," Chrollo answers. "I've always heard that sort of thing changes a person forever and that it damages their soul. I expected to feel a torrent of agony, but that feeling never came."

Chrollo encircles Kurapika's naked wrist with his thieving, and apparently murderous, fingers.

"But I don't know how you'll feel when it's your turn. I don't think there's anything you can do to prepare yourself for it."

"I am prepared," Kurapika says too automatically for it to be genuine.

"Alright." Chrollo's reply is just as automatic. If Chrollo is bothered by Kurapika's response, he doesn't show it. He accepts Kurapika's answer at face value.

Kurapika's eyes drift from the field of flowers to take in the sight of Chrollo holding his hand to his face. Kurapika hasn't acknowledged the way Chrollo's been speaking to him since they met, brushing it off as double-speak or teasing. It's harder to ignore the way Chrollo is touching him. Kurapika has to accept that he should take Chrollo at face-value too.

"… I liked the reveal," Kurapika says, bringing them back to the book as a form of peace offering.

With half of his face tucked against Kurapika's wrist, Chrollo's small smile is obscured.

"I liked it too. It was a little cliche but - "

"- But it was set up well."

Chrollo nods, "Exactly."

Chrollo lowers their hands to let them rest in his lap. His hold on Kurapika is light enough that it would be easy for Kurapika to pull away if he wanted to.

Although Kurapika didn't mean to let this visit become a book-club meeting, it happens extremely fast. Getting to talk about something normal for once brings Kurapika out of his body into his imagination. It's a relief.

"You're in a good mood."

Melody's tone is as pleasant as her smile. She's sitting at the bar with a glass of water between her folded hands. Kurapika is on the other side of the bar, counting the money in the register so they can close up for the night. He isn't smiling.

"What?" Kurapika's rhythm doesn't fluctuate as he quickly thumbs bills onto the counter.

"You heard me," Melody doesn't let up. "Peace looks lovely on you."

Kurapika frowns, his body thoughtlessly trying to prove her wrong.

"Any peace I feel is only temporary until I've done what I need to do." He says.

"Mm, maybe, but if we don't appreciate the things in life that are temporary, then there wouldn't be anything to appreciate at all." Melody says.

Melody is too wise. It's both wonderful and frustrating. She sees through him just as easily as Chrollo does and Kurapika wonders what the alpha convict and the beta musician could possibly have in common to give them that skill.

"Fine," Kurapika concedes and moves onto the coins. "Any word from your contact?"

It was thanks to some mysterious connection Melody has that he was able to learn that Tserracnich was in the Omega Therapy Program in the first place. He's not *completely* reliant on Chrollo, despite what the alpha might think. However, because Melody is so wise, she hasn't revealed her contact to Kurapika just as he hasn't revealed Melody to Chrollo.

"Not much, but there are talks inside the program about alternative therapy methods planned for the next few months." Melody says.

"Such as?"

"Nothing ground-breaking. Just more gentle socialization and trying out healthy coping activities."

Kurapika scoffs.

"If you think only the innocent deserve a gentle rehabilitation experience, then you should give it an earnest try for yourself." Melody calls him out without hesitation.

Kurapika flattens out his scornful expression.

"No, I don't need that. And I don't think it would be helpful anyway."

Melody hums a few notes. They both know that Kurapika just said two completely different things.

"In any case, the plans for the program aren't set in stone, so I think you could put in some suggestions for socialization methods that you think would be helpful to you." Melody finishes, sipping her water.

"I got it, thanks Melody."

Chapter 7

For their next appointment, Kurapika makes Babimyna stop at the vending machine to get Chrollo another treat. With his coins in hand, Kurapika hesitates at the selection, not really sure what Chrollo would want. Three seconds pass and Kurapika is highly aware that Babimyna is waiting for him. He and Chrollo are supposed to be close enough for a *private* room so Kurapika should probably know what sorts of snacks Chrollo likes. Every time his heart beats, Kurapika imagines the weight of suspicion on him growing and he makes a hasty decision for one of the candy bars near the keypad. Chrollo said he didn't have a refined pallet and he's got no right to complain when Kurapika's spending his precious tip

money on him. The candy bar thunks to the bottom of the machine and Kurapika bends over to fish it out, his lanyard clunking against it.

"I like those too," Babimyna says mildly as Kurapika straightens back up. "I like the salty and sweet combination."

Kurapika glances up at Babimyna through his bangs, conscious of what Chrollo said about the guard likely being *interested* in him. He thumbs at the folded edge of the candy wrapper and steps towards the private room.

"… I don't have much of a sweet-tooth," Kurapika replies. "But sometimes a little bit is nice."

Since Kurapika took extra time at the vending machine, he arrives at the door at the same time as Chrollo for once. Chrollo looks from Kurapika to Babimyna, his polite, flat smile peeking through his muzzle. Babimyna reaches between them to get the door for Kurapika like always, not giving Chrollo much attention in a way that feels almost decisive. Kurapika steps past Babimyna first, walking through the faint waft of cologne that compliments his mild pheromones. The two alphas at his back don't exchange any words. Kurapika glances over his shoulder to see Chrollo following him inside, touching his elbow to the door to keep it open as Babimyna steps away to give them space.

As soon as the door shuts, Kurapika turns on his heel to show Chrollo the candy bar. His polite smile curls and he leans back against the door.

"Is that for me?" Chrollo asks.

"Maybe," Kurapika tears it open and takes a bite, breaking the dark chocolate shell and letting the salted caramel stretch through his teeth as he pulls away. "What've you got?"

Chrollo's eyes follow the stretch of the candy before it breaks off and Kurapika starts chewing.

"Tserracnich doesn't like how *'easy'* his omega partner is," Chrollo says.

Kurapika raises a brow and hands over the rest of the candy bar. Chrollo takes it and bows his head when Kurapika pulls out the key. He grabs the muzzle strap and yanks Chrollo's head down an extra few centimeters so he can fit the key into the lock. It clicks open and as soon as Kurapika pulls it away, Chrollo fits the damp, bitten end of the chocolate between his teeth.

Kurapika turns away from the sight to go deeper into the room, sitting at the table. Chrollo goes to sits on the couch instead, propping his feet up casually.

"Apparently, Juno is - and these are not my words - *'clearly a dumb slut'*." Chrollo says, taking another bite.

Kurapika turns his chair to face the couch. He sits with one leg crossed over the other and doesn't so much as blink at the needlessly vile language.

"Do you know why he thinks that?" Kurapika asks.

Chrollo hums and sucks caramel off his thumb.

"It's hard to get anything rational from a hateful man's words. Something to do with how often she smiles and laughs."

Kurapika sighs, slumping in his seat and dropping his head back, unable to stay poised for long when hearing something so blatantly ridiculous. But Chrollo has a point. If Tserracnich was a reasonable man,

he wouldn't have done any of the things he did.

"Of course. How dare she." Kurapika drawls sarcastically.

"At least it's more good news for you. Maybe you really would have gotten paired with him on your first try if I hadn't gotten in your way."

Kurapika lifts his head to glare at Chrollo. "I still haven't forgiven you for that."

Chrollo looks back at Kurapika serenely. "I'm not apologizing."

Chrollo tosses the candy bar wrapper in the small trashcan and leans back with his hands folded over his stomach.

"So, do you think they'd go for wife-swapping as a therapy activity?" Chrollo suggests.

With Chrollo's flat affect, Kurapika can't even tell if he's joking.

"No way. But… something about mitigating alpha possessiveness could be good. Like working on…"

"Resource guarding?"

Kurapika nods.

"Basically. Putting more than one couple in a room together and having everyone act civilized as a way to practice re-joining society." Kurapika continues.

Although he knows he's the one least likely to act civilized in that situation. He'll have to be strong.

"Like a double-date." Chrollo says.

Kurapika grimaces at the thought.

"An ice-cream social then." Chrollo tries again.

Kurapika stares incredulously.

"Why an ice-cream social?"

Chrollo shrugs. "I want to eat ice-cream. I'm sure I can get a few people on board with that."

It certainly sounds like an innocent suggestion. Something that's not likely to draw too much suspicion either. Plus, if Chrollo is right about it being appealing to other alphas, they might be able to get one of the other members in the program to make the suggestion.

"… Fine. We'll try that."

"Then all you have to do is seduce Tserracnich with your frowns and poor sense of humor, pretend to fall for his silver-spoon charm, then request him and finish the job."

Kurapika crosses his arms and gives Chrollo a flat look. "You just focus on pretending to care about the next therapy activity they have planned and I'll start talking about having concerns with reintegration into society. Then we work on getting them to agree to the social event."

"Now who's giving orders?"

"Do you want to eat ice-cream and kill Tserracnich or not?"

"Yes sir."

As he's glaring at Chrollo, the alpha reaches up the bottom of his orange shirt without warning. Kurapika's eyes go wide and he quickly looks away as Chrollo pushes it up with his cuffed hands, only to tear the white tank-top he was wearing as an undershirt from his body nearly effortlessly. Kurapika can't conceal his shock as the front half of the undershirt practically falls away from the back. Every other seam must have been ripped so it could be easily removed without having to contend with the handcuffs. Without a word of explanation, Chrollo holds the two pieces of fabric out to him.

"By the way, bring this message to my people."

Kurapika’s mouth is still slack as he slowly reaches out to accept the material. The inside of the fabric is heavily marked. Kurapika can't understand the symbols on it, but the way they're arranged makes him think of a map.

Kurapika swallows. He can't know for sure but… this is almost certainly a map of the prison. It would be insane if it was anything other than a map of the prison. His eyes flicker to Chrollo’s and the alpha looks back at him without a shred of uncertainty.

Slowly, Kurapika nods. He knew this was a possibility when he first made his deal with Chrollo and he won't back out now.

When Kurapika leaves that day, he can feel the broken pieces of Chrollo’s shirt shift against his body where it's hidden under his clothes. His heart is in his throat, hoping they won't slip out. He can feel the weight of Babimyna's eyes on him until he's left the building.

Kurapika meets with the counselor again and sits with his shoulders rounded, making himself small. He looks at Kastro with wide eyes.

"I don't want to get anyone in trouble." Kurapika says meekly.

"It's alright," Kastro assures him. His voice is low and soothing. "Your honest feelings are very important to us."

Kurapika presses his lips together in a thin line then takes a deep breath, relaxing his shoulders as though he's letting go of something.

"It's just… a few of the things Chrollo was telling me about the other alphas in the program make me a little nervous."

Kurapika winds the yellow strap of his badge around his finger, subtly drawing attention to his status as a vulnerable person while fidgeting.

"He said that once they leave the office, some of the alphas say crude things about their omega partners, using them to compete. Like we're objects rather than companions."

Kurapika’s eyes dart to Kastro's face to check his reaction and then looks away. Kastro isn't as unreadable as Kaiser, but he certainly doesn't seem to be taken back by this information. He simply nods along, encouraging Kurapika to continue.

"I know alphas outside the prison talk like that sometimes too so it's not all that strange. I'm just worried that the wrong lessons are being taught here."

"I understand completely," Kastro says and Kurapika bites back to urge to snap at him that he couldn't possibly. Whether Kastro is sympathizing or empathizing isn't the real issue right now. "Thank you for telling me, Kurapika. I agree that there's no need for anyone to get in trouble but we should address this. I'll speak with the other staff members and we'll try to include more of a focus on un-learning some of the harmful biases these alphas have."

Kurapika nods and smiles at Kastro. "Thank you. That makes me feel much better."

How he feels. His feelings. He's talking about feelings just like he's supposed to.

"Ice-cream social." Chrollo's voice is stuck in his head.

Kurapika is not going to say that. He'll be patient and wait for Chrollo to plant the idea in other people's minds first to see if that bears fruit.

Kurapika isn't as afraid of going into the thieves den a second time, but he still doesn't like it. Once again, he's gone to their hideout in the dead of night. He's dressed in a grey pull-over that hides his hair and has a canvas cross-body bag slung over one shoulder. His eyes linger on the strange symbol on the doorframe and reaches out to knocks. This time, he doesn't have to start speaking in code for someone to answer.

The door swings open and all of the fear comes rushing back with a vengeance that makes him nauseous. The person opening the door is a hulking alpha Kurapika doesn't recognize. This alpha is so large that Kurapika can't even see all of him through the doorframe.

"Woah. You *really* smell like the boss." The big alpha says bluntly.

That word bludgeons Kurapika, but he's careful not to let it show. Like water going down a drain pipe, his thoughts circle that one, casually spoken, word.

"boss."

"Don't just stand out there. Bring him in." The pink-haired woman calls out.

Kurapika might've been relieved to hear the familiar voice if he wasn't in total shock. He nearly jumps out of his skin when the new, big alpha's hand lands on his shoulder heavily and he pulls Kurapika into the office. The hair on the back of his neck stands on end and he stumbles forward. There's another new face. Along with the pink-haired woman and the quiet, little person from last time is a perfectly average man with blond hair and a polite smile.

Like last time, the door shuts behind him and the new alpha stands against it. Kurapika quickly gets his footing and stands as tall as he can while everyone in the room watches him expectantly.

Boss.

Kurapika mentally sets that detail aside for now. He opens his bag and pulls out the pieces of undershirt Chrollo gave him.

"This is what you're smelling," Kurapika explains, showing it to the group.

The blond man laughs and takes it, holding the pieces up in the dim light.

"I see. Tell him we understand." The man says cheerfully.

"We do?" The alpha behind Kurapika says. "That's great! I'm glad we're finally gettin' some motion."

The blond man nods and passes the cloth to the little person at the table.

"How's he doing?" The pink haired woman asks, having never taken her eyes off Kurapika.

"… He seems calm. Untouchable, I guess." Kurapika replies carefully. "I don't know what he was like before."

"That's Chrollo for ya. Sounds like nothin's changed." The alpha chuckles.

The woman hums thoughtfully but doesn't say anything else. Her gaze on Kurapika remains steady, studying him. Right now, Kurapika feels more seen by her than any of the counselors or therapists.

When Kurapika gets home that night, the symbol the thieves group have carved on the doorframe lingers behind Kurapika's eyes as he tries to make sense of it. A sun or a star… but maybe it's something else entirely. Some other radial pattern that's been simplified so it's easier to carve. Like a mandala or a spiderweb.

Kurapika considers whether or not he should confront Chrollo over being the boss of this band of thieves. Merely the notion of him being the boss of a highly organized group with *at least* five other members, maybe more, sets Kurapika on edge. But when Kurapika takes a deep breath and thinks it through beneath the sputter of hot water from his old shower, he can't think of any good that would come from talking to Chrollo about it. There's almost no way that the police knew Chrollo was the boss of this thief group when he was sentenced. Something like that would have been far more note-worthy during the reports. Whatever happened during that heist that led to Chrollo getting caught, the one thing Kurapika is certain of is that Chrollo kept his mouth shut through the investigation and the trial. If Chrollo thinks that Kurapika knows too much, that can only be bad for him. Especially when he's just given the group what's most likely a map of the prison and they're *"finally getting some motion."*

By the time Kurapika gets to the prison for his next appointment, he's clean, fresh-faced, and calm. He sits at the table in their private room and waits. He listens to the door open and shut as Chrollo arrives.

"He was giving me a pretty dirty look." Chrollo says.

Kurapika looks up and sees Chrollo gesture to the door with his shoulders, showing he's talking about Babimyna.

"Maybe it's because I was reeking of you when I left last time." Kurapika replies.

"Reeking?"

Kurapika doesn't acknowledge Chrollo's offended act.

"He probably thought you scent-marked me when I left with your shirt. Like you got competitive about me and him." Kurapika speculates.

Chrollo walks over to the couch and sits, his body angled towards Kurapika and his elbows resting on his thighs.

"You're probably right. Although I don't see him as competition."

Kurapika nods. Some alphas get possessive over omegas they spend a lot of time with even when there's nothing romantic or sexual between them. For all of Chrollo's faults, possessiveness doesn't seem to be one of them, thankfully.

"Your people noticed how strongly I smelled of you too when I brought them the message." Kurapika continues. "They said they understood it and one of the alphas mentioned something about being glad to get moving…"

Kurapika trails off, looking at Chrollo to see if he'll offer any more details. Meanwhile, Kurapika keeps the *"boss"* detail close to his chest.

"Good," Chrollo responds simply.

Of course.

"I think it would be reasonable if I was scent-marking you." Chrollo adds abruptly.

Kurapika's eyes sharpen. "… Why?"

"Because we're in a private room," Chrollo says like it's self-evident. "Do you really want them wondering why we wanted a private room if we were only going to talk? They could get curious about why we want to hide what we're talking about so badly."

Kurapika considers this. It's true that he never told anyone in the psychologist's office that they were courting or getting intimate, but the implication was always there. Chrollo has a point about it seeming strange if Kurapika only left this room wearing his scent one time.

Scent marking is intimate, usually for lovers or close friends and family, but it's not all that extreme. Especially considering the secrets they're keeping and the fact that Chrollo could have been demanding sex as payment from the beginning. Objectively, there aren't any downsides to scent-marking except a bit of embarrassment on Kurapika's end when he leaves.

It's worth it, so Kurapika nods.

"… You're right."

There's nothing more to consider so he gets up from the table and Chrollo's brows jump up to his hairline in surprise. Kurapika steps towards the alpha who straightens up and lifts his cuffed hands when the gap between them closes.

Kurapika is tense as he settles into Chrollo's lap. He slowly allows his weight to sink into Chrollo's thighs, staring blankly ahead. He swallows heavily then reaches up to peel the patch off his neck, displaying his mating gland for Chrollo. Even though Chrollo is still muzzled, Kurapika's heart races so fast he feels light-headed. Taking the muzzle off Chrollo to let him eat and drink was one thing. For this, the muzzle *stays.*

Chrollo leans forward, curling over Kurapika's back. He loops his cuffed hands over Kurapika, fitting him inside his bound arms. He hooks his chin over Kurapika's shoulder and presses the glands on their necks

together, allowing their scents to start mixing. Kurapika shudders as the details and nuance in the alpha's pheromones flood his mind. The faint sweetness he had noticed weeks ago becomes more prominent. It's a delicate, floral, and herbaceous scent that softens the deeper tones of his alpha pheromones in an unexpected way. Kurapika's breath hitches as it all swirls together, leaving him with the sudden and dizzying sensation of bone-deep comfort that he didn't expect.

Chrollo's pulse is steady. It feels calm as it beats against Kurapika's.

Involuntarily, he relaxes back into Chrollo's chest, letting himself sink into it. He doesn't even mind the way Chrollo's arms tighten around his waist. For a moment, he's not worried about why they're scent-marking or his plans. All his feelings towards Chrollo become perfectly simple.

He can feel the rough straps of the muzzle scrape against his jaw as Chrollo nuzzles him and his breath spilling down his neck. Kurapika lays his head back and closes his eyes. He breathes in slow and deep in time with Chrollo as the warmth of this alpha seeps through his clothes and fills Kurapika up.

Chrollo's voice enters the peaceful silence. It's low, like he's giving Kurapika another dangerous secret.

"The truth about me is that I was born trash and I never tried to be better. I've never tried to have a good job or normal life and I don't intend to."

Kurapika shuts his eyes as Chrollo spreads his hands out over as much of Kurapika's abdomen as he can, running his fingers over the stitches of his knit sweater. His touch is greedy, like he's doing something he knows he shouldn't.

"You smell too good to be in this rotten place with me… but I'm glad you are anyway."

Kurapika lets the words sink in before opening his eyes slowly, looking straight ahead at the door.

"… I think I'm too good for it too."

"…"

Chrollo's shoulders shake against Kurapika's back with an earnest chuckle.

"That doesn't surprise me at all. I'm sure that pure, blushing virgin bit you do for Eliza isn't just an act." Chrollo teases.

He turns his head, pressing the cold metal bars of the muzzle to Kurapika's cheek, getting as close to touching his face as possible.

"Let me guess," Chrollo's hands creep up to tug on the modest neckline of Kurapika's sweater playfully. "You've spent every heat alone, hiding from everyone and trying desperately to deny yourself carnal pleasure because you're either too pure or too proud for it."

Kurapika huffs, his chin lifting as he turns his nose up at the crass remarks. He slaps the hands away from his neck.

"Not that it's any of your business - but you're wrong. You can't read me as well as you think you can." He says hotly.

Chrollo's hands hang in the air in front of Kurapika and he pulls his head back in surprise, trying to get a better look at Kurapika's face.

"Is that so? Pardon me for disregarding your experience. I'd love to hear *all about* exactly how wrong I am." Chrollo says.

"Once again, not your business."

It's true that Kurapika's alone most of the time, but on occasion he will spend his heats with Melody. She's a beta so she can't quite match Kurapika's appetite when he's in heat but her soothing presence is comforting and she's excellent with her fingers. Kurapika's never spent his heat with an alpha before but he's no blushing virgin.

"I can't help but be curious about what you'll do to find a partner for your cycle while I'm scent-marking you."

Kurapika scoffs. Curious but not concerned, of course. Chrollo lowers his hands, letting them rest in Kurapika's lap.

"What happens for ruts? You get tossed into an empty solitary room?" Kurapika asks, turning it back on him.

"Correct."

There's an implicit cruelty to the practice that goes along with the practicality. Kurapika doesn't know exactly what he'd change if he could. Maybe the option for medication or for the room to not be completely bare at least. But those changes would require money and care, things the therapy program is trying to bring.

"It wasn't as bad last time since I was able to sneak in the scented handkerchief you gave me."

Blood rushes to Kurapika's face so fast he feels dizzy. He drops his burning hot face into his hands.

Chapter 8

The self-defense class is wrapping up and Kurapika's hands are on another omega, helping her adjust her stance to show her how to be more stable. This omega is one of their regulars, a woman in her forties with a broad nose and round, flat face that's weathered like a good book. When she started attending half a year ago, Kurapika overheard her whispering to the other students that she's fresh out of a messy divorce. He's always liked her determination and the way she encourages her sparring partners.

So, out of everyone who could have possibly noticed the sudden change in Kurapika's scent first, she's not so bad.

The two of them go still. Since Kurapika is wearing his scent patches it's faint, but the lesson today was rigorous enough to make him sweat. It's the scent of preheat nearly five days before Kurapika expected it.

Immediately, the older woman switches to try and help him. She places her hands on his shoulders and glances at the only alpha in the room anxiously.

"I've got some scented wipes in my purse." She says to Kurapika softly. "You should go home. You gonna be okay, hun?"

Kurapika's hands fall to his sides and he nods.

"Yeah, I'm alright."

Kurapika's not feeling it much yet. He's a little warm but he attributed that to the exercise. With the preheat setting in, he can feel the muscles in his lower body tensing and he finds himself getting distracted by silver strands in the woman's black hair. As Kurapika gradually becomes aware of his own breathing, she pulls him off to the side where her bag is hanging on a folding chair. She hastily fishes out a packet of refreshing, eucalyptus-scented wipes and pats one around the edges of Kurapika's scent patch. The cool dampness of the cloth and the strong scent help Kurapika focus a little.

Having noticed something isn't right, Izunavi comes over to check on them. The woman tenses at his approach, eyeing her instructor more warily than she ever has before.

"Is everything okay?" Izunavi asks, keeping his voice low.

Kurapika nods, taking the wipe from the woman's hands to scrub it over the nape of his neck.

"… My heat is starting earlier than I expected it." Kurapika admits quietly.

Izunavi's brows raise but he doesn't react much beyond that. Not that Kurapika expected him too, since he is a very measured man.

"Oh, got it. Let's call it day - you just have a seat for now." Izunavi says.

Kurapika does as told and fixes his eyes on the linoleum floor to count tiles so his mind won't wander to places it shouldn't. He's not far enough into heat to feel particularly weak, but it isn't like Izunavi needs him to help end the class. It's better if he takes it easy until he's home.

"Don't worry," Kurapika whispers to the woman lingering with him. "I trust Izunavi."

She presses her lips together in a thin line but nods. It isn't impossible for alphas to restrain themselves around omegas in heat - it's just that most alphas don't try as hard as they should. But Izunavi isn't one of the best omega self-defense instructors in the city for nothing.

Izunavi wraps up the class quickly, congratulating the omegas on another evening of hard work. Soon, he returns to Kurapika's side and offers him a hand up which Kurapika accepts. He sways the moment he's on his feet.

"Let me walk you home," Izunavi offers.

"Yeah…" Kurapika agrees, his voice faint.

He lets go of Izunavi's hand looks to the older woman again.

"Thank you for the wipe. Get home safe." Kurapika says.

"It was nothing. You do the same."

It's a dark, drizzling evening in Yorknew. They put on their coats for protection against the late fall chill and Kurapika pulls his hood up, hiding himself in as deep in the slick material as he can. The moment Kurapika and Izunavi step out of the community center, Izunavi has a pack of cigarettes and shakes one out. He brings the filter to his lips and lights the end. His breath mixes with the smoke to create a lazy cloud in front of his face.

Kurapika wraps his arms around his waist, curling into himself as his focus begins to slip again. He can only think of one thing to blame for his heat coming early. Getting scent-marked by an alpha.

"It wasn't as bad last time since…"

Kurapika blocks out the intrusive memory of Chrollo whispering that secret into his ear. The worst part is that Kurapika can't make himself believe that Chrollo was making fun of him.

Walking shoulder-to-shoulder with Izunavi, Kurapika can feel him take an extra-long drag of his cigarette to blow a big puff of smoke as they pass another group of people rushing through the dreary night. The smoke fills the space around them, covering the faint, sweet scent of Kurapika's preheat.

Kurapika associates Izunavi's pheromones with the smell of cigarettes.

The silent presence of the old alpha trying to cover for him and protect him, even if it's just a little bit, helps keep Kurapika relaxed. The only problem with being relaxed is the slick that's steadily beginning to soak his underwear. He can feel it building up with every step.

Still, he keeps his eyes fixed on the sidewalk. Although he trusts Izunavi with his physical safety, he's never spent his heat with an alpha before and he isn't going to try it out this time. Kurapika reminds himself to stay strong and ignore the pheromones at his side.

Izunavi walks Kurapika up the stairs of his apartment and all the way to his front door. He waits for Kurapika to successfully open the lock before taking a step back.

"Want me to pick you up anything?" Izunavi offers.

Kurapika shakes his head no and pulls the door partially closed between them. Halfway behind the door, Kurapika leans into the cold wood with a barely suppressed shiver.

"No, I have what I need… Have a good night."

Izunavi accepts that and turns away with a casual wave.

"You too."

Kurapika closes the door fully and rests his forehead against it, taking a deep, unsteady breath. He closes his eyes and the faces of comforting, enticing people who touched him recently cycle through his mind. Izunavi's tan, worn face seasoned with stubble and wrinkles. His strong, broad hands and a cigarette hanging from his lax mouth. The nurturing omega woman from class with her attentive hands, soft face, and peppered hair. Chrollo with his straight nose, dark lashes, strange smile, and vastly knowing eyes…

Kurapika swallows heavily and shoves his hand into his coat pocket as one more person comes to mind. His best friend and the only person he could actually call in a moment like this. Melody with her round eyes, crooked teeth, and fine, feather-soft hair. Her soothing voice and precise fingers… Kurapika pulls out his phone and opens his eyes to send Melody a text to see if she's willing and available.

The next morning, Kurapika wakes with his skin nearly fused to Melody's. They lay together in a tangled mess and for a few hazy moments he can't tell who's limbs belong to who. One of Kurapika's legs is fit between Melody's thick thighs and one of her arms is trapped between Kurapika's waist and the bed. He

peels a strand of someone's hair from his bottom lip and looks down to see Melody hugging his other arm tight between her breasts. Feeling him stir, Melody starts to wake. Her mouth stretches wide for the quietest yawn.

"Mm, you seem well enough for breakfast," Melody says, looking up at Kurapika's bare body, the blanket pooling at his hips."Yes… Thank you for coming over last night." Kurapika says, his voice low and worn. "I'm feeling calmer right now."

"It was no trouble."

They get up, dress in old, worn-thin cotton shirts, and go to Kurapika's kitchenette. Kurapika uses his french press to prepare two cups of coffee while Melody sets the flaky, almond pastries she brought last night out on a plate for them to share. Kurapika doesn't have much - very few people in Yorknew City do - but he does have a nice cushioned seat by the window. He and Melody sit pressed together to have breakfast overlooking the cornerstone that's shadowed by big, business buildings.

"You smell like him. Just a little bit." Melody says.

Kurapika is too worn-out to be defensive about it. He suspects Melody knows that too. Kurapika slouches, bracing his elbow on his knee and resting his chin in his palm. In his other hand, he cradles the hot mug to his left breast for comfort.

"… Is it bad?" Kurapika asks, voice small.

Melody shakes her head no.

"I don't think so."

Melody lays her cheek on Kurapika's shoulder, giving him the closeness he wishes he didn't crave so much during his cycle.

"It's very understated."

Kurapika unfurls just enough to nibble on one of the pastries. Despite the lingering heat that makes his hips feel heavy, Melody's weight, the sugar, and the caffeine all make him feel a little more like himself.

"That makes sense. He said he doesn't feel competitive about me." Kurapika replies.

Melody laughs, her voice high and light, the tip of her nose crinkling.

"Kurapika, I would sincerely like to know who you think could compete with him for your interest." Melody says

Kurapika's face warms and he pouts.

"Responding to that in any way is a trap."

Nearby, Melody's phone pings. She peers over the steaming rim of her mug to down at the screen, then pushes it aside.

"It's not urgent?" Kurapika asks.

He finishes his share of breakfast and slides his hands around her waist without realizing he's doing it until his finger lace together around her stomach.

"No, just a guy." Melody says dismissively.

Kurapika raises a brow and his lips quirk up with a small smile. Melody sets the last sip of her coffee aside and looks up to kiss just under his chin.

"A guy?"

"MmHmm. One I haven't made up my mind about yet."

Melody tugs on his shoulders so Kurapika leans down. Melody whispers to him.

"But I wish you knew how funny it is to imagine him and your guy on the sidelines while we enjoy ourselves."

Kurapika blushes, imagining Chrollo in the corner of the room, cuffed and muzzled like he always is, while he's entangled with Melody. He squirms, feeling his heat light up like Melody's blown gently across a bed of embers. She giggles at the look on Kurapika's face and he lightly shoves her shoulder.

"M-Melody, c'mon, that's..." Kurapika shakes his head in disbelief but can't help giggling with her. "You'd have to be with whoever is texting you for another twenty-something years for that to happen."

"Maybe. So you'll agree to it in twenty-something years?"

Melody reaches up, looping her arms around his neck. He welcomes her in, her full figure fitting against his as their chests press together.

"Sure," Kurapika doesn't believe that it'll ever become possible. "We can put Chrollo to the test - really find out if he doesn't feel competitive about me. What about your guy?"

"It's hard to say for sure... but I would guess that he's secretly the jealous type."

Their lips meet for a kiss and Kurapika doesn't know who leaned in first. Melody says it's always Kurapika who leans in first when he's in heat, and he's not so sure about that. She calls him passionate but it's hard for Kurapika to see himself that way through the haze.

The next time Kurapika goes to see Chrollo, he's ready to be the one to take the alpha off guard.

Even though Kurapika isn't holding any treats, Chrollo smiles when he sees him. While Chrollo is settling onto the couch Kurapika shucks off his winter coat and hangs it over the back of the chair. His movements are slow and deliberate. Memories of their last therapy session mix with Melody's teasing words. The mounting tension between them has become impossible to forget - just like the secret Kurapika's smuggled in under his clothes.

Not interested in their usual smalltalk, Kurapika decides to get right to it.

"Does Tserracnich have any weaknesses that aren't public knowledge? Maybe a dangerous allergy, a disability, or an injury that never healed after his arrest?" Kurapika asks.

If Kurapika's lack of banter bothers Chrollo, he doesn't show it. He matches Kurapika's direct line of questioning with a direct answer.

"I don't know about any allergies but I've seen him work out in the yard and-"

Kurapika drifts away from the table to stands over Chrollo without joining him on the couch yet, listening intently. Chrollo lifts his head to keep his eyes on Kurapika.

"- and he's obsessive about it. There's no physical issue that I've noticed, but he'll fixate on a particular exercise and do it repeatedly until he thinks he's doing it better than anyone's ever done it. It's like a complex." Chrollo explains.

Kurapika would have liked to hear that after Tserracnich's arrest some inmate busted his kneecap or fucked up his hand. Something that Kurapika could take advantage of. But he's sure Chrollo is telling him this because he thinks it's exploitable. Kurapika tilts his head as he considers it. It isn't healthy to overwork one part of the body. An obsession with perfection can easily backfire.

"You think he burns himself out regularly," Kurapika says.

Chrollo nods. "I don't think that *he* thinks it's a problem. He has his own cell and is almost untouchable. The only ones who get close to him during his recovery time are guards, counselors, and his omega."

Kurapika smiles dryly.

"Just a weak, stupid omega. Nothing he would need to worry about."

"Maybe. Do you think he'll have something to worry about?" Chrollo replies.

Although Chrollo's voice barely changes, his unwavering gaze answers the question for them. He's played with Kurapika a lot in the few months they've known each other, but the heaviness in this eyes reveals that he takes Kurapika very, *very* seriously.

It feels *so good* to be taken seriously.

Slowly, Kurapika pulls up the bottom of his shirt, feeling Chrollo's stare for every languid second that passes. Kurapika stops just before he reveals his chest, only displaying the plastic bag he has taped to his stomach. He pulls the bag off his skin and hands it to Chrollo. Inside is one of Kurapika’s thin, white tank tops that's folded neatly to be as flat as possible. He hands it over to Chrollo.

Intrigued, Chrollo accepts the bag. He cracks it open to discover the secret treat he's been given. In an instant, his eyes go wide at the scent that wafts up from it. It's one of the shirts Kurapika wore between waves of his heat.

Kurapika's pushing down everything he likes about working with Chrollo and those feelings have begun to overflow. Going so far as to bring Chrollo something from his heat is proof of that. He should take it back while he can - but he doesn't. Kurapika keeps pushing.

"Help me time it right and he'll have more than worries." Kurapika coerces Chrollo.

He stands tall putting forth every bit of confidence he has. Usually, Kurapika's trying to intimidate alphas with his audacity, so he's not really sure how to de-tangle this new, bold seduction from being threatening. Melody said that the offered clothing would be enough to make things clear. Kurapika is betting on that.

Chrollo gawks at Kurapika, stunned. It's true that Kurapika has been resistant to use intimacy as a bargaining method with Chrollo so far, so this must be quite a shock. But lately, Kurapika's started to think that trading with Chrollo like this wouldn't be so disgusting after all.

Chrollo opens the bag up again to stick his nose inside and smell it.

"… I love honeysuckle." Chrollo confesses into the bag, his eyes closed. "When I was a kid, there weren't many opportunities to have something sweet… one of the older girls I knew showed me where to find honeysuckle in the woods by the orphanage."

Orphan. Kurapika wishes he didn't keep finding things that he has in common with Chrollo.

Kurapika closes the remaining distance between them. He straddles one of Chrollo's thighs, knees sinking into the dull, grey cushion, and shuffles closer until his thigh is right against Chrollo's crotch. He didn't expect Chrollo to get half-hard so fast, which makes Kurapika flush, but he refuses to back down.

"… I had my heat early because of you," Kurapika says softly. He didn't plan on telling Chrollo that. It just comes out. "I'm still mad at you for that."

"Really?"

Kurapika isn't sure if Chrollo is asking if he's really mad or if he really had his heat early. He just nods since either is true enough.

He moves slowly, spreading his fingers over Chrollo's chest to explore his body. The prison uniform feels cheap and Kurapika knows how thin Chrollo's undershirts are. His fingers easily map out the shape of Chrollo's collar bones and the valley between the swell of his pecs.

"I'm flattered you were thinking of me, but I'm not sure I'll be able to sneak this in," Chrollo sighs. "My cellmate was already too interested in the scraps you've given me."

Kurapika's fingers find the top divots of Chrollo's ribcage.

"… I was barely thinking of you." Kurapika mutters, confidence wavering just a bit.

"Barely is enough."

Chrollo pulls the tank-top out of the bag and drapes it over Kurapika's shoulder. He tucks his muzzle into the crevice between Kurapika's neck and the folded shirt, breathing in deeply. For once, Chrollo's exhale shakes, and that's enough to bolster Kurapika.

He trails his fingers down below Chrollo's cuffed hands for knot in his waistband and works it open, loosening his pants. Kurapika sits up on his knees, looking down on Chrollo. The cage over Chrollo's face keeps him from being able to feel Kurapika's breast that's a few centimeters away, so Kurapika doubts he can tell it's there at all.

Kurapika traces the lines of Chrollo's hips and follows them down into his underwear. Kurapika fits his hand over the shape of Chrollo's cock, squeezing gently. He groans.

"Are you barely thinking of me now?" Chrollo asks, his voice low and flickering with heat as he huffs Kurapika's scent.

"Less than barely," Kurapika lies.

Chrollo's cock throbs in Kurapika's hands, swelling even bigger. By touch alone, Kurapika uses both hands to map out the shape of this alpha's cock. His thumb swipes through a bead of precum that's gathering at the tip and he spreads it over the velvety skin. He caresses the length, fondly petting the vein

he finds that reminds him of Chrollo’s wrist. One hand continues to explore the shaft while his other dips even lower to rub Chrollo’s balls. Chrollo moans softly as Kurapika gives him another gentle squeeze.

Chrollo’s head falls back as he pants. His brows are furrowed and his normally ghoulish complexion is flushed with arousal. His thighs flex beneath Kurapika rhythmically as Chrollo fights the instinct to buck his hips.

Kurapika looms over Chrollo’s face, unconsciously leaning in with the desire to study him even more closely. He couldn't have constructed this when he imagined Chrollo's face as his heat crept in. He could only picture Chrollo's stoic focus. Now his features have softened. He doesn't look normal - Kurapika doubts he ever could - but the heat makes his features seem more malleable.

Chrollo’s eyes flutter open to meet Kurapika’s fixated gaze. His eyes are heavy beneath his black lashes and hazy with arousal like a foggy night. Chrollo is panting with his lips parted, drinking in as much of Kurapika’s scent as he can. Kurapika isn't sure why he does it. Maybe Chrollo’s hunger for him is a compulsion.

"Take off my muzzle." Chrollo whispers.

There's the faintest color of desperation to his voice that Kurapika’s never heard from him before. It sends a rush through Kurapika's body that soaks his underwear.

"No."

Chrollo’s jaw drops open with a pained groan at the denial. Kurapika can feel the way Chrollo throbs in his hands and a thicker stream of precum dribbles down in between his fingers. It's slick enough to make Kurapika's hand slide down the shaft faster, his pinky finger bumping against the swelling knot at the base. Kurapika can't help wondering what it would feel like to deny Chrollo something he wants while he's inside him.

Kurapika breaths deeply with Chrollo but his tempo stays slow and deliberate. Without thinking about why, he opens his mouth with his tongue resting heavily on his bottom lip. Chrollo’s eyes immediately lock onto it, watching as drool rolls down Kurapika’s tongue and pools at the tip. Anticipating what will happen next, Chrollo opens his mouth wider to catch Kurapika’s spit as it falls off his tongue and through the gaps in his muzzle.

As Chrollo swallows Kurapika's spit his whole body shudders. A guttural moan shakes free from Chrollo's gasping throat and even though this is the first time Kurapika's touched an alpha he can tell what's happening.

With one hand, Kurapika grabs Chrollo's knot as tight as he can. He's unable to fully fit his fingers around it and his forearm flexes with the strain. It pulses in Kurapika's grip as wave after wave of cum streams down the length. Chrollo grits his teeth, biting down his groans so he won't give Babimyna a reason to do an unsolicited wellness check on Kurapika.

It's Kurapika's first time seeing Chrollo's teeth bared. His fangs are sharp and as straight as he bridge of his nose. Kurapika follows the shape of them with his eyes, still holding Chrollo's knot tight through the waves of his orgasm.

Kurapika really hadn't brought his worn shirt and plastic bag with the intention of it being used to clean up Chrollo's cum, but that's the most practical use for it now. Kurapika's nose wrinkles as his vague

distaste for alphas returns. In terms of intimate partners, alphas have the most inconvenient body type by far. But Kurapika thinks he'll like fucking Chrollo well enough anyway.

Chapter 9

"Good morning, Kurapika. How are you feeling?" Kaiser asks.

Kurapika is sitting in his winter coat with his limbs arranged to pantomime relaxation.

"I'm feeling fine. Yourself?" Kurapika replies.

"I cannot complain."

Kaiser makes a mark on his clipboard.

"How are your sessions with Chrollo?" Kaiser asks.

Kurapika knew this question would be coming and he knows how he needs to answer. He crosses his ankles and laces his fingers together. He answers slowly. Deliberately.

"They're going alright. Chrollo is nice but…"

He allows the "but" to linger for a few beats. Kaiser doesn't give any nonverbal prompts to continue like a normal person would for a conversation. Kurapika continues anyway.

"… But I think he's a little limited in his self-taut education."

The words have a slimy texture in Kurapika's mouth. Usually, Kurapika doesn't feel this way when he's criticizing people. The problem is that it's a lie. It's a lie Chrollo knows he's telling because it should help him seem like a better match for Tserracnich, but it still feels wrong.

"I don't think he's incapable," Kurapika adds to maintain his sweeter persona. "It's just that he hasn't been exposed to a broader range of topics…"

Kaiser stares at Kurapika impassively.

"… Do you find it frustrating? To talk to someone of lower education?" Kaiser asks after a long beat of silence.

Kurapika is stunned by the loaded question. Kaiser has never asked something so leading before. It's far from the "non-directive" therapy style Chrollo mentioned. In fact, Kurapika thinks it's wholly *unprofessional.*

And it's not far off from a complaint Kurapika thinks Tserracnich would make.

Kurapika's hands clench inside the sleeves if his jacket.

"… Sometimes," Kurapika hears himself answer quietly, feeling distant.

Kaiser makes another mark on his clipboard. Not a single muscle on his face so much as twitches.

"You told him I'm too stupid for you?"

"I said it more kindly than that."

"Good."

Kurapika taps his fingers against his forearm. *"Boss,"* he thinks. Regardless of whether or not Kurapika's words to the therapist get him closer to Tserracnich, Chrollo would want the administration to underestimate his intelligence.

Even so, it's hard for Kurapika to focus on what Chrollo's getting out of this when Kaiser's strange question sticks in his mind. It felt almost *too* specific. Kaiser couldn't know that Kurapika knows that Tserracnich is an option. Perhaps Kaiser knows that Tserracnich is getting frustrated with his omega and is looking for a new candidate in advance. But if that is the case, being careless with the omegas' therapy just to look for a new toy for Tserracnich indicates a troubling level of corruption. It wouldn't be the first bad sign about the program, but it could be the worst…

"What's got your wheels spinning?" Chrollo asks.

Kurapika's head snaps up as he's pulled from his thoughts. Kurapika hadn't even realized that he's still on his feet and wearing his coat. Meanwhile, Chrollo's seated comfortably in his usual spot on the couch.

Kurapika sighs and shrugs off his coat, dropping it over the back of the chair. He combs his fingers through his hair as he tries to decide how honest he wants to be with Chrollo.

"… I wonder if Tserracnich talks about his compulsion towards exploitation in therapy or if that all gets wrapped up into typical *alpha dominance issues…"* Kurapika grumbles, not really answering Chrollo's question.

"Therapy didn't go well," Chrollo infers.

Kurapika joins Chrollo on the couch, resting his elbows on his knees and letting his head hang between his shoulders.

Chrollo tilts his head.

"Did Kaiser try to invalidate your complaints about me?" He asks.

Kurapika shakes his head no.

"He was too eager to… accept them."

Chrollo steeples his fingers. "… That is odd."

"I don't know what to make of it, but I don't like it." Kurapika says.

Chrollo's fingers knit together and he looks straight ahead at nothing.

"I couldn't imagine what Tserracnich talks about in his therapy sessions." Chrollo says, going back to Kurapika's earlier musings. "When I overhear him talking to other inmates he's an egotistical gender-essentialist, but he probably doesn't speak like that to the people who control his access to an omega." Chrollo speculates.

"Maybe. Or he's completely honest and the people running the program think that forcing him to spend time a good omega who he can't assault and dispose of will fix some of that." Kurapika counters.

"So, you think he might be actually doing therapy right by being himself?"

Unlike us.

"I didn't say that," Kurapika dismisses quickly. "But if he's such an egotist, wouldn't changing himself for others be beneath him? And being a dominating freak just so happens to be working out for him again?"

"Maybe…" Chrollo drawls. "Well, you're the one who's been studying him for years."

Kurapika leans back into the couch with a deflated sigh. He lets go of the urge to argue and tries to see Chrollo's perspective a little more. Since Chrollo's in the same prison and therapy group as Tserracnich, he probably does have a better sense for what the alpha is like.

"… I truly don't know. The only time I ever saw the man personally was in the courtroom. During the trial I thought he was very… direct." Kurapika says, much more subdued now.

From what Kurapika could see, Tserracnich was upfront about the things he did and didn't do that strictly corresponded to the evidence. Of course, Tserracnich would have been coached by his lawyers in advance, just like Kurapika was before he went to the stand.

Chrollo hums idly. "As I said before, it is difficult for me to parse what a man like Tserracnich could be thinking. I can admit to you that I don't have the proper feelings when it comes to taking a life but-"

"Tserracnich is different." Kurapika finishes, perhaps too hastily. Chrollo lets him without comment.

"And you don't talk about how you feel about killing in your therapy sessions." Kurapika surmises.

"I don't talk about anything that matters, same as you." Chrollo says softly. "Similarly, I haven't spoken about Tserracnich in many years."

Kurapika looks directly at Chrollo, trying in vain once again to read his serene face.

"Not even with your people?" He questions.

Chrollo shakes his head. "Not with them. With them, I have to be… I have to be strong."

Kurapika knows what Chrollo really means - that he has to be a leader - but it seems he still won't tell Kurapika that.

"… Her name was Sarasa."

Kurapika straightens up as Chrollo begins to share something Kurapika never thought he would.

"She was one of my friends at the church-run orphanage I grew up in." Chrollo shares.

Kurapika listens quietly. Against his wishes, he begins to feel closer to Chrollo with every word. That feeling manifests as a growing ache in his heart.

"Sarasa was sweet and outgoing. She was an honest and punctual sort of girl. The day she went missing without explanation wasn't like her at all. It terrified me the very moment I noticed she wasn't where she was supposed to be. When I found her, or rather, what was left of her, she was in a sack."

Chrollo is staring at a blank wall as he recounts the details, his voice low and closed off from any emotion despite saying how he felt that day.

"I don't know that it was Tserracnich personally - it probably wasn't. But I believe the culprits were in the exploitation ring he's the head of now."

Mentally, Kurapika connects Chrollo's story to the facts. Tserracnich's in his late forties now, so he would have been in his twenties when Chrollo was a preteen. It's possible that Tserracnich could have been been personally involved in what happened to her but no evidence was ever recovered.

The nature of the crime is strikingly similar to Kurapika's experience as well. There are details that Chrollo couldn't have possibly known in order to manufacture the story for Kurapika's sympathy.

When Chrollo's eyes finally meet his, Kurapika stares into the black, vacuous holes. Kurapika's always thought there was an emptiness to Chrollo's gaze but now it's so clear to him. Chrollo fills himself up with things - his books, his gang, his chosen identity as a thief - but nothing is enough. For the first time, Kurapika reaches for Chrollo's hand first. Kurapika doesn't think he can't hold it in anymore.

"… I used to be a preschool teacher…" Kurapika confesses.

In the past, Kurapika's been teased for having such a damn stereotypical omega career. Reflexively, he braces himself but the mockery doesn't come.

Kurapika takes a shaky breath and continues.

"… I make better money at a shady bar now then I did when I was taking care of people's children, if you can believe that."

"I absolutely can believe that." Chrollo says.

Kurapika smiles dryly."But that wasn't why I quit."

He curls into himself as though trying to shield himself from the memory though he knows he can't. Even back when Kurapika and Chrollo were playing with those stupid icebreaker cards he could hardly stand the mention of being a teacher.

"One of my students - the sweetest little boy - his name was Parrio." Kurapika closes his eyes, remembering the child's face. "He was so shy but he loved bugs a lot. I always had to keep an extra eye on him to make sure he didn't wander off during recess."

Kurapika's brows furrow as his imagination takes him down the spiral of the painful memories.

"And one day he went missing. Everyone was so worried - *I* was so worried. Every waking moment his parents were searching for him. It took months for us to find…"

Feeling a wave of nausea, Kurapika covers his mouth. In his mind, he's following the same paths as he did that day. Stepping off the trail in the woods between neighborhoods with deadfall crunching underfoot, losing his footing as he climbed over a rotting, fallen tree. Seeing the corner of a plastic bag that was most likely litter but he had to check. He couldn't overlook any detail.

"I found him by accident. It wasn't police work or detectives, it was me. If I didn't wander off in the direction I did, his parents might've never had anything to bury."

It's just like how Chrollo found Sarasa. Kurapika tries to stop himself from imagining how a little boy with black hair and wide eyes would have handled seeing the things Kurapika saw, but he can't. Chrollo is right here as an example. Kurapika tips his head back, struggling to breath. He feels feverish and clammy. Chrollo squeezes his hand, grounding Kurapika enough for him to continue.

"I found Parrio in parts. And the things that had been done to his h-head…"

Kurapika pitches forward, dry heaving. He can't describe what he saw. Parrio's head was recognizable at best but there were obvious signs of heavy abuse. Kurapika couldn't tell if the abuse happened before or after Parrio's death. Maybe it was both. According to the autopsy, his body parts had been dunked in bleach before being tossed away so none of the evidence could be linked to specific individuals. Fortunately, they were able to gather other types of evidence to add the the growing case file detectives had already been building against Tserracnich's group. But in the end, Tserracnich himself was never charged for what happened to Parrio. They could only get him for lesser charges. It was better than nothing, but still not enough.

"I know Tserracnich is responsible. I can't stomach the fact that a monster like him is still living in this world. I don't care if he can't hurt anyone else anymore - I want him dead." Kurapika whispers viciously, his voice harsh and bitter with hate. "And I want to be the one who does it."

Chrollo’s fingers interlock with Kurapika’s and he shifts closer until their shoulders are pressed together.

"Did you like being a teacher?" Chrollo asks.

The simple, unexpected question almost causes Kurapika to collapse. For a few aching heartbeats he can't breath. The worst part is he doesn't know why it hurts him so much. Kurapika nods, blinking away the tears stinging his eyes before they can fall. Still, his voice trembles.

"I loved it. I loved working with kids."

Even now, he's certain he could identify the developing handwriting of every child that was in his class.

And he won't ever do it again.

Kurapika shuts his eyes, wanting to hide them. He knows without checking they're rimmed red. Despite how hard he's worked at keeping himself from crying over every little thing, he can't help it. Grief, anger, even happiness… Kurapika wishes he wasn't so emotional. He doesn't cry like he used to, but his eyes still get red.

Chrollo lets go of Kurapika’s hands. Cool fingers startle Kurapika as they lightly touch the thin skin around his eyes. He's tense as Chrollo’s thumbs caress the dark blotches under his eyes and brush along the tips of his lashes.

"I believe that revenge is going to be the best form of therapy." Chrollo whispers.

Kurapika laughs humorously, some of the tension leaking out and gathering in his eyelashes.

"I shouldn't listen to your mental-health advice." Kurapika’s voice is shamefully wet.

Chrollo’s thumb swipes across his lashes line again, drying his eyes.

"But you will because it's what you want to hear. Let's kill that son of a bitch."

Aside from the few times they've spoken, Babimyna is the sort of man who has been very good at minding his own business. But since Chrollo's started to scent Kurapika more heavily - enough for it to linger for days at a time - Babimyna's been watching Kurapika more openly. Kurapika pretends not to notice the way the guard's stare has changed but he is a little worried he's pretending to be *too* dense. It has gotten rather… obvious.

As soon as Kurapika's alone in the visitation room for his next appointment he lets out a sign of relief. Kurapika is still pretty sure that Babimyna is a good man, but that's part of the problem. The other part of the problem is that Babimyna works for the prison system. Although Chrollo insists that Babimyna is attracted to Kurapika, it would never work out between them. Not unless Babimyna would be willing to *actually* do the right thing and put Kurapika in a room alone with Tserracnich. That would never happen so Babimyna will never be on Kurapika's side.

Kurapika sits at the table to wait for Chrollo like usual. He can tell when Chrollo arrives but this time he's stopped at the door. Kurapika's ears perk as he hears low voices briefly conversing. He holds his breath, but it's still too muffled for Kurapika to make out anything.

There are cameras in the hall so whatever Chrollo and Babimyna are saying can't be that damning. Then again, camera footage only exists when it's convenient for the people in charge. Kurapika swallows thickly and counts how long the exchange lasts - five long, tense beats. Then the door opens and Chrollo steps inside, carrying a roll of stained paper in his hands.

Kurapika frowns, glancing from the paper to Chrollo's face.

"What were you talking about?" Kurapika asks.

"This," Chrollo gestures to the paper. "He wanted to inspect it, but I think that was an excuse. I think he just wanted to show me that he's in charge."

Kurapika takes that opinion with a grain of salt and turns his attention back to the paper. Chrollo's never brought anything like that before. Kurapika had no idea it was allowed. Babimyna could be right to be suspicious.

Chrollo approaches the table and unrolls the paper. He places it in front of Kurapika and smooths it out with his hands. The paper is thick and won't lay completely flat.

"My fellow inmates and I did an art group therapy session. I made this for you." Chrollo says. "I also brought up the idea of an ice cream social and the other inmates liked it."

Kurapika takes in his deadpan expression for a moment before taking a closer look at what's on the paper.

It's an abstract blend of bright paints interwoven with strips of magazine that have been cut and pasted onto the surface. Kurapika can't make out any hidden symbols of patterns… He squints and lifts the paper up to the light to see if he can make out whatever message Chrollo is trying to convey to him that way.

"There's no secret message." Chrollo says abruptly.

Kurapika looks over at Chrollo with confusion.

"What?"

"Well, I suppose that's not true, because all art has meaning. But this isn't about our deal or anything like that. I just wanted to make something… for you." Chrollo explains.

Kurapika stares for a few moments in disbelief but Chrollo never cracks a smile. He stays completely serious.

"… Oh," Kurapika lowers the page and looks at the colors and shapes again.

Instantly, he's back in his classroom, seeing the vibrant imagination pouring out of the children despite how few supplies they had to express themselves with. Against Kurapika's will, he sees that same liveliness in Chrollo. In this moment, he's no longer a deadpan, alpha convict confined to a give-and-take relationship with a desperate omega as a way to get a glimpse of life outside the prison.

Suddenly, he sees that Chrollo is right. This paper is so loaded with meaning it's hard to look away. Kurapika swallows thickly and runs his fingers over the rough, dried texture of the cheap, water-based paint and the glue that's seeped out of the edges of shapes of the shards of magazine. He's being given a glimpse of Chrollo’s vast internal world.

"I… thank you. I…"

Kurapika hesitates. Can he even say he likes it? Something about that doesn't feel right.

"You're radiating with passion." Chrollo says.

It's the sort of thing Melody would say.

He reaches down to take Kurapika’s hand and guides it to a particular section of the piece. The texture is rough from the way the water has soaked the paper. It's a violent burst of color that bleeds all over the rest of the piece.

"Just like this."

Suddenly nothing about the art looks messy or flawed.

"It's beautiful," Kurpika thinks.

"I think so too."

Kurapika chokes, realizing he's spoken his thoughts out loud. Chrollo curls over Kurapika, his chest pressing to the line of his shoulders. It's warm like a winter coat and a cup of coffee on a cold, Yorknew morning. Just like he's stepped out into a frigid sunrise, Kurapika takes a deep, satisfying breath. He feels strangely at peace. Kurapika's sure the way he feels is fleeting, but it's as Melody said. If Kurapika doesn't appreciate the things in life that are temporary, then there isn't anything to appreciate at all.

Kurapika turns just enough for Chrollo to understand that he should loosen his hold. He stays close, looking down at Kurapika like a cat watching a bird. Slowly, Kurapika lifts his hands and beckons Chrollo to come closer. Chrollo bows his head and stays still, patiently letting Kurapika unlock his muzzle and ease it away from his face.

This time, Kurapika has nothing for Chrollo to eat or drink. He places his hands on Chrollo's cheeks, feeling the smooth planes of his pale face. Again, the red marks left by the muzzle catch Kurapika's attention. Rather than shoving down the empathy he feels at the sight of them, Kurapika soothingly rubs the irritated skin with his fingers.

Chrollo leans into the touch, pressing his nose to Kurapika's palm. Kurapika watches as Chrollo raises his cuffed hands to fit a fingernail beneath the adhesive scent patch on Kurapika's wrist. He starts peeling it off slowly like he's expecting Kurapika to stop him. Distantly, Kurapika thinks that he probably should.

Chrollo tosses the scent patch to the side where his muzzle rests. Chrollo presses his lips to Kurapika's skin. His breath hitches at the faint touch and his pulse pounds. Just behind Chrollo's gentle lips are his alpha fangs - barely a centimeter from the unmarked gland in Kurapika's wrist. Kurapika still doesn't think Chrollo would but he *could.* Kurapika closes his eyes.

Chapter 10

After one gentle kiss, Chrollo’s lips leave Kurapika’s wrist. Kurapika's eyes are still closed when he hears the shuffling of paper. Opening them, he sees Chrollo’s set the art on the unoccupied chair. Before he can ask, Chrollo’s urging Kurapika to sit up on the table.

Kurapika flushes as Chrollo steps between his legs. With his hands still cuffed there's only so much he can do, so Chrollo grabs Kurapika's sweater as he drops heated kisses into Kurapika’s hair. Kurapika’s eyes linger on Chrollo’s throat as the alpha's breath flutters his hair, watching his adam's apple bob as he swallows. It's enticing and there's nothing that restricts him from reaching out to trail his fingers over Chrollo’s pulse and scent gland. Chrollo tips his head to the side, submitting to the touch and resting his cheek on the top of Kurapika’s head.

In this moment, Kurapika can't think of a single reason to not accept the invitation. He extends his arm further, wrapping his hand around the back of Chrollo’s neck to pull him closer. Chrollo bows into him, allowing Kurapika to tuck his face into the alpha's neck and breathe him in deeply. It fills him with a bone-deep comfort that reminds him of having a morning coffee by his little window. It's the feeling of staving off the cold radiating from the window with a steaming mug in his hands and a blanket over his shoulders. Kurapika *doesn't* nest but if he did, he would use that blanket.

Kurapika wishes Chrollo could hold him back. He swallows that thick, sticky desire and the taste lingers in his mouth as he loops his other arm around Chrollo’s neck, keeping him in place a little longer. Kurapika rubs Chrollo’s soft earlobe between his thumb and finger discovering scar tissue left behind from piercings. Chrollo shudder against him as Kurapika caresses the delicate skin. He parts his lips and fits his mouth over Chrollo’s steady pulse to taste that instead.

Chrollo opens his hands to try and touch Kurapika more. For once, Kurapika doesn't shy away from it. He shifts forward to sit at the edge of the table so he's close enough for Chrollo’s palms to press flat against his stomach. Chrollo’s throat rumbles beneath the tip of Kurapika’s tongue as his inner thighs fit around Chrollo’s waist.

Dizzy on Chrollo’s pheromones, Kurapika slowly lifts his head to kiss just beneath Chrollo’s chin. Chrollo moves with him, his lips passing over Kurapika’s brows and down his nose to meet Kurapika’s. Chrollo’s lips are slightly chapped but his mouth is relaxed, easily giving way for the two of them to find how they fit together.

Kurapika’s breath hitches as Chrollo's hands sneak up his sweater to touch his bare stomach. The chains between Chrollo's wrists clatter as he strains to spread his hands further, trying to grasp Kurapika’s waist. A low, heated groan flutters Kurapika’s hair as Chrollo’s fingers sink into the soft flesh. Kurapika arches into the touch, his lingering fears about sharing his body with Chrollo quieted.

Chrollo sighs into the kiss, leaning more of his weight into Kurapika as his hands creep higher. Kurapika's sweater is thick enough to obscure most of his body so beneath it there's nothing stopping Chrollo's fingers from finding Kurapika's breasts.

Their lips part for a few millimeters as Chrollo takes a sharp breath. Kurapika's eyes barely crack open, unconsciously wanting to try and read Chrollo's reaction, but he doesn't get the chance. Without remarking on them, he kisses Kurapika again, fitting his hands over the graceful shape. Kurapika can feel the callouses on Chrollo's thumbs glide over his sensitive skin.

Lockpicking. *"My touch is more refined…"* Chrollo had said.

Kurapika gasps through his nose as Chrollo's thumbs roll over his nipples. It makes Kurapika's skin buzz. Reflexively, his knees dig into Chrollo's sides as he feels a rush of heat tugging just beneath his stomach. Before Kurapika gets too sensitive, Chrollo's hands slide back down his body to the waistband of his pants.

"Lift your hips," Chrollo whispers into Kurapika's mouth.

Although Kurapika's enjoyed telling Chrollo *no* in the past, this time he accepts easily. He plants his feet on the chair behind Chrollo, lifting himself off the table just enough. Even while handcuffed, Chrollo is startlingly swift at pushing down Kurapika's pants and underwear. Kurapika chooses to believe that dexterity comes with being a thief.

He settles his weight on the table again and shivers at the cold. It's not his first time baring himself to another person but it is the first time he's done it outside his home. His cheeks are hot from the embarrassment and they only burn hotter as Chrollo looks down at the tuft of blond hair between his legs.

Automatically, Kurapika's eyes lower, expecting to experience the shape of Chrollo's erection with more than his hands. Before he can get a good look, Chrollo sits in the chair and scoots in close, hiding his lap under the table as he fits his shoulders between Kurapika's legs. Chrollo pulls one of Kurapika's legs up to rest it on his shoulder, making his weight tip back. Kurapika catches himself on his palms and sets his other leg on Chrollo's shoulder to match. He's familiar with this position - being with an alpha is new but this isn't.

Kurapika's always heard that alphas are wild in bed but Chrollo is perfectly tame. Chrollo's always so…

Even temperament, calm presence, low-risk…

Kurapika uses one hand to fist Chrollo's inky bangs, his knuckles against Chrollo's scalp. Chrollo groans, his mouth falling open and his tongue resting heavily on his bottom lip. He presses his face to Kurapika's stomach breathing in deeply through his nose and mouth. Chrollo's groan vibrates against Kurapika's core, making a comforting haze settle over the base of Kurapika's brain. The alpha is radiating with satisfaction so hot it boils away every drop of Kurapika's self-consciousness.

Slick drips down onto the table as Chrollo's trails open-mouthed kisses over his bellybutton and into the crease of his inner thigh. Anticipation makes Kurapika's thighs tremble, only for them to lock up when Chrollo's tongue finally licks along the velvety pink slit, curtained by soft lips. Kurapika trembles and clenches his teeth to hold back a moan as Chrollo fits his mouth over Kurapika's clit to suck it against his tongue. Chrollo looks perfect with his head buried between his legs.

Suddenly, Kurapika has no idea why they haven't spent the past few weeks doing this.

Kurapika brings a hand up to his mouth to muffle himself with his sweater as Chrollo laps him up greedily.

"Ah… *Chrollo…*" he whispers into the knit material.

Kurapika's slick flows more freely than his breathy moans. Chrollo buries his face in deeper and presses his tongue inside like he's determined to swallow every drop. It feels so good that Kurapika digs his heel into Chrollo’s back to lift his hips for more.

It's almost perfect. Just a bit more *inside*. Fingers or… Kurapika's body craves a good stretch to compliment the sweet friction.

Frustration builds alongside the swirling pleasure in his core. Using his tight grip on Chrollo’s hair and his legs for leverage, Kurapika grinds against Chrollo's face. Slick smears over Chrollo’s nose and chin as Kurapika bucks against him roughly. He takes what he wants and Chrollo gives it to him, dark eyes fluttering as he's stifled.

Kurapika bites the sleeve of his sweater to keep quiet as a high keen of pleasure nearly escapes. Despite being empty, his back-arching orgasm has him creaming on Chrollo’s face. His thighs lock around Chrollo’s head, squeezing it tight with the instinctive need to keep his partner's body pressed against his.

Trembling and panting through his nose, Kurapika rides out the waves of pleasure, his cunt pulsing around Chrollo’s tongue. Kurapika's hips continue to rock as he rides out the waves pleasure for several long seconds. When his muscles eventually relax, the buzzing high in his veins still lingers. Chrollo only pulls back enough to gasp for air and distantly Kurapika wonders if he was suffocating him for long. Not that Chrollo seemed to mind.

The placement of his thighs wasn't right to properly choke an alpha anyway.

Chrollo straightens up. With Kurapika’s ankles still hooked over his shoulders, his legs are lifted too. Kurapika stares up, feeling light-headed and delirious with desire as Chrollo licks his lips and chin clean of slick. Just as Kurapika is certain his first time fucking an alpha is going to be with a convict on a prison compound, Chrollo lowers Kurapika's legs and begins fixing his clothes.

"We're short on time," Chrollo whispers.

That brings Kurapika down from his high. He blinks slowly, haze receding.

"… right." Kurapika murmurs, voice hoarse.

Chrollo leans in to give Kurapika one more lingering kiss.

"I look forward to seeing you again." Chrollo breathes.

Kurapika inhales those words.

He can't bring himself to admit he feels the same so he nods silently.

Chrollo helps him sit up and combs his fingers through the back of his hair, easing the tangles. In turn, Kurapika fixes the heavy muzzle back onto Chrollo’s maw. He remains unbitten a week longer.

Kurapika places his cool hands on the back of his neck and takes a deep breath. Carefully, he gets down from the table. He's never been so unsteady outside his heat. Chrollo hovers but Kurapika is done accepting his help. There is no way he's asking Babimyna for an arm so he's going to have to walk out of here on his own.

Kurapika takes the art Chrollo made for him and rolls it up. He holds the crinkling paper to his chest and makes his way to the door, pretending he doesn't feel Chrollo's weighty gaze.

Babimyna escorts him to the security gate and Kurapika is certain that he *knows.*

At the gate, the security guard takes the warped painting to examine it for only a second or two. He scoffs then passes it back to Kurapika.

Kurapika swallows the unexpected surge of aggression that makes him want to snap at the guard. He bites his tongue and leaves, shoulders curled around the paper defensively.

In his dreams that night, Kurapika's back in his old classroom.

It's the end of a peaceful school day and the empty classroom is painted by the sunset. Every child has been safely returned to the caring arms of their guardians and Kurapika is alone.

His hair is longer, just like before, and his ponytail tickles the back of his neck as he moves through the little desks, doing a final check to make sure no beloved toy or stained lunch box was left behind. But really, he's biding his time, waiting for someone. He doesn't know who or why, but he can feel that someone is going to pick him up and take him home. He just has to wait a little longer.

He gets to the front of the classroom and looks at his calendar. He sees a familiar symbol written on it. A radial burst or a mandala of some sort. Only this time, Kurapika feels very sure that it's actually just a poorly drawn spiderweb. The lines of the symbol slowly extend past the day it was drawn on and grow beyond the calendar page to creep onto the wall.

His heart beats with anticipation. It's almost time.

When Kurapika wakes, the shape of the web lingers in his mind. It could just be nonsense from his subconscious but Kurapika's not in the habit of leaving stones unturned. The symbol that was carved into the doorframe of 13th Street Printing company could be a poor attempt at drawing a lot of things, including a spiderweb.

So Kurapika begins his search for any gangs that are known for spider symbolism. Chrollo might not call his group a gang, but Kurapika's spent enough time around them to know better. A tight-knit group of criminals with a power structure - Chrollo can use whatever nice words he wants but those are the facts.

Kurapika doesn't find any official media statements about it so he turns to online forums. Buried deep in the logs, he finds rumors about a group utilizing the symbol of a spider with twelve legs. The rumors don't say where the group is based, but with the context he can gleam off the posts he's pretty sure the rumors are from this region.

Kurapika closes his eyes and tries to remember exactly how many lines he saw on that radial carving. He hadn't counted so he can't be certain.

But spiders do fit Chrollo's style.

It shouldn't matter. Kurapika should be planning for the upcoming ice-cream social. Even so, his mind keeps wandering to rumors of the Spiders over the next several days, turning over each forum post in his mind obsessively. The Spiders are ruthless, they're thieves, they give money to under-served communities, they're unstoppable, they're nothing special… Kurapika doesn't know what to believe. He

wants to ask Chrollo or he wants Chrollo to send him to 13th Street with another message so he has an excuse to count the lines on that stupid symbol.

13th Street Printing Company… Twelve-legged spider... Maybe that means something…

"You're in your head too much," Izunavi says as Kurapika fumbles through a move.

It's a simple technique and they both know Kurapika shouldn't be screwing it up. Class starts in fifteen minutes and he should be able to do this.

"I know," Kurapika sighs, peeling himself off the mat.

"… You're seein' someone, right? Is it about that?" Izunavi asks.

Of course Izunavi was going to notice the pheromones clinging to Kurapika eventually. Especially now that they're doing more than sharing their scents.

"It's complicated," Kurapika replies.

He doesn't want to talk about it. There's too much he can't say. Even if he could tell Izunavi everything, it's too much of a mess for him to sort out.

"Alright…" Izunavi lifts his guard, settling into a stance. "Three minute spar and it'll get simple enough."

It's been a long time since Kurapika fought seriously. For months he's just been running simple drills for beginners. He should sharpen up before things in the prison get serious.

Kurapika nods and settles into his stance. For the next three minutes, Kurapika proves to himself that he hasn't lost his ferocity.

"It's exciting isn't it?" Eliza chatters with Kurapika before his next appointment with Chrollo. "They're going to let us have ice-cream in the office too."

"Yeah," Squala leans back in his chair to join in the conversation with a smile.

He's not looking at his monitors at all. He only has eyes for pretty, friendly, social Eliza.

"What are your favorite toppings? Let's make some requests." Squala asks Eliza, obviously just wanting to know what candy she likes.

For Squala and Eliza, the ice-cream social is just going to be a little office party. They won't be attending the accompanying *social* event with the volunteers, prisoners, counselors, and guards. How nice for them.

"I love anything with milk chocolate!" Eliza chirps.

Kurapika smiles sweetly with her.

"Me too," he lies.

While they chat, Kastro arrives for his shift, bidding Squala a good-morning.

"Is this the party-planning committee?" Kastro teases good-naturedly.

"Oh, ah, no sir." Eliza says demurely. "We're just a little excited."

"Glad to hear it," Kastro replies.

He takes another step towards his office. Before he can take on the roll of counselor for the day, Kurapika pipes up.

"Excited and a bit nervous," Kurapika says.

Kastro stops, his hand hovering over the door to his office. He looks back over his shoulder.

"Nervous?" Kastro prods.

"Just a little," Kurapika says with a small, polite smile painted on. "I'm excited to meet the other volunteers but a nervous to be around all those alphas. I know I'm being a bit silly, because you vet them all."

And yet, Tserracnich is in the program, despite being a heinous, bigoted monster.

"They're not *violent,* right?"

"Ah…"

Kastro glances between Eliza and Squala before continuing.

"Well, it's not top secret information, we just generally don't discuss the details. The basic risk assessment for the program is not simply a matter of their past actions. A lot of charges could be argued as having violent undertones, including things like destruction of property, and we want to work towards rehabilitating as many inmates as possible." Kastro explains.

Kurapika nods, keeping his expression polite and understanding. He *does* understand what Kastro is saying. Violence can look like a lot of things. Even if they were to limit the eligible inmates to those who have no record of causing bodily harm to others both before and after their detainment, it would cut out a lot of alphas who are learning to change and include a lot of vile, emotionally manipulative alphas. The lines that are drawn can't be so rigid.

Though those lines should have still cut around Tserracnich.

"The screening process is more about being receptive to therapy and whether or not they have the self-control to not attempt to attack an omega while they know they are being monitored."

As ridiculous as it may seem to attack someone under these circumstances, not everyone is capable of making rational decisions. Kurapika isn't intending to behave any differently once he gets alone with Tserracnich. He's only rational enough to premeditate it.

"Oh, but we're a lot more rigorous for the private room screening." Kastro adds quickly. "Different situations call for different levels of caution, of course."

"Of course," Kurapika echos. "… I'm sure it'll be fine."

Kastro disappears into his office with a wave and Kurapika rejoins Babimyna in the hall to go to his appointment, stopping at the vending machine on the way. Babimyna is silent this time.

Kurapika finds that he doesn't feel much awkwardness about going to Chrollo now that their partnership is both practical and sexual. There was a time he thinks he would have felt strange about it, but he's too tired for that now. There are so many things competing for his attention, not the least of which being whether or not Chrollo is the boss of this spectral group that refer to themselves as Spiders. And none of that should matter as much as Kurapika's mission.

Chrollo is waiting for him in the room, looking very relaxed at the table with his back to the door. He doesn't bother to turn as Kurapika steps inside and shuts the door.

There's no tension in his body as Kurapika approaches him from behind and reaches over his shoulder to set coffee and the candy bar in front of him. It's as if Chrollo's sitting at his kitchen table enjoying a lazy morning. Wordlessly, Kurapika unlocks Chrollo's muzzle without making any demands.

"Eliza wants milk chocolate for the ice-cream social," Kurapika says innocuously.

Once the muzzle rolls off his fingers and onto the table, it feels like they can both pretend things are innocuous.

"Oh? That's nice. I hope she gets it. She works very hard." Chrollo replies smoothly.

Chrollo's hands slide across the table to grab the mug of coffee, his cuffs scratching their strange daydream of normalcy without shattering it.

"Mm," Kurapika hums in mild agreement.

He allows his hands to rest on Chrollo's upper back for a moment, feeling the way his body expands as he inhales the steam before taking a drink.

"What do you want for the party?" Chrollo asks.

Kurapika stares as the back of Chrollo's head. His hair is dry from whatever passes for shampoo in the prison and the straps of the muzzle have left a dent in it.

In reality, he wants Tserracnich dead for the party. If it was a nice, normal ice-cream party then…

"… I like toasted peanuts." Kurapika says.

He lets his hands fall from Chrollo, dropping the illusion with them. He walks over to take a seat. He meets Chrollo's dark, empty eyes that are never as warm as his voice or touch. He looks as contemplative as Kurapika has felt these last few days.

"What's on your mind?" Kurapika prods, knowing that he wouldn't respond honestly if Chrollo decided to turn the question on him.

"Some things the other alphas were saying," Chrollo says, sounding quiet serious.

Kurapika allows the silence to hang for a beat, inviting Chrollo to elaborate. Fortunately, Chrollo seems to want to talk about it without any tricks.

"…… Please don't start shaving on my account."

This time, Kurapika's lack of response is because he's stunned. Chrollo spoke clearly but Kurapika almost doubts he's heard him right.

"I- Huh? Okay?" Kurapika stutters.

Simultaneously, he's baffled and relieved it wasn't as important as he feared.

Chrollo's face smooths back into neutrality and he lets out a breath. Like it was really, actually worrying him.

Embarrassment stings Kurapika's face and he tilts his head into his hand to rub his temple. Just when he's starting to think he can follow what's going on in Chrollo's mind, he's reminded how truly baffling the man is.

"Are you *telling* them about me?" Kurapika asks.

It would be embarrassing and completely inappropriate… but it also wouldn't matter, functionally. It's another thing Kurapika *shouldn't* care about.

"No, I just heard them talking about how their omegas have shaved or waxed for them. Like it's a boon." Chrollo says, sounding morose.

Kurapika takes a measured breath and drops his hands flat on the table.

"I'm done with this conversation." He declares.

He would rather not think about whether or not the other omegas in the program are following the latest trends in porn for their alphas. In Kurapika's opinion, taking off any clothing for an alpha is doing more than enough to cater to them anyway.

It doesn't matter. In two weeks he's going to see Tserracnich. He has to stay focused.

Chapter 11

After wiping down all the tables Kurapika makes his way around the bar for a second time to fill all the napkin holders. No matter how many menial tasks Kurapika finds, it isn't enough to calm his nerves. He wishes Melody was performing tonight. She recently booked a gig for a ritzy, high-rise restaurant in upper Yorknew. She deserves it… It's just that hearing her sing always helps Kurapika clear his head.

Yesterday when he was helping her pick out a sleek dress for her show, she helped him decide what to wear for the cursed ice-cream social. However he dresses around Chrollo is irrelevant, but it's important that he catches Tserracnich's eye. After that, they sat together and went through the breathing exercises she does to calm herself before an important show. Kurapika has tried to do them a few times during his shift but halfway through each attempt he thinks of a new task to do instead.

Refilling the salt shakers seems like a good thing to do after he finishes with the napkins.

In a blink, it's the final week before the ice-cream social and Kurapika's at his next appointment with Chrollo . He doesn't even remember the smalltalk Babimyna was trying to engage him in on the short walk to the private room. He feels like he should be using this time to prepare more to meet Tserracnich, but he doesn't know how.

"Relax," Chrollo urges Kurapika over to the couch with a tap on his elbow. "You're just going to try to match with him like you did the first time. Except it'll be easier because you'll be able to see his face."

But they both know that the first time Kurapika tried to match with Tserracnich he was just as tense. It's why he earned himself the label *"sensitive."*

Kurapika takes a slow, uneven breath.

"But I should still… I still need to…"

Kurapika's wheels spin without getting any traction.

"You always think that."

They sit with their shoulders pressed together and Chrollo's muzzle bumps against Kurapika's temple.

"If everything goes as it should, we won't have this time together anymore." Chrollo says.

There's no comfort in Chrollo's words - just simple truth - and that makes all of the tension seep out of Kurapika's body. Right from the start, they both knew Kurapika was going to exchange Chrollo for the worst alpha he could imagine. Soon, he's going to carry vengeance forward for the both of them. But it would be nice if he could have Chrollo too.

"I never thought that I would find anyone to talk to in this program." Kurapika admits.

"I feel the same way," Chrollo replies.

The muzzle key rests in Kurapika’s open palm. He gave up on trying to be coy with it a while ago. The muzzle clatters to the floor while Chrollo surges for Kurapika’s neck.

Even as the alpha's damp lips part and the edge of his teeth scrape just beneath Kurapika's scent-blocking patch, Kurapika doesn't feel any fear with Chrollo. He tilts his head to the side and Chrollo’s hands urge him to keep going, tipping him back onto the loveseat. Chrollo props himself up with one knee on the cushions between Kurapika's legs, causing the couch to dip towards him.

There's the faint pressure of Chrollo's fangs but they never breach Kurapika's skin. It's just enough to give Kurapika a twinge of excitement that is coaxed into a simmer of arousal with Chrollo's tongue soothing over the scraped skin.

Kurapika closes his eyes to block out the harsh ceiling lights as he shares this final moment of intimacy with Chrollo. All he feels is his hair clinging to the stiff, pleather fabric on the arm of the couch and Chrollo's splayed hands trailing down the front of his body. He takes a slow, meditative breath in that Melody would be proud of except he's filling his lungs with Chrollo's pheromones. As he exhales, Chrollo's parted lips fit over his to take in some of his breath. Beneath his eyelids, Kurapika's eyes flicker like he's dreaming as he remembers that they will carry pieces of each other when this has to end.

Kurapika loops his arms around Chrollo's neck and dips his tongue into Chrollo's mouth to feel the edges of his teeth again. As they kiss, Chrollo sinks enough of his weight into Kurapika to let him feel his erection against his thigh. A low hum of pleasure passes between them as Chrollo sucks on his bottom lip and. In reply, Kurapika lifts his leg to give Chrollo more room, hooking his ankle over the back of the couch.

Chrollo pulls back to nuzzle and kiss Kurapika's cheek and his slides his hands up Kurapika's sweater. Kurapika shivers as the metal cuffs ghost over his skin as Chrollo pushes up far enough to reveal his chest. Then, Chrollo lowers himself to cradle and kiss Kurapika's chest as tenderly as he did with Kurapika's throat. Chrollo is able to spread his hands just far enough for his fingers to caress Kurapika's nipples as he drags his tongue between the valley of his breasts. Kurapika bites his bottom lip at the heat that pours down from his mind into his body.

The tip of Chrollo's nose presses into the flesh on the inside of Kurapika's left breast as he latches onto the skin and sucks it between his teeth. Chrollo is making a small, easy to hide mark. It isn't anything permanent and will most likely fade in a few days. Still, Chrollo is leaving some sort of mark on Kurapika. It makes him feel lightheaded as the river of pleasure has started to rush so fast that it soaks his underwear.

There's a change in the light and Kurapika opens his eyes to find Chrollo is looming over him. In Chrollo’s shadow, Kurapika lets himself forget where he is and why he's been coming here. His black, vacuous eyes swallow up all the light in the room.

It feels good to forget.

Kurapika lifts his hips to shift down his pants and underwear, kicking them to the floor and knocking the muzzle further away in the process. At the same time, Chrollo works open the knot in his pants to free his erection. Kurapika looks down to finally see it and his mouth relaxes. There's nothing too surprising about it. It's as well-groomed as the rest of Chrollo and flushed with a healthy shade of arousal. The curve of it is similar to the vibrator Kurapika likes and it's just a bit larger. He doesn't have to look at it for long to find a vein running down the shaft. It reminds him of the one in Chrollo's wrists that he's been familiar with since their first, faceless meeting.

While Kurapika's head is downturned, Chrollo trails his lips along the shell of his ear to the stud in his earlobe. Absentmindedly, Kurapika combs his fingers through Chrollo's hair and caresses the angle of his jaw as he watches Chrollo run his fingers along his pubic mound to find his clit. A small moan slips past Kurapika's lips at the light, circular motions Chrollo makes with his fingers. He was already wet and the friction makes Kurapika's core tighten.

Chrollo's fingers slide along the soaking folds of Kurapika's labia and he dips two inside. With how much Kurapika wants it, Chrollo's fingers sink in easily and they only make Kurapika want more. Kurapika breathes in time with the steady thrusts of Chrollo's fingers as he pumps them in deeper and gradually spreads them until Kurapika loses his patience. He lowers a hand to wave Chrollo's out of the way so he can grab the base of the alpha's cock. Chrollo nips at Kurapika's ear but doesn't tease him. Chrollo is more conscious of their time than Kurapika is, so he wouldn't argue in favor of wasting it.

Chrollo shifts closer, taking care to balance with his cuffed hands on the arm of the couch. Since Chrollo can't do more than one thing at a time with his hands, Kurapika angles the length to press the glistening tip to his entrance just like he would with his vibrator. Still, it's not the same as using a toy. The touch of raw, hot skin makes Kurapika gasp and his heart skip a beat.

Chrollo’s lax mouth drags across Kurapika's cheek to press a damp kiss of the corner of his lips. Their breath mingles, enticing them to slot their lips together again just as Chrollo presses inside. Kurapika's eyes fall shut once more to focus on Chrollo sinking in deeper and deeper until their hips are flush. His chest aches at the satisfying stretch.

Kurapika fists the coarse material of Chrollo's shirt as they move together. The push and pull of their bodies feels as natural as kissing. In a few rolling thrusts, Kurapika's legs have wound themselves around Chrollo's waist with the desire to engulf him even more. Moans seep through the seams of their kissing as Kurapika's slick leaks out and smears between them. With every thrust, the head of Chrollo's cock rubs against the spot that make Kurapika's faint voice pitch up and his muscles clench. In turn, Chrollo's arms tremble from the mounting intensity and he sinks more of his weight into Kurapika.

"Chrollo," Kurapika whispers desperately into Chrollo's mouth when he knows he's right at the edge.

He yanks on Chrollo's shirt, pulling him closer to tell him without words that he *needs* Chrollo against him. Kurapika needs Chrollo to smother his sounds, keep him grounded, and fill him as deeply as possible.

In an instant, Chrollo's kiss turns from passionate to oppressive.

Kurapika tumbles over the edge into orgasm and Chrollo swallows up his moans. The waves of pleasure roll through him in pulses that have him tightening up around Chrollo's cock and soaking his lap. Chrollo cums with Kurapika and the moans that spill into him have of the same desperation Kurapika saw when he spat in Chrollo's mouth.

But no matter how viciously Kurapika pulls on Chrollo's clothing, he won't thrust in the final centimeters to knot Kurapika.

Kurapika whimpers in frustration, brows furrowing. He can feel Chrollo's length throbbing with pulse after pulse of cum that shoots inside but he won't knot him.

In moments, Kurapika's high fades and they can control themselves enough to break the kiss while staying quiet. As Kurapika gasps for air, he looks down to see Chrollo's knot. It's swollen and soaked in Kurapika's slick, pressed against the outside of his pussy. Chrollo grips the arm of the couch so tight that the pleather creaks as he slowly pulls out. Cum is still drooling and clinging to the matted, blond hair between Kurapika's legs.

He looks back up to Chrollo's face - his head is hanging between his shoulders. His eyes are screwed shut and his expression is tight with focus as he breathes through his instinct to knot Kurapika.

Kurapika is disappointed too, but he knows he shouldn't be. This is for the best.

Kurapika cradles Chrollo's tense jaw in both hands and gives him a doting kiss on the forehead. That's enough to smooth out Chrollo's face into something more at-ease. He lets go of the couch and opens his eyes to meet Kurapika's. In the blackness of Chrollo's eyes, Kurapika finds a deep, peaceful silence. Chrollo shares in Kurapika's long gaze and whatever it is he sees, he's clearly just as reluctant to look away.

There isn't much they can do about the mess. Kurapika has no choice but to pull up his underwear and deal with the fact that he's going to be leaking alpha cum until he can get to a bathroom to sort himself out. As for Chrollo, his shirt is long enough to cover most of the wet spot Kurapika leaked onto the waistband of his pants, but that's about it. They're both a disaster.

They stand up to quickly fix their hair and clothing as much as possible. Kurapika's cheeks burn as he already feels some cum and slick starting to leak out. He'll have to get home quickly.

Kurapika bites his lip as he pets Chrollo's shirt, fussing over the extremely obvious wrinkles he left in it by gripping it so tight. He can't smooth them out so he just uselessly rubs Chrollo's chest for a few seconds while Chrollo watches with silent amusement.

With a huff, Kurapika gives up and grabs the muzzle to lock Chrollo back up before they leave. As Kurapika is turning away from Chrollo, he catches Kurapika by his belt loop.

"One more thing…"

Chrollo tugs on Kurapika's pants to slip a neatly folded wrapper into the elastic of his underwear. Even after all this time that feels rude. Kurapika glares up at Chrollo.

"Please," Chrollo adds pleasantly.

There's no need for Kurapika to voice his agreement. Of course he'll bring it to Chrollo’s gang and he'll take a more careful look at the symbol on the door and the members while he's at it.

Kurapika leaves the room knowing that his kiss-swollen lips are the least of his worries. Babimyna offers to escort Kurapika to the bathroom and he's in no position to refuse but the fact that Babimyna knew to offer is damning. He rushes inside to try and make himself marginally more presentable before he has to go through security.

At least while he's like this the only secret they'll think he's trying to hide is being fucked by a felon and not the information he's bringing to the felon's gang.

Before doing anything else, Kurapika goes straight home to shower. That stop in the bathroom allowed him to clean up the worst of it but there was even *more* cum that started leaking out while he was riding the bus. No matter how good Chrollo is, there's no changing the fact that alphas really are the least convenient intimate partners.

Kurapika rushes up the stairs to his unit in record time and throws off his clothes before he's even shut himself in the bathroom. As he's reaching for the shower curtain, he catches sight of himself in the mirror and pauses. On his chest right over his heart is the bright, red mark Chrollo left.

Frustration and embarrassment are wiped from Kurapika's mind and nothing takes their place. Having no idea what to think or feel, Kurapika stares at the mark for several lingering seconds.

A drop of cum rolling down his thigh snaps Kurapika out of it and he jumps into the shower. Having sex with an alpha is so messy and annoying and if Kurapika ever gets the chance to fuck Chrollo again he's going to demand that Chrollo just *knot* him.

That night, Kurapika returns to the thieves' hideout with the wrapper in his pocket. As always, he looked it over and couldn't figure out exactly what it meant. The message on the wrapper is formatted like a bible verse, but it isn't a *real* bible verse. Chrollo did mention growing up in a church-run orphanage but it's interesting that the other members of his group would be savvy to the same themes. Not for the first time, Kurapika wonders how long the members of the group have known each other.

With his hand poised to knock, Kurapika takes in the symbol on the doorframe again. Radiating from the center of the symbol are twelve lines, just as he suspected.

He knocks on the door and is let inside without scrutiny.

The next day, Kurapika receives a call from Eliza and she explains to him the procedure for the party. Groups of couples are being given different arrival times so there won't be a pileup of omegas and alpha inmates showing up at once, which could be overwhelming for the guards and the security check-in. Kurapika and Chrollo are in the second wave of arrivals but Eliza assures Kurapika that they'll still have plenty of time to enjoy the party and meet everyone.

The day of the ice-cream social is a cold, grey afternoon in Yorknew. Traffic is normal and the weather is expected for this time of year. Not a single act of divine intervention happens to make Kurapika miss his assigned arrival time for the party.

When he gets to the prison there are two omegas with yellow lanyards ahead of him passing through security. One is a small, plump man with crooked glasses who is smiling at everyone. The other is a petite woman with mousy brown hair tied into a low bun and she won't take her eyes off the floor. When the omega male notices his arrival, he looks over his shoulder to greet Kurapika with a little wave and Kurapika responds with a nod of acknowledgement. Chrollo speculated that all of the omegas in the program are crazy, but Kurapika isn't concerned about that.

On the other side of the check-in is Babimyna, waiting to escort Kurapika and the other omegas to a new area of the building. It's further back than Kurapika is used to going but the building is compact so it doesn't take long for them to reach the small group of omegas and alphas who are waiting outside a conference room. In this hallway there are four guards, two stationed by the conference room door and two at the end of the group.

The energy in the hallway is strained, but not as strained as Kurapika. The guards are watching them all carefully but they aren't doing anything to segregate the milling crowd. Omegas are already moving towards the alphas they are familiar and talking in low voices so Kurapika and the omegas he arrived with do the same. The meek woman shuffles over to a friendly-looking alpha with buzzed-short hair and the man with glasses joins a tall, broad alpha with curly, brown hair.

Kurapika passes through the couples to join Chrollo, who's eyes have been on him since he entered the hall.

"You look nice," Chrollo remarks, taking notice of the berry-red sweater and slacks Melody picked out.

"Thank you," Kurapika replies stiffly.

Kurapika has no idea if Tserracnich is already inside the room or if he's scheduled to arrive with the next group, but Kurapika can already feel an evil aura emanating from the door. He stares ahead, expecting to see nothing but fire and brimstone and melted ice-cream when it opens.

Then, Chrollo lowers his head to speak to Kurapika in a low voice.

"Don't think about it too much. Where did you actually study?" Chrollo asks, trying to distract Kurapika from what lies ahead so he'll relax.

It won't work this time. Kurapika stands perfectly still, breathing slow and deep as his stomach churns.

"A local community college downtown," Kurapika replies softly.

"Did you like it?"

"I liked it. It was normal, I think. There were good things and bad things - I was lucky to have a few great professors."

"That's nice," Chrollo's hums. "What was - "

Before Chrollo can ask another question, the door opens and Kastro comes out into the hall to address the group waiting to enter.

"Welcome everyone. The tables for ice-cream are set up in the far side of the room and there's plenty for everyone so go in an orderly fashion." Kastro explains pleasantly.

"It's very important to remember that just because you have an assigned omega doesn't mean you own them." He continues, addressing just the alphas in a slow, deliberate tone. "It isn't appropriate to get possessive in mixed company. Remember that this is a friendly, social gathering."

Murmurs of understanding ripple through the crowd and they sort themselves out into a semblance of order to enter. Kurapika and Chrollo stand behind the omega with glasses and his large alpha companion to shuffle in slowly.

"Just stay calm and remember: you're beautiful and you don't want him. It's the same way you always seduce men" Chrollo whispers encouragingly.

"I'm not in the mood for jokes," Kurapika hisses back.

Chrollo's eyes crinkle but he doesn't say anything. He squares his shoulders and looks straight ahead.

They step into the conference room and Kurapika finds the monster immediately. He knew he would.

His heart stops. He can't breathe.

Next to Kurapika, Chrollo is having his muzzle removed by one of the guards so he can eat, but Kurapika's only distantly aware of that. All of his focus is on Tserracnich, standing tall near the center of the room holding a bowl of ice-cream. The last time they were in a room together, it was a courtroom.

Despite looking less refined than he did in the during the trial, Tserracnich's sandy, shaggy hair and a hint of stubble are almost exactly as Kurapika remembers. Back then, Kurapika was dressed in black and his hair was long, hanging over his shoulders and spilling down his chest. Tserracnich hadn't looked at Kurapika during the trial - he barely even spared a glance at Parrio's parents. Kurapika had forced himself to look at Tserracnich through bleary, red-rimmed eyes so he would remember his face.

Kurapika hates him. *Hates* him.

Tserracnich is standing next to a cute, young omega woman with frosty, blonde hair wearing a knee-length dress with thick stocking and fuzzy winter boots. Tserracnich looks entirely indifferent to her presence so she is probably Juno.

Surreptitiously, Chrollo taps Kurapika's heel with his foot, and Kurapika finally breathes. Chrollo's muzzle is off and laying in a bin by the door so they have to keep walking.

Kurapika steels himself. He has to be strong and stick to the plan. He's isn't supposed to know or care about Tserracnich.

Kurapika and Chrollo walk deeper into the room, getting closer and closer to the monster inside. Kurapika matches Chrollo's pace - they're simply going to move past Tserracnich. It doesn't take long for

them to get close enough for Tserracnich's pheromones to make Kurapika's nose tingle. Kurapika controls the urge to wrinkle his nose at the sharp, bright scent that makes saliva gather under the sides of his tongue like he's just tasted something acidic. It's not disgusting, but it's strange.

As Kurapika steps past him, Tserracnich lifts his gaze. It feels as though time has slowed as the monster sets his sights on him. Tserracnich's mouth parts and he breathes, taking in Kurapika's scent. He wishes he could rip it back out of Tserracnich's lungs.

Then Kurapika and Chrollo get to the end of the line for ice-cream and Chrollo passes him a styrofoam bowl.

"What flavor do you want?" Chrollo asks him sweetly.

Kurapika already knew that Chrollo was capable of acting charming at-will, but he's *so good* at it that it's startling. Especially when Kurapika knows Chrollo hates Tserracnich's guts too.

"I-"

Suddenly, Kurapika doesn't even know what ice-cream even is.

"Here," Chrollo cradles the back of Kurapika's hands to hold them steady and drops a scoop of vanilla ice-cream on his bowl. "Milk chocolate isn't your favorite, right?"

Kurapika stares into the bowl, his heart in his ears while Chrollo helps himself to some toppings then sprinkle some roasted peanuts onto Kurapika's vanilla ice-cream. He feels like throwing up.

"Whoops. I don't think he likes that I'm serving you," Chrollo whispers with barely-concealed amusement. "At least we have his attention."

Kurapika glances up through his bangs to see Tserracnich looking down his nose at them. Meanwhile, Chrollo continues to guide them through the line and they end up mingling with the mousy little omega and the buzz-cut alpha. The alpha talks eagerly about the party, leaning into the nervous woman who at least seems comfortable with her partner. Kurapika keeps one eye on Tserracnich the whole time, watching as Juno fruitlessly tries to keep his interest.

Eventually, the little conference room gets smaller as the third wave of program participants arrives, making it seem more natural for Kurapika and Chrollo to drift closer to Tserracnich and Juno. Tserracnich is talking at Juno and a few other alphas, saying something about how "being a leader is an immutable identity."

"Insufferable," Chrollo murmurs just before they slip into Tserracnich's orbit.

Tserracnich talks more, his tone self-assured and his body language radiating confidence. Watching him talk, Kurapika tries to form a plan to get him alone without doing something that makes him seem *"easy"* in the way Tserracnich sees Juno. He's in agreement with Chrollo that being too friendly or fawning would be mistakes. What Tserracnich likes best is feeling dominant and while acting like a doormat may seem like the right strategy, Tserracnich is also a violent sadist. He won't be interested in wet clay, he'll be interested in metal that he gets to hammer at for a while.

Kurapika finally looks away from Tserracnich to glance around the room. There are guards stationed in each corner, watching, and there are counselors mingling with the couples. His gaze catches on Kaiser, standing with a group near the door silently and holding a bowl of steadily melting, untouched chocolate

ice-cream with marshmallows piled on top. Melody likes marshmallows in her hot chocolate. Kurapika should try to breathe the way she showed him - it'll help.

"- what do you think?"

Tserracnich's voice cuts through Kurapika’s thoughts, making his eyes snap back to him. Tserracnich is looking at him expectantly. Kurapika wonders if it's because he stopped paying attention while the alpha was speaking. It's ridiculous for Tserracnich to expect so many people to listen to him bend philosophical theories to fit with his egotistical worldview for so long. Kurapika really hates him.

The teasing advice Chrollo gave Kurapika scratches at he base of his brain, but he'll have to be careful not go too far.

"… I don't think I need to consider your cruel sophistry." Kurapika replies, trying so hard to cover his disgust that he sounds completely deadpan.

Their group falls silent and Chrollo smiles more widely than Kurapika thought he was capable of. Maybe that means he went too far.

Chapter 12

Chrollo jumps into the interrupted flow of Tserracnich's lecture. He gets Juno's attention by leaning over to her to ask about her statement necklace and matching earrings. Juno brightens immediately and takes the opportunity to finally talk about herself. Chrollo isn't as tall or broad as Tserracnich, but he's far more handsome and engaging.

Wife-swapping.

The attention of the other people in their gaggle is split as they glance between Chrollo and Juno's light conversation and the tension between Kurapika and Tserracnich. Tserracnich's no more interested in Juno talking about what her sister makes for craft fairs now than he was ten seconds ago so his attention stays fixed on Kurapika.

"… Rude bitches like you always have a short shelf-life. I wonder how long it'll take you to degrade." Tserracnich replies with the tone of a casual remark.

The only indication that Chrollo’s still listening to their conversation is the subtle twitch of his fingers against his spoon. Kurapika’s mouth tightens as he suppresses the need to scream in Tserracnich's face. As if being a bitch is anywhere near the level of Tserracnich's sins. Kurapika's fear and his rage are a tangled mess that's growing by the second - threatening to spill out of every pore.

Kurapika turns his nose up at Tserracnich but otherwise stays very still, like if he moves too much he'll break the surface tension that's holding his blood-red hatred together.

"Your dominance is obviously low-class," Kurapika replies hotly.

He knows that Tserracnich is the richest person in this room and proud of it. Maybe this way, he can goad Tserracnich into thinking he's of the same ilk.

Tserracnich laughs. "If you only bare your neck for blue-blood it's no wonder you haven't been tamed. Being paired up with that and all."

Tserracnich jerks his head towards Chrollo. For the first time, Kurapika wonders what Tserracnich knows of the thief. Chrollo's been watching Tserracnich because they're hunting him and Kurapika had assumed that Tserracnich wouldn't care about anyone else enough to notice him. But what if that's wrong?

Deciding it won't change things, Kurapika shakes off the idea. It could also be that Tserracnich merely assumes everyone is a peasant compared to him and has no real knowledge of Chrollo as an individual.

Kurapika steps away from the group rather than giving Tserracnich a response and dumps his untouched ice-cream into a trashcan. Taking a moment to himself, Kurapika breathes in deeply and tries to decide what to do next. He definitely has Tserracnich's attention, that much is clear, but how can he ensure that Tserracnich will ask for him as a partner… Perhaps he could directly challenge Tserracnich's assumption that he could tame Kurapika, but maybe that would read as too flirtatious and desperate.

A hand materializes from beyond Kurapika's consciousness. He nearly jumps out of his skin and turns to see Chrollo looming over his shoulder.

"It's going well," Chrollo assures him. "I left him with Juno and a few others but he's still staring at you."

Kurapika swallows but he doesn't turn to check. He'll just have to trust Chrollo.

"I'll try to keep people off you two as much as possible. But trust me - you're irresistibly vicious."

Kurapika's brow twitches and he closes his eyes. He's starting to worry he's trusting Chrollo's masochistic streak too much.

"… Don't drool on me," He mutters.

"No promises," Chrollo replies.

Kurapika can't help smiling to himself. He really is going to miss Chrollo.

He smacks Chrollo's hand off like he can't stand his touch and stalks away. Though Chrollo's encouragement helped, Kurapika decides he's going to take a quick bathroom break to try Melody's breathing techniques one more time before returning to his performance. Near the door to the hallway is a set of all-gender bathrooms and Kurapika quickly picks one to duck into.

Inside are two stalls and one is occupied but Kurapika doesn't linger on that. He goes to the sink and wets a paper towel, pressing it to the back of his neck to try and cool some of his simmering rage while taking care not to get his scent patches wet. He looks at himself in the mirror and is relieved by how normal he appears. His face is a little flushed from the adrenaline but he looks more clear-minded than he feels.

Behind him, the stall opens and an alpha Kurapika doesn't recognize steps out. He gives Kurapika a wide birth as he goes to wash his hands for far too little time. His body language makes it seem like he's worried about how lingering around an omega in private might be interpreted. It's both thoughtful and a little offensive.

The alpha rushes out as Kurapika fixes his bangs and tucks the strands of hair that frame his face behind his ears to show off the nice rubies dangling from them - the most expensive thing he owns and a gift from Izunavi. He hopes they'll pass for a casual choice and seeing them is another reminder for him to stay strong.

The door to the bathroom swings open again and glancing towards it is more of an automatic reaction than a decision. Seeing who it is, Kurapika freezes with his hands still in his hair. Tserracnich locks eyes with him and Kurapika is not naive enough to think that this is a coincidence.

"Your alpha was just whining to my omega about how you're losing interest in him…" Tserracnich drawls.

Whether that's a lie Chrollo is telling or a lie Tserracnich is making up to drive a wedge between them, this is good. It's an easy path forward. But Kurapika can't find the words to capitalize it as Tserracnich prowls towards him. Trapped in Tserracnich's gaze, Kurapika feels frozen in time.

"Of course you would. That man barely counts as an alpha anyway," Tserracnich continues, since an omega's words barely matter to him anyway.

Tserracnich joins Kurapika in the mirror. Looking at their shared reflection makes Kurapika aware that his hands are still hovering on either side of his face. Nothing about his shock is a passable performance at all. Slowly, Kurapika lowers his hands to grip the edge of the sink. The sight of Tserracnich standing over his shoulder makes hair on the back of Kurapika's neck bristle. His vision narrows and he becomes achingly aware of every shallow breath.

It's a nightmare and Kurapika is terrified that if he looks down into the sink he'll see Pario's head, floating in a pool of bleach with his brown hair clogging the drain.

"So you'll leave him, naturally. It's just biology. That's why it doesn't matter how I speak to you, nor you to me."

Tserracnich moves a hand up to trace Kurapika's jaw. Kurapika's knees buckle as a dizzying wave of nausea nearly makes him sick. A cold sweat rushes over him and he's forced to acknowledge that his original plan to match with and seduce Tserracnich on his first try would have never worked. He can't pretend. He really, really can't.

Tserracnich either doesn't notice or doesn't care about the discomfort that's seized Kurapika's body. He just keeps speaking at him. Kurapika wonders if Tserracnich spoke to his victims in the same way. Or perhaps he never spoke to them at all and merely instructed the other members of the exploitation ring on what to do using this tone.

"You have a rather unique face. The shape of your eyes is quite striking…" Tserracnich remarks with a semblance of thoughtfulness. "I wonder what lineage you are a princess of. Good genetics, and you seem healthy and bright… Not a bad candidate to carry my down-line."

Tserracnich lowers his hand to trail his fingers down the yellow omega lanyard. He lets the cord slide through his fingers for a few centimeters before tightening his grip to tug on it.

Every time Kurapika's ever gone alone into a room with Chrollo, Babimyna always reminds Kurapika that he can call for him.

Kurapika sees red. He's not the one who's at risk of being another one of Tserracnich's victims. He's not the one who is going to need to call for help.

In one silent motion, Kurapika seizes Tserracnich's wrist and ducks out from under his lanyard. Through the haze of adrenaline, Kurapika has never executed a faster take-down in his life by kicking out Tserracnich's knees. Tserracnich hisses through his teeth in pain as he drops. Although Tserracnich's caught off-guard but he has nearly as much reason to keep quiet as Kurapika does.

He grabs the front of Kurapika's sweater to pull him down. Kurapika's feet slip on the tile as he's yanked forward faster than he expected because Tserracnich is *strong*. The moment he's on the floor with Tserracnich, the alpha grabs his jaw and digs his fingers into the joints hard enough to nearly make Kurapika yelp in pain.

"You *stupid* - "

Kurapika strikes up with his palm, hitting the bottom of Tserracnich's nose. Blood bursts over Kurapika's hand but he's more concerned with making sure he covers Tserracnich's mouth to muffle him. Beneath Kurapika's palm, slick with blood, he can feel Tserracnich's lips pulling back like the alpha's about to try and sink his fangs into Kurapika's wrist.

Even a broken nose is not enough to make Tserracnich lose his grip on Kurapika's jaw, but it does loosen. Years of training omegas with Izunavi is enough for Kurapika's body to escape on it's own. He grabs Tserracnich's thumb and uses it as leverage to wrench the man's hand off his face.

As he pries Tserracnich's hand open, Kurapika's lanyard falls back into his possession.

Before Tserracnich can bite him, Kurapika slips away. He dives behind the alpha and latches onto his back, locking his legs around Tserracnich's waist to keep him from turning on Kurapika. In the same instant, he wraps his lanyard around Tserracnich's neck to choke him.

Tserracnich's full weight falls back onto Kurapika, knocking the air out of his lungs, but Kurapika doesn't let up. The weight of the heavily-muscled alpha makes it hard to breathe, but Kurapika is doing everything he can to make damn sure that Tserracnich is in a much, much worse position.

The cord of the lanyard is too narrow for Tserracnich to get a hold on it as Kurapika pulls it into the column of his throat. Kurapika keeps his elbows tucked in close to his body, not giving Tserracnich one centimeter of leverage while Tserracnich thrashes on top of Kurapika. Tserracnich's struggle makes them slide across the tiles further under the sink. The back of Kurapika's head hits the plumbing but he barely feels it.

"… How could you," Kurapika whispers to the underside of the porcelain, hot, enraged tears stinging the corners of his eyes.

"How could you hurt so many people - so many children - and not care. And think you had a right. You think you had a right because… because *nothing.* Just shit you made up because you *wanted to*, you…"

It doesn't matter if Tserracnich understands what Kurapika is talking about. It doesn't matter what Tserracnich has to say for himself or if he's even able to listen. Let Tserracnich being the one spoken *at* rather than *to* for a change.

"I hate you, I hate you, I *hate* you…" Kurapika hisses out with every thin breath he manages to take while denying Tserracnich even one gasp.

Kurapika feels no pain in his fingers as the cord digs into them from his relentless, white-knuckle grip. Tserracnich's struggle weakens as he begins to lose consciousness.

Kurapika feels no satisfaction as Tserracnich goes still and his jaw stops trying to gulp down air. All Kurapika wants to do is wail out his agony and *cry*, but he can't. Kurapika can't cry or scream, or stop trying to pull the cord of his omega lanyard through this monstrous alpha's throat.

The bathroom door opens and Kurapika doesn't care to look to see who steps in. It doesn't even strike him as odd that they don't scream until a familiar pair of pale hands are dragging him out from under the sink by his shoulders.

"Kurapika," Chrollo's urgent voice finds it's way through the dull ringing in Kurapika's ears before he's able to focus on his face.

Somehow, Chrollo's managed to coax Kurapika into letting go of the cord and sitting upright. The yellow flashes in Kurapika's peripheral vision as Chrollo drapes it over his shoulders.

"Kurapika. You need to leave quickly, alright? You aren't feeling well." Chrollo whispers.

Kurapika looks from Chrollo's calm face to Tserracnich's body, then back to Chrollo. Chrollo is quickly unknotting the tie for his waistband and pulling the cord fully free from his pants. Kurapika watches, barely comprehending what Chrollo is doing as he matches it to the deep, red bruising around Tserracnich's neck.

"Good enough," Chrollo mutters then turns his gaze back to Kurapika.

Chrollo takes Kurapika's hands, cupping them as he's done so many times before. He gives them one grounding squeeze before opening Kurapika's hands to smear Tserracnich's blood over his knuckles. Looking up into Chrollo's eyes, Kurapika finds a familiar and comforting stillness.

"'So farewell hope, and with hope farewell fear'," Chrollo whispers.

Kurapika is able to recognize it's a quote from the text that he used send that first secret message to Chrollo's people, but Kurapika cannot parse the meaning.

"Now wash your hands and go home."

Wordlessly, Kurapika sways to his feet and rinses the remaining blood from his hands. He winces at the sound of a dull thud behind him as Chrollo strikes Tserracnich's motionless face, bloodying it further. Chrollo has plenty of good reason to take his own vengeance on Tserracnich, but seeing it doesn't stop the sense of vertigo any more than Kurapika's own revenge did.

The world is a blur. It's surreal to step out into the party, carrying on like nothing in the world has changed. Like what Kurapika just did doesn't matter. But he knows that this sense of limbo won't last.

Kurapika walks past the guard who's closest to the bathroom and he's wrapped up in conversation with Juno. That seems like something Chrollo would do - leaving the two of them distract each other when he realized that Kurapika was taking too long after Tserracnich followed him into the bathroom.

Kurapika makes his way to the doors that lead back into the hallway. He passes Kaiser who gives him a long look that makes Kurapika feel deeply unwell but he keeps walking. One of the guards stationed at the exit door is Babimyna.

Babimyna is surprised at the sudden approach and nearly stumbles back as Kurapika latches onto his arm.

"I… I'm not feeling well," Kurapika whispers to him. "I need to leave - please."

Kurapika isn't sure what he looks like, but he feels faint and disheveled. Judging from Babimyna's face, he doesn't look like himself at all.

"Of course. Let me…" Babimyna looks up at the second guard stationed at the door.

They exchange a nod and Babimyna quickly brings Kurapika out of the room. Kurapika clings to the support of Babimyna's arm as they walk, actually leaning into it. He's watching his feet at his walks and every step he takes feels too loud.

"You look... You're so pale," Babimyna says, shaken. "Let me take you to a doctor. We have one nearby…"

Kurapika shakes his head no.

"No, I just need to get out of here. I…" The yellow swaying from Kurapika's neck presents itself as a tool once more.

It says *"Caution. Be careful with me,"* it says *"I'm weak,"* it says *"Save me"*. It's a weapon and he'll try to use it one more time.

"I need to see a specialist. You don't have an omega care provider here, do you?"

Babimyna hesitates, then shakes his head. He's clearly uncertain, but he doesn't know any better and he's too good of a man to question an omega about their own needs.

"I don't think so. I'm sorry, I'll call you a cab while you go through the check-out." Babimyna says.

"Thank you," Kurapika allows the genuine relief to come through.

He passes through the security gate in a blur soon Babimyna is helping him into the back seat of a taxi.

It isn't until the taxi makes the turn onto Kurapika's street that he wonders what they're going to catch Chrollo doing to Tserracnich's body.

They're going to catch Chrollo.

Kurapika runs up to his apartment and dry-heaves into the toilet.

The next day, Kurapika is standing in his bathroom, staring at the developing bruises left on his jaw from Tserracnich's fingers when receives a call from the counselor's office. It's Eliza on the phone, telling him they'll have to cancel his upcoming appointments. She's doing her best to sound normal, but it's obviously a mask. He wants to hang up the phone, but that would be too strange.

"… Oh. Is everything okay?" Kurapika asks, almost robotically.

Kurapika wants to stop performing but if he does then Chrollo covering for him will be worthless. Despite their efforts, the authorities might still link him to Tserracnich's death. Still, he has has to try.

"Um, yeah. It's just…"

There are muffled voices of other people in the office speaking.

"I can't say. I'm sorry." Eliza says instead. "But we'll call you back to schedule another therapy session and talk more then. Okay?"

"Alright. I'll see you later," Kurapika says, knowing he is not going anywhere near that place again.

He hangs up the phone and steps away from the mirror.

The Paradise Lost quote Chrollo whispered to Kurapika lingers in the back of his mind. Maybe it was whatever passes for Chrollo’s strange style of comfort. But Kurapika thinks, hopes, that it was a final message. The reference clearly points to Chrollo’s gang who are intimately familiar with the text.

It's dangerous for Kurapika to seek them out for so many reasons. He doesn't have anything to offer them this time and he could be under more scrutiny than ever from the justice system. But they're also the ones who are the most likely to know what, if anything, Chrollo was trying to tell him.

That night, Kurapika decides to take the risk and return to 13th Street Printing Company. The alley is as silent as ever but when he knocks on the door, no one answers.

He knocks again and even tries speaking Chrollo's final words to him. He listens through the door and tries to peer through the windows, but there's nothing. Chrollo's gang have vanished like phantoms.

Turning away to go home, there's a familiar knot in his throat a heat behind his eyes. It swells with every step and he keeps trying to swallow it down with short, tight breaths. There's no reason for it - no reason at all.

Stop it.

Kurapika's vision blurs as he fumbles with his keys to get into his apartment. Mortifyingly, tears shake free from his lashes.

No matter how many times Kurapika wishes he didn't cry so easily, he sobs into his pillow until he falls asleep. He dreams of walking into his bathroom and finding Tserracnich's body sprawled across the floor, his empty eyes staring up at the yellow ceiling lights.

Kurapika is back to going through the motions at work. During his bathroom breaks he finds himself avoiding looking in the mirror and does his business as fast as possible. The bartender on his shift asks him about the bruises on his jaw but he brushes her off.

For once, he's glad Melody doesn't have a show with them tonight. He doesn't feel ready to accept her warmth.

Instead of thinking of himself, Kurapika thinks of Pario, running into the arms of his foster parents with dirt under his fingernails after spending half of recess digging for worms. Kurapika doesn't try to picture of Pario's smile often. Usually, all he can see is the boy's broken mouth through the wrinkles of a filthy plastic shopping bag. But Kurapika takes a deep breath and tries to remember him again. He really, really tries to simply remember Pario as he was.

His shift ends before the sun rises. Kurapika steps out into the dark and rainy early morning. Despite the exhaustion, Kurapika doesn't feel like going home alone. He steps into the convenience store near the bar, not his usual spot, and gets a large coffee at the self-service station. The transaction hardly takes more than a few minutes but all of the sit-down cafes are closed at this hour.

Walking through the rain with the burning hot cup in his cold fingers, Kurapika meanders down the sidewalk in the general direction of his apartment. Every step is stiff as he stares into the steam, thinking

of Chrollo's warm breath on his face. Chrollo likes rain and he likes coffee. Maybe he'd like to be walking with Kurapika now.

Chrollo didn't have to step in and cover for Kurapika at all. That was never in their deal and Kurapika… Kurapika knows that Chrollo had plans of his own. Kurapika wonders if those will still be possible now. He hadn't really let himself think about whether it would be right or wrong to aid Chrollo before. Now, all Kurapika can think about is Chrollo being tossed into one of those rut-isolation rooms for however long the prison wants with no one to advocate for him.

The streetlights dim as shadow of an umbrella looms over Kurapika's head. A figure with no scent has silently come to stand at his side. Kurapika tenses and turns slowly.

It's Kaiser, standing in a thick, black wool coat without a speck of rain on him and his hair perfectly combed.

Kurapika's heart pounds. There's no reason for Kaiser to approach him outside of a therapy session and they haven't scheduled one. Unless Kaiser was sent to him by the police as a means for luring him back in.

Kurapika may have utterly destroyed every ounce of good will Chrollo had in the prison, but he still won't give up easily.

"You were surprisingly impatient," Kaiser says.

Kurapika doesn't speak. Whatever Kaiser thinks, he might not have any real evidence yet. He's probably got a wire so Kurapika has to be careful not to say anything that gives him evidence.

"What?" Kurapika asks softly.

Kaiser blinks. He does not appear interested in Kurapika's attempt to play dumb.

"I can't promise I'll be able to protect you if they decide to take the investigation beyond Chrollo's confession. Do with that as you will - but please put in a good word for me with Ms. Melody anyway." Kaiser says.

With no further explanation, Kaiser turns away, taking his umbrella with him. Kurapika watches the sharp silhouette of Kaiser's frame walk across the street and turn out of view.

Melody had a contact inside the prison.

Kurapika stares at the lid of his coffee mug, dumbfounded by how much Kaiser just admitted.

The guy Melody was texting… Said she hadn't made up her mind about him…

Melody's contact always had to be someone with access to confidential records and some sway over the approval process. All the things Kaiser said and allowed - Kurapika had assumed they were being done to unfairly benefit a rich, horrible man. Of course, those choices benefited Kurapika too, but he didn't expect Kaiser to know that.

And what Melody had said about the guy she was testing…

Kurapika's mug slips from his fingers and drops to the sidewalk, spilling coffee and steam into the rain.

Against his will, Kurapika is forced to imagine Kaiser's face next to Chrollo’s in the corner of his bedroom, the two of them watching Kurapika and Melody in bed. A pair dead-faced men with completely black eyes, barely blinking.

No. Absolutely not. Not even in twenty-something years!

Kurapika buries his face in his hands. He wants to berate Melody for her taste in men, but he can't. Kurapika’s in a glass house and Melody could easily hit a high note that shatters it.

Another two days of tense monotony pass and Kurapika isn't sure what to do with himself. It feels like he should move on, maybe skip town and use that as a catalyst to move on. But he isn't sure how to want to keep going forward without a long-term goal and the weight of what he's done makes him feel even slower.

He teaches another self-defense class but Izunavi can tell that Kurapika's missing his usual edge. What's worse are the bruises on Kurapika's face have only manged to fade to a pale yellow. He has to fight off concerned looks all evening and Izunavi even tried to grill him after class.

Kurapika manages to escape the questioning and slip off into the night. He can't give Izunavi part of the truth without causing more questions. He returns to his dark apartment with his shoulders even heavier. Hanging his head, Kurapika toes off his shoes and tosses his coat into the closet carelessly.

The moment Kurapika steps off the doormat, he can feel the energy in the room isn't right.

He head snaps up to find a dark figure standing in the middle of the room, silhouetted by the streetlights seeping through his curtains.

Kurapika gasps and instinctively throws himself back into the door, his heart hammering in his chest. In moments, his eyes adjust to the low light well enough to make sense of the figure and his panic subsides enough for him the recognize the pheromones hanging in the air. The clothes he's wearing change the shape of him, but there's no mistaking it. Chrollo is standing in his apartment.

Kurapika feels like a fool for not thinking of how easy it would have been for a member of Chrollo's gang to follow him home after any one of their meetings. *Of course* they know where he lives.

But after what happened with Tserracnich, Kurapika wasn't sure that Chrollo had gotten enough out of their deal to actually escape. So soon, too.

Kurapika should be afraid that Chrollo tracked him down and he should be furious that Chrollo broke in.

It's not romantic. It's *not.* Chrollo is obviously sick for breaking into his home.

Through the dense shadows between them, Kurapika can feels Chrollo’s dark eyes are meeting his. All of the tension Kurapika has been carrying melts out of him. He rushes forward, throwing himself at Chrollo, and wrapping his arms around his neck. Chrollo is wearing a long, black coat that obscures most of his body and a pair of blue earrings that distort the dim light like the glass of a fishbowl.

"I missed you too," Chrollo says softly, returning the hug,

It's the first time Chrollo is able to touch him without handcuffs on. He spreads his hands out to hold Kurapika securely, one hand in his hair and the other pressed to the middle of his back.

"I should have thanked you," Kurapika says into Chrollo's chest.

"There's no need. You gave me everything I needed to reunite with my family, there's nothing I value more than that. And, as your partner, making sure you could get home was the least I could do." Chrollo says simply.

For a moment, Kurapika just squeezes him tight. Finally he doesn't feel so alone with his choices. Kurapika pulls back enough to look up at Chrollo's face.

"What are you going to do now?" Kurapika asks.

Chrollo doesn't seem to be in too much of a rush so the cops can't be just around the corner. But they must be on the hunt.

"My family and I have to leave Yorknew." Chrollo replies.

Kurapika nods. He expected something like that.

"Where are you going?"

"I can't tell you unless you come with us."

Kurapika's breath hitches. He finds nothing but sincerity in Chrollo's steady tone.

"We're leaving tonight." Chrollo continues. "Sorry to rush your decision, but we don't have much time. If you say no, I'll let you go and you can put all of this behind you."

Kurapika closes his eyes, taking a deep breath to try and clear his head to be reasonable. There is catharsis in knowing that Chrollo is doing well and doesn't blame him. Maybe he could move forward a bit more with that assurance.

He doesn't know if he is under any serious scrutiny since Chrollo was caught red-handed, apparently confessed as a bonus, and is now on the run. Still, even if Kurapika never becomes a suspect, they're going to want to question him on the basis of his close relationship with Chrollo alone.

When Kurapika first resolved himself to seeking revenge, he had assumed that being caught was inevitable. With how things turned out, he could try getting away with it. But before Kurapika decides to try getting away with Chrollo's help, he has another question.

"Who's your family? The Spiders?" Kurapika deserves to know if Chrollo expects him to even consider this proposal.

Chrollo's lips curl into a little smile.

"… You caught me."

It's just as Kurapika suspected. A few weeks ago, that answer would have been frightening. Now it's another weight off his shoulders to know he wasn't just being paranoid.

The Spiders are a dangerous group and probably even more capable than the rumors suggested with how they've managed to free Chrollo. However, staying alone, either in his life as it is now or running away by himself, would mean being alone with his memories of death and his lingering feelings for Chrollo.

He fists Chrollo’s coat and grits his teeth. Kurapika is used to thinking himself in circles, but what he really wants to do is to answer from him worn, frayed heart.

"Do not hide important things like that from me again."

Chrollo brings Kurapika to the window and points to the convenience store across the street. A van is parked and there's the silhouette of a large man leaning against it. It's the sort of sight that would activate any omega's fight or flight response.

"You have my word. Come with me and I will treat you like family."

Chapter 13

Chrollo did not kidnap Kurapika. He asked Kurapika, very politely, to abandon his current life and get into the an unmarked van in the dead of night.

The day that bank heist took a turn for the worst, Chrollo’s first priority became making sure no one else went down with him. The authorities found his tattoo, but they couldn't pin him as the leader and they couldn't get him to talk.

When he discovered he had been sentenced to the same prison that was holding Tserracnich he spent quite some time seriously considering what he could do to make the man pay. Unfortunately, as a high-profile criminal, Tserracnich was closely guarded. Without getting some serious help from a few key guards, Chrollo couldn't think of a plan that was more than fifty percent likely to get the job done.

And he had *a lot* of time to think about it.

Laying low and wielding what power he could find among the alphas had to take priority. After all, Tserracnich's exploitation ring extended past the man himself. Killing him would have been satisfying, but for Chrollo, getting back to his Spiders mattered more than anything else. During long nights, Chrollo thought about each member carefully. He made himself imagine every detail he could and went over the reasons they would be okay without him. It was lonely to imagine the Spiders without picturing himself by their side, but it also brought him peace as he drifted into dreamless sleep. He missed his family every day. It was hard knowing they could never visit, but Chrollo would have been more upset if they tried.

The announcement of the Omega Therapy Program accepting applicants was a wild day. The list of perks was long and the list of perks the inmates imagined they could get because of how special they thought they were was even longer. Alphas were drooling onto the pages of their application forms. When the counselors for the program left, the alphas spun fantasies to each other. Pheromones clogged the cellblock as they imagined a flock of pristine little omegas for them to choose from - like picking out a well-bred and trained service animal. Chrollo's cellmate was particularly excited to get his hands on some innocent, barely-legal little thing so he would have someone waiting for him after the remaining three years of his sentence was up. It was knot-headed fantasy since they were told that the omegas would be volunteers from all paths in life and must be over twenty years old. The omegas would have established lives and personalities that wouldn't have anything to do with some random, alpha convict.

The self-selecting pool of personalities for who would volunteer for such a program did intrigue Chrollo, but there was only one opportunity he really cared about. A window to the world outside.

At first, that window was only big enough for a single hand to pass through. And what a lovely hand it was. They had elegant fingers with a small burn scar on the back of a ring finger that looked like it was from a minor accident in the kitchen. The scent on their wrist was refreshing too. It was sweet, vibrant, and clear. Chrollo had enjoyed the fragrance of many omegas in the past but none had made him feel so alive and *present* in his body before. At first, Chrollo had assumed it was just a psychological quirk. After all, he had been drowning in alphas since his arrest.

But after he chose Kurapika to be his therapy omega, everything started falling into place.

Blonde hair shining like gold, cat-like eyes, and a frown that looked like it was moments from cussing Chrollo out. It was obvious that Kurapika had never spent a day in therapy in his life and wasn't anywhere near qualified to provide it. Maybe if Chrollo had done anything to earn Kurapika's ire, screaming in his face could have been a therapeutic moment for both of them. At the very least, Chrollo thinks he would have enjoyed getting berated by an omega with such an angelic face. Except the guards would have rushed in to separate them, so Chrollo didn't try to piss Kurapika off too much.

Beyond Kurapika's beauty, his intellect and willingness to work with Chrollo were ideal. There was no need to trick him into anything. He knowingly gave Chrollo a way to connect with his family again and even wanted to kill the same man Chrollo did. It was like the universe crafted Kurapika just for him and fate placed him right in Chrollo’s lap. It was almost too good to be true, but Chrollo was never one to miss a golden opportunity, and Kurapika might as well have been made of gold.

Then, Chrollo began to dream of seeing his family again and Kurapika was there too. Chrollo didn't always see him in the dreams, but he always felt the young man was there. Like his scent clung to the back of Chrollo’s throat.

Kurapika losing his cool and killing Tserracnich on the bathroom floor in the middle of the ice-cream social was not part of the plan. But plans change all the time and having a bit of righteous spice was one of the things Chrollo liked about Kurapika. He would never be angry with his perfect omega for having a little murderous rage.

Chrollo is not kidnapping Kurapika. But Kurapika looks *so cute* stuffed into the back of the van and hidden under blankets. It makes Chrollo's heart race as though he's doing something as vile as stealing an angel from heaven, but this angel came of his own accord - hands dirty.

They cross Yorknew City's district lines and Kurapika comes out of hiding in time to see the sun rise. His hair is a tangled mess and he clutches the small bag he packed to his chest as he watches the tallest buildings in Yorknew shrink. They're headed north.

There is no need for confessions between them just as there is no need for any member of Chrollo's family to exchange declarations of loyalty. Everything Chrollo needs to be fulfilled is in their actions. There's familiarity when Kurapika splits a cup of coffee with him at a rest-stop. It feels right to watch Kurapika turn his back to him to chat with Pakunoda and Franklin as they discuss the alternate routes the Spiders are taking to the base Shalnark found for them. Then, they cross the border into southern Schmattes and stop in a creaky motel. The space Kurapika leaves for Chrollo on the bed is thoughtful and they lay on top of the stiff bedding, keeping each other warm under Chrollo's trench coat. Kurapika

presses his chest to Chrollo’s back and hooks his chin over Chrollo’s shoulder. Between blinks of sleep, Kurapika whispers about his nightmares, and Chrollo can feel that Kurapika loves him.

Killing had hurt Kurapika more than it hurt Chrollo and it didn't fix anything. Even so, Chrollo wouldn't have done things any differently. It was important to Kurapika that he be the one to end Tserracnich's life. Although doing so brought him pain, Chrollo is happy for Kurapika and proud to have helped him. He has no regrets.

During the final leg of their journey, Kurapika quietly tells Chrollo he needs to be able to send a message to someone back in Yorknew. Kurapika never mentioned having any family and the Spiders told Chrollo that aside from visiting the prison Kurapika lived alone, worked long hours, and only taught those self-defense classes.

"I just want her to know I'm alright," Kurapika explains.

"We can make that work. Who would you like to send a message to?" Chrollo asks.

His choice to take Kurapika away was a practical one but as long as Kurapika's message doesn't endanger his Spiders he would be a hypocrite to refuse.

Kurapika hesitates before answering. Being cagey is a deep habit of his.

"… Her name is Melody. She's my best friend and helped me get into the therapy program. She had a contact in the prison."

Chrollo hums and nods. That does explain why Kurapika knew Tserracnich got approved to be in the program before Chrollo did, among other things.

"Sounds like a good friend. Give me your message and tell us more about her so we can deliver it."

Kurapika nods and scrawls something in the little notebook he brought then tears out the page. Chrollo accepts it and takes a glance at Kurapika's handwriting. It's very neat - crafted to be easy for children to read. Skimming the words confirms that there isn't anything too revealing but a word at the bottom catches his attention. It says *'harmony'* with no apparent context.

"What's this for?" Chrollo asks curiously, pointing it out.

"That, ah, it's a… code word," Kurapika explains, pink dusting the tips of his ears. "It's just to signal to her that I wrote this of my own accord so she knows everything really is okay."

"Ah," Chrollo folds the paper neatly.

It is clever, since Chrollo couldn't have known to compel Kurapika to do that. He's heard Machi mention that lots of omegas set up code words with their friends or family for when they go on dates and such. It reminds him of a safe word and Kurapika's faint blush makes him suspect it could be that too.

"The word *'hymn'* would be better for the two of us, don't you think?"

Kurapika scowls at Chrollo. Franklin and Pakunoda don't react.

They arrive at the little place Shalnark rented. All of the buildings in Schmattes are pale, rickety, and unassuming. According to Shalnark, the house is owned by an elderly man who's wife passed not long ago. It's too much space for him and he was more than happy to rent the place old-school style. As in, off

the record without the hassle of background checks, proof of income, and such. The only thing between them and this old man will be cash.

The house is tucked between naked trees near a drainage basin that smells of brine. They pull into the gravel driveway where a sedan with some Spiders is already waiting for them: Bonolenov, Shizuku, and Nobunaga. They greet each other then Franklin and Nobunaga start unloading the cars while Chrollo and the remaining Spiders exchange the latest updates from the members who are still on the road. Then, Chrollo tells his group about Kurapika's message.

"So, where will we be able to find your friend?" Chrollo asks.

"She's a singer at the bar I worked in, but lately she's been getting booked at restaurants in upper Yorknew." Kurapika says. He tells the group her name and describes her a bit further.

Chrollo is surprised to see Bonolenov perk up at the description. He's normally a quiet man who keeps to himself - a beta with dark skin, lots of piercings, and eye-catching cheek gauges. He has several unexpected and useful skills.

"I've seen Melody perform at a festival in the Yorknew City Square before. She's got some recognition in the indie music scene," Bonolenov explains. "I know some people in her orbit so I could send this her way without getting too close."

"Perfect," Chrollo hands him the message to take care of. If Bonolenov says he can do it, it's as good as done.

They move into the house, dividing up the space for work and living. To claim his room, Kurapika mounts the wrinkled painting Chrollo made for him on the wall. Kurapika is so insistent that it's good it's a bit embarrassing. Especially when Chrollo has no talent for visual art at all. Chrollo thinks that Kurapika is treating him a bit like a child for it, but he likes that too.

On their first night together in their new home Chrollo shows Kurapika the massive spider tattoo on his back and Kurapika traces it's spindly legs and jagged webbing.

The house isn't big enough for fourteen people to stay in comfortably, but it'll work for a while. Some of the Spiders make their own arrangements to move into other places nearby but with this as their base the house is always lively.

They lay low for a a time while plotting smaller schemes to keep the cash flowing. Chrollo doesn't expect Kurapika to be heavily involved in this aspect of his life since he isn't a very experienced criminal. Mostly, Kurapika stays on the fringes of the group. Occasionally, he'll interject with something interesting, so Chrollo knows he's always listening.

Chrollo promised to treat Kurapika like family and all members of Chrollo’s family get to speak. It only takes a few words here and there for the Spiders to know that Kurapika is worth hearing out.

What Chrollo *really* doesn't expect is to find Kurapika sitting at the kitchen table with Franklin one dreary Monday morning, helping him clean his guns in total silence. Later, when Chrollo asks Franklin about it, he tells Chrollo that he didn't teach Kurapika how to do any of that. There's still so much more Chrollo has to learn about his little omega.

Before getting Kurapika as a partner, Chrollo never considered himself the romantic type. Now, he's certain that no one is more perfectly suited to being his partner. As Kurapika takes up more space in

Chrollo’s life, the better he seems to fit into it. It's as though that space was always supposed to be Kurapika’s anyway. So there's no reason for Chrollo to think twice about giving him more.

Soon, it's safe enough for Chrollo to take Kurapika out on a date to an art house in the city of Bosons where his beloved friend, the illustrious Ms. Melody, is performing. She's a very short woman with heavy curves, part of her head shaved, and a voice like a flute. Her show is an experimental and mesmerizing set that involves a big, empty dumpster that was wheeled into the center of the room. It's a very evocative performance and the perfect opportunity for a few of his Spiders to investigate the owner of the art house as a potential target for their next job.

Chrollo can tell Ms. Melody is a good friend because the only reason she would book a show this far north would be to check on Kurapika. After the show, Chrollo proudly presents Kurapika to Ms. Melody, proving that her friend is safe and healthy. Chrollo gives them space so they can catch up without him looming over their shoulders.

While he indulges in the complimentary wine and observes Schmattes' old money, he keeps one eye on how Kurapika interacts with Ms. Melody. He can't hear what they're saying, but watching them for a few moments is all it takes for Chrollo to be sure that she was a heat partner of his. While Chrollo isn't looking to share his treasure, Ms. Melody is unique a gem herself. If Kurapika wanted to be with her again Chrollo thinks they could work something out, but he has no plans to bring it up first.

"I should put you back in cuffs."

Kurapika mutters, pushing his hands into Chrollo’s snow-damp jacket to get closer to his skin.

They've been living here safely for a while so it was only a matter of time before Kurapika's heat started. Chrollo didn't mean to be out so late, but he's glad he took the time to tie up all the loose ends for a smuggling job. Now they won't be bothered.

Kurapika shudders as Chrollo’s pheromones waft out of his clothes, mixing with the scent of winter. Chrollo slips off his leather glove to bury his bare hand in Kurapika’s hair. His fingers are cold while Kurapika is radiating with heat that makes Chrollo’s skin tingle.

"Only if you collar me too." Chrollo replies with a tender smile.

Kurapika pushes the jacket off Chrollo’s shoulders and buries his face into his chest. He presses his nose into the cotton and takes deep, shaky breaths. Watching Kurapika huff his scent makes Chrollo’s vision narrow down only to him. Chrollo stays completely still, hardly blinking or breathing because of his dedication to committing this moment to his long-term memory.

"Take this off. Give it to me. Now." Kurapika demands.

"Don't you want me to come with it?"

Kurapika huffs and shoves Chrollo’s shirt up to his armpits, his face in Chrollo pecs.

"Okay, I'm sorry I took so long. I would never want to be late for…" Chrollo says, taking Kurapika's elbows to steers them to the bedroom they claimed.

The floors creaking with every step. As soon as they pass through the doorway Kurapika’s dragging Chrollo’s shirt up over his chin. Chrollo’s head pops free and that's when he finally takes in the state of

the bed. His lips part but he's silent for a moment, processing and gathering his thoughts.

"… You're nesting…" Chrollo says as Kurapika unbuckles his belt.

While they were on the road, Kurapika told Chrollo that there was no need to accommodate for nesting because he doesn't nest. Now there's a mound of Chrollo’s clothes, pillows, and blankets piled on the bed. It's an endearing, lumpy thing that looks every bit as amateur and sincere as the painting Chrollo made. He loves it.

Kurapika is far enough into preheat that he doesn't even care to respond to Chrollo, rubbing the stolen shirt against his face and neck like a cat. His scent is getting sweeter by the second. Thoughtlessly, Chrollo runs his tongue over the edges of his fangs as he feels a rush of desire.

"… Please tell me I'm allowed in there too." Chrollo asks, suddenly dazed by how eager he feels.

Kurapika holds Chrollo’s shirt in his mouth so he can shove down Chrollo’s jeans with both hands, revealing the steadily growing bulge in his underwear. The second Chrollo steps out of his pants, Kurapika drags him into the nest and starts shuffling material to accommodate the new shirt and Chrollo.

"It's my heat but you sound slower than me." Kurapika says.

"Sorry," Chrollo lays down and stares up at the ceiling. He takes slow, deep breaths. "I'm just excited. I like this."

The last time he smelled Kurapika's heat, it was faintly clinging to a piece of fabric. Even light traces of it was enough to make Chrollo salivate. He remembers the way Kurapika teased him with it and looked down on him. How he denied Chrollo a simple kiss but casually spit in his mouth.

"You better," Kurapika grumbles.

Kurapika swings one leg over Chrollo’s hips to straddle him. Dressed in nothing but Chrollo’s shirt, the material pools around Kurapika’s hips, barely giving Chrollo a peak between his legs. Kurapika's slick dampens Chrollo's boxers over his erection and he moves in slow circles, grinding for satiating friction.

Kurapika's heat smells sweet and inviting but there's nothing docile about it.

Slowly, Kurapika strips off that final piece of clothing. Chrollo follows the motion with anticipation, greedily taking in Kurapika's stomach, his soft chest, and his armpits - Chrollo wants to kiss everything. Drool pools under his tongue as he runs his hands up Kurapika's thighs and stomach. As his hands creep up to Kurapika's chest, he abruptly smacks them away.

Before Chrollo can ask, Kurapika crawls up his body. That's all the explanation he needs. Chrollo’s tongue feels heavy in his mouth, his breath hitches, and his heart pounds as Kurapika straddles his head. For just a second, Chrollo gets a perfect view of Kurapika's flushed pussy with slick clinging to the thatch of blond hair. Chrollo doesn't get to look for very long before Kurapika sits on his face.

Hot, tender skin and syrupy slick flood Chrollo’s senses. The weight of Kurapika's heat is a soothing pressure on Chrollo’s mind. Through the wet sounds of Kurapika grinding on his mouth he listens for the soft, high breathy moans that Kurapika lets out.

In moments, Kurapika's scent has developed into full heat. Fresh slick flows into Chrollo mouth and is smeared from his chin to his nose. It mixes with Chrollo's drool and drips down the sides of his face, but he isn't wasting it due to a lack of trying. Chrollo wraps his hands around Kurapika's waist to keep him

steady. Surrendering to his pleasure, Chrollo does what he can to lap at Kurapika's soaking folds. He tries over and over again to suck on Kurapika's clit but the constant movement of his impatient hips keeps him from latching on for more than half a second. He just has to try again.

"Fuck, *fuck*…" Kurapika hisses, yanking on Chrollo's hair as his thighs tremble around his cheeks. "I am taking your knot this time… You b-bastard."

Chrollo wouldn't have guessed that would be the first thing Kurapika decided to cuss him out over.

Muscles harden and clench around Chrollo's head, covering his ears so he can barely hear Kurapika's fragmented moans. Beneath his hands, Chrollo can feel Kurapika's abdomen flex as he cums. He bares more weight down on Chrollo as he fucks his face through his orgasm, squirting into his mouth. Chrollo's throat bobs as it works to swallow as much as possible. Drunk on slick and light-headed from lack of oxygen, Chrollo barely feels like a person. With his nose buried in Kurapika's hair, it feels like every breath he can manage is just another way to fill himself up with his omega.

Kurapika goes still so Chrollo can *finally* thrust his tongue into his soft cunt. He presses it against the spongy top, licking as deep as he can get. His pussy clenches and just as Chrollo's fingers are sinking into Kurapika's stomach, he pulls away.

A deep, reflexive inhale shudders through Chrollo's chest but it does nothing to cool the smoldering heat inside. He props himself up on his elbows with a groan to keep his eyes on Kurapika as he backs away. There's a pretty flush that's spread down to Kurapika's chest and his eyes are blown wide. It's like his body is inviting Chrollo to chase it.

"Your scent is different," Kurapika says softly, tilting his head.

"Ah?"

Chrollo licks his lips clean, in too much of a haze to get what Kurapika is saying. Pretty hands land on Chrollo's chest and Kurapika leans in.

"I think… we're syncing up." Kurapika mutters.

His breath spills over Chrollo's neck, taking in his scent. Last Chrollo knew, Kurapika's heat was just a little over week apart from his rut. Since then, they've hooked up and gotten closer than ever, so their cycles were always going match up eventually. Seems eventually is today. Of course drowning between Kurapika's thighs would be what snaps Chrollo's rut into place.

A small, wet tongue presses to Chrollo's scent gland and his whole body throbs in response. Kurapika's never *licked* him before. Splayed hands roam over Chrollo's chest, squeezing it then trailing down his abs to the waistband of his strained boxers. Back in prison, Chrollo already thought that Kurapika was unusually bold for an omega. Heat has only enhanced Kurapika's direct approach as he sucks on Chrollo's racing pulse and shoves his hands into Chrollo's underwear.

Chrollo's throat rumbles with a groan and he helps Kurapika finish stripping him. The elastic catches on the damp, swollen head of his cock before it springs out to smear precum against Kurapika's stomach.

He buries his hands in Kurapika's hair to scent mark him. At the same time, a pair of hands wraps around his shaft to stroke his length. Chrollo can feel every centimeter of Kurapika's fingers and palms dragging against his skin. The friction is almost too much. He hisses and his hips flex, lifting his omega a bit.

"Kurapika, come on…" Chrollo urges him with a gentle tug on his hair. "You want my knot, don't you?"

Chrollo won't tell his omega to stop touching him a particular way. He only wants Kurapika to consider what they could be doing instead.

Little fangs scrape against Chrollo's mating gland without sinking in, making Chrollo's heart ache. He doesn't know how long it's appropriate to wait before asking… but it took a lot of self-control not to pounce on Kurapika when he was trapped in the back of the van.

A damp patch is left to cool on Chrollo’s throat as Kurapika gets into a better position. Despite Chrollo’s hands being free, Kurapika takes the lead again. Straddling Chrollo’s thighs, he guides the tip to his entrance, letting Chrollo touch Kurapika's flushed shoulders and chest all he likes.

Kurapika’s heat has him melting down Chrollo’s length as he takes him. It's a slow stretch that has Kurapika's head falling back with a shameless moan. Chrollo’s eyelids droop as the ache in his gut is appeased by Kurapika’s weight settling into his lap, but he keeps his eyes open. He doesn't want to miss out on such a beautiful sight.

Kurapika leans back to brace his hands on Chrollo’s thighs rocks against him slowly. As Kurapika moves, his muscles tighten and relax, making even a little motion pleasurable for Chrollo. When he was in prison, being in rut came with a sickening sensation of desperation. Although he was happy to sneak even the tiniest piece of Kurapika into the isolation room, deep inside Chrollo only felt worse by having it. He could cum faster and more easily but each time ended in his eyes darting around the empty room as adrenaline surged through him with the need to look for a person he knew couldn't be there. With Kurapika centered in his vision and the scent of his nest surrounding them Chrollo feels at ease through the waves of arousal.

Soon, Kurapika works himself up to riding him. Chrollo puts his hands to good use by helping him move and he can't choose between watching Kurapika's blond hair sway against his red cheeks, his tiny tits bounce, or the pussy milking his cock.

The harder Kurapika works, the tighter he gets. Every time he lifts himself up, his body clings to Chrollo's length like it's trying to suck him back inside. When he lands heavily in Chrollo’s lap, his cunt gushes and his cute toes curl into the bedding. The deep strokes make him relax and in seconds Kurapika’s mewling sweetly.

The base of Chrollo's length swells and starts to catch on the sopping wet folds, threatening to give Kurapika the knot he demanded. Moans wrack Chrollo's heaving chest and he grits his teeth through them, fighting the urge to growl at Kurapika like a mindless animal. But maybe Kurapika would like that. Or, even better, he wouldn't and he would try to put Chrollo in his place for it.

The growing knot catches and Chrollo cums with a guttural sound, his fingers sinking into Kurapika's hips. His forearms flex with the strain of molten pleasure and his hips lift in sync with every pulse of cum that paints Kurapika's insides. The moment that Kurapika's locked into place, he gasps sharply and pitches forward as he's thrown into his orgasm. Trembling knees curl in as he squirts on Chrollo's knot, soaking them with way more satisfaction than he had in prison.

"Ah… that's…"

Kurapika places his hands over his stomach and hangs his head. His eyes slip shut and he just breathes for a few moments. Chrollo takes hold of Kurapika’s hips to keep him supported.

"… I've never been in heat with an alpha before," Kurapika confesses softly.

"Yeah?" As always, unless he's acting Chrollo’s tone fails to convey how pleased he is. He thumbs over Kurapika’s hips idly.

As Kurapika catches his breath, he melts into purrs, blissed-out as Chrollo's knot continues to fill him. Chrollo reaches up to take hold of Kurapika's shoulders, coaxing him into laying on his chest. In return, Kurapika embraces him, rubbing his wrists and neck over Chrollo as if he's not coated in enough of the omega's scent.

Chrollo keeps his arms around Kurapika tight so he won't pull on the knot locking them together too much as he rolls to switch their positions, pressing Kurapika into the nest under him. His rut was satiated before it had even begun to bother him, but Chrollo knows it won't be long until they're pawing at each other for another round. Until then, Chrollo thinks that they haven't been kissing enough, so he's going to fix that.

He catches Kurapika's roaming hands to kiss them then takes his lips. The way he kisses Chrollo back feels like enough of a love confession for the both of them. Kurapika's mouth is pliant and gentle and Chrollo is only willing to leave it to make sure he shows enough love to the rest of his omega's body. Chrollo trails kisses down Kurapika's neck to his chest. As he goes lower, he pushes Kurapika's arms up above his head into the clumsy nest. Chrollo's lips brush over perky nipples as he kisses across one breast to finally get his face into Kurapika's armpit.

Kurapika jolts but Chrollo holds his arms in place.

"*What* are you - ?"

Chrollo shushes him and nuzzles into the warm, delicate skin and hair.

"Just relax - you smell so good and you know I love every part of you... There's no rush this time so I'm not skipping one bit. I mean it."

Kurapika huffs but his arms relax.

"I shouldn't be surprised… Of course you'd wait for me to be stuck with you to start being weird." Kurapika grumbles.

Chrollo laughs and goes back to kissing Kurapika's chest. He wants Kurapika to be stuck with him in every way possible.

"I don't believe you're only now finding me weird." Chrollo replies.

Kurapika wraps his legs around Chrollo's waist and locks his ankles together at the small of his back to keep their hips pressed together firmly.

"… Fine. Just make good on your word."

"For you - always."

Chrollo never expected to get his hands on such a gorgeous, volatile omega while he was locked up. Now that Kurapika's killed Tserracnich, perhaps Chrollo could convince him that having a baby should be their next step on their therapeutic journey. Chrollo loves being part of a big family and he knows that Kurapika loves kids.